



Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Panel backs law for DGCA facelift with safety in focus

Neha LM Tripathi

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's aviation regulator should be replaced by an independent authority, created by a new law and with its own money and its own hiring, according to a proposal submitted to the government. The regulator has nearly half its posts vacant, a parliamentary panel has faulted it for "systemic" safety failures, and critics have accused it of bending its own rules last year during the IndiGo operational meltdown.

The report, submitted to the ministry of civil aviation (MoCA) and seen by HT, recommends replacing the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) with a statutory Civil Aviation Authority of India (CAA).

The new body would have a governing board, a dedicated aviation safety fund and control over recruitment, pay and spending. Part of the cost would fall on passengers, through a levy on every departure that a study cited in the report puts at ₹15, the proposal states.

The report is by a special committee headed by former economic advisor Lalit Kumar

What the panel proposes

A new regulator
● DGCA be converted into a statutory Civil Aviation Authority of India, created by an act of Parliament
● Board headed by DG (civil aviation): Whole-time members from the DGCA, part-time from the industry

Passenger grievances

An independent ombudsman for cancellations, delays and lost luggage

Funding

- An Aviation Safety Fund, also fed by fees and penalties, to pay for staff and oversight
- Audited every year by the CAG

A charge on flyers

A levy on every departing passenger; the report backs ₹15, from a ministry study, with the board setting the final rate

NEXT STEPS

Recommendations only; a law must be drafted and passed first

Stopgap measures for the DGCA until then

Chandel and with all joint directors general as the other members. It was constituted in August 2025; it submitted its report in November.

The committee wants it set up "as a statutory body with adequate administrative and financial autonomy through legislation". "Accordingly, a bill

for introduction in the Parliament to be prepared in consultation with the ministry of law & justice," the report said.

A person aware of the matter said the report is now with the ministry and some discussions have been held over it.

"The restructuring of the DGCA into an autonomous

authority will strengthen regulatory capacity, close safety gaps, and secure India's position as a global aviation leader. Immediate short-term reforms -- recruitment, digital upgrades, stakeholder engagement -- and longer-term legislative measures should be mapped and tracked with a clear implementation timeline. Periodic assessments based on international best practices and statutory review will ensure continued effectiveness and institutional growth," the official told HT, asking not to be named.

A second official said the report followed a direction from the ministry's top bureaucrat. "The report was made after the secretary (of MoCA) ordered to come up with a short / mid- and long-term restructuring plan considering the present and future development of aviation in the country," the official said.

The committee's diagnosis is blunt. As an attached office of MoCA, the report says, DGCA has limited operational independence, and its dependence on budgetary allocations can hold back recruitment of specialised talent and investment in technology.

continued on →T1

'Averted a 9/11-style tragedy': Modi lauds Capt Machchhar

HT Correspondent and Agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/MUMBAI: Smit Machchhar, the Indian captain allegedly stabbed by his co-pilot on a flydubai flight to Tel Aviv, was moved from Saudi Arabia to a hospital in the United Arab Emirates on Thursday, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he had averted a "9/11-style tragedy" and leaders in India and Israel praised his courage.

Machchhar, 40, who was seriously wounded in Wednesday's attack, is "in good health and recovering well," India's ambassador to the UAE, Deepak Mittal, said after visiting him and his family in hospital.

"Very reassured to meet Capt Smit. Thank the UAE govern-

Machchhar taken to Abu Dhabi

Capt Smit Machchhar airlifted to Abu Dhabi after initial treatment in Saudi

His condition is stable, according to India's ambassador to UAE who met the Indian national and his family

"He was talking, smiling and laughing, which was a huge relief for us..."

— DEEPAK MITTAL, India's ambassador to UAE



PTI

ment for their support and medical care being extended," Mittal said in a post on X.

Despite his wounds, Machchhar unlocked the cockpit door of flight FZ-1073, allowing passengers and crew to overpower the attacker. A reserve

crew on board then flew the Boeing 737 MAX 8, carrying 174 people, to an emergency landing at Tabuk in north-western Saudi Arabia.

continued on →T1
→GOVT TO DELIBERATE ADVISORY FOR AIRLINES AFTER ATTACK ON PILOT P2

CHEMBUR LOCALS CELEBRATE PILOT, SEEKS CIVIL HONOUR

Residents of Swastik Heights at Chembur gathered in large numbers in the building compound on Thursday to raise a cheer for Captain Smit Machchhar and demand that the government bestow a civil honour on him. "We are so proud that Smit saved so many lives," said his uncle Kishor Machchhar. Smit Machchhar, originally from Rajkot, grew up in the predominantly Gujarati middle class neighbourhood of Ghatkopar East where the family runs a printing press business. He completed his flying course from New Zealand and joined SpiceJet where he worked for 11 years. The pilot moved to Dubai in 2022 to work for flydubai.

→P3

SC: Freeze car services over traffic fines

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed states and Union territories (UTs) to freeze online and other vehicle-related services, including renewal of registration, issuance of fitness and

pollution-under-control certificates, ownership transfers and even renewal of driving licences, where traffic fines remain unpaid, as part of a nationwide push to make electronic enforcement of road-safety laws more effective.

A bench of Justices JB Pardi-

wala and KV Viswanathan also directed that vehicles with outstanding e-challans be blacklisted on the central Parivahan portal, blocking their sale or transfer, while no centre should be permitted to issue a PUC certificate until pending traffic fines are cleared. In cases involving multi-

ple violations, authorities have been told to suspend renewal of the driving licence and take steps to suspend an existing licence.

The bench said merely issuing thousands or lakhs of e-challans served little purpose unless authorities were able to recover the fines.

→P9

S.I.T. TO PROBE SHIV SENA (UBT) LEADER'S MURDER

Kaptaan Mali and Saurabha Kulshreshtha

letters@hindustantimes.com

THANE: The Thane police have formed a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the murder of Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Pradeep Purnekar, while six people, including two women, have been detained for questioning, police said.

The SIT will be headed by Deputy Commissioner of Police Amarsinh Jadhav and comprise two assistant commissioners of police, an inspector and a sub-inspector. Thane police commissioner Ashutosh Dumbare said.

Police also questioned Shiv Sena corporator and former Thane mayor Meenakshi Shinde and her husband, Rajendra Shinde, on Thursday after Purnekar's son, Ram, alleged that they were behind his father's murder due to political rivalry.

Meenakshi denied the allegations, saying she was not in the city and had neither been contacted by police nor received any notice to record her statement. She termed the allegations "baseless".

→P6

SC declines ONOE panel's informal interaction invite

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court administration on Thursday declined a proposal from a parliamentary panel, examining bills aimed at rolling out simultaneous elections, to interact with Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and other sitting judges, with the court's secretary general informing the committee that the proposed constitutional amendments could eventually be subject to judicial review.

People aware of the matter said that the apex court secretary general's office, in a communication sent to the joint committee of Parliament on Thursday afternoon, stated that the proposal for an informal discussion with the CJI and other judges on simultaneous elections was discussed among the Supreme Court's senior judges.

The communication, people cited above said, stated that as

SC SECRETARY GENERAL SAID IT MAY NOT BE DESIRABLE TO DISCUSS ISSUE ON ADMIN SIDE AS PROPOSED CHANGES MAY UNDERGO JUDICIAL REVIEW

the proposed amendment might become a subject of judicial review before the Supreme Court, it may not be expedient or desirable to discuss the issue on the administrative side. The proposed meeting was accordingly "cancelled".

The decision followed a discussion between CJI Surya Kant and some senior judges, after which the CJI directed that the proposed interaction should not proceed, the people cited above said.

The joint committee chairman and Bharatiya Janata Party member PP Chaudhary told

news agency PTI that the visit was put off as the dates of committee members did not match. "I also have other commitments to attend to," he told the agency.

The communication from the secretary general's office came even as earlier in the day, independent Rajya Sabha member and senior advocate Kapil Sibal publicly objected to the proposed visit, describing it as "unconstitutional" and contrary to the principle of separation of powers.

The joint committee, headed by Chaudhary, had proposed a visit to the Supreme Court on October 6 as part of its consultations on the Constitution (One Hundred and Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill, 2024 and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2024. The programme described the visit as a "local study visit" and proposed an informal discussion with the CJI and other judges on simultaneous elections.

The developments came

continued on →T1

Preparing for a protest



Ahead of the BJP's protest and Jail Bhara Andolan at Shivaji Park today, Mumbai police blocked the park's entrance points with barricades.

RAJU SHINDE

CJP NATIONWIDE PROTEST BEGINS IN CITY TODAY, POLICE DENY NOD

The CJP will start their nationwide agitation demanding the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in electoral rolls from Shivaji Park today. Mumbai police, however, denied permission for the proposed protest.

OPPOSITION PARTIES TO JOIN THACKERAYS' SUNDAY MARCH

The October 4 protest march announced by Uddhav and Raj Thackeray is set to become a broader Opposition mobilisation, with the Congress and NCP (SP) deciding to participate. The march will begin at Byculla and conclude at the BMC headquarters.

NEW CEOs FOR HDFC AND KOTAK MAHINDRA BANKS

MUMBAI: HDFC Bank and Kotak Mahindra Bank are set for new chief executives after the RBI approved the appointments of Anup Bagchi (in pic) and Anup Kumar Saha, respectively, for three-year terms. Bagchi, 56, was widely seen as the top contender for the post, alongside internal candidate Kaizad M Bharucha. For Bagchi, whose term begins on October 27, the appointment marks a return to banking after three years in insurance. The appointment is also the second instance in recent years of an insurance executive being brought in to lead a bank. In 2019, Amitabh Chaudhry joined Axis Bank as chief executive from HDFC Life Insurance Company.

Saha, whose term will begin on January 27, joined Kotak nine months ago and has been overseeing its retail bank, data analytics and marketing functions. The bank's board of directors will take further steps to formalise Saha's appointment and seek shareholders' approval.

→P14

MAMATA GOT ₹30L FROM EX-MIN AS 'ROYALTY': ED IN PUJA CASE PROBE

KOLKATA: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday said its money laundering probe into alleged financial irregularities linked to the Durga Puja "preview shows" case found that former West Bengal tourism minister Indranil Sen's proprietorship concern transferred nearly ₹30 lakh to former CM Mamata Banerjee through banking channels. ED said Sen claimed the payment was made as "royalty".

→P8

SABARIMALA: JUSTICE NAGARATHNA FIRST SC JUDGE TO START WRITING VERDICT

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Justice BV Nagarathna has become the first judge on the nine-member Constitution bench to start writing the judgment in the Sabarimala reference, setting the stage for a verdict that could redefine the Supreme Court's approach to religious freedom, judicial review and the "essential religious practices" doctrine.

→P9

TRAUMA CENTRES TO COME UP EVERY 100 KMS TO CURB ACCIDENT DEATHS

Shashank Rao

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The state government is considering setting up trauma care centres every 100 km along highways to reduce road accident deaths, officials said. The proposal was discussed at a recent meeting on road safety after Transport Department data showed that 56,000 people died in 1.29 lakh road accidents across the state between January 2023 and July 2026 -- an average of nearly 43 fatalities a day.

→P6



India's Nitesh Siwach poses with his silver medal along with national coach Hargobind Singh, in Nagoya on Thursday.

PTI

Siwach grapples his way into history with Greco-Roman silver

Shantanu Srivastava

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Back in 2015, when Nitesh Siwach was at home at Jagsi village in Haryana's Sonapat, he would hop on to his father's motorbike and set off before dawn daily to deliver milk. It wouldn't be a significant nugget until you know that Nitesh, then barely 12 and hardly strong enough to control the vehicle -- never mind being under-age to ride -- was still recovering from a knee surgery that would keep him out of sports for two years.

"We didn't have enough resour-

ces, so Nitesh decided to do his bit. Today, he is reaping the rewards for all the hard work. He has had a tough life," said Nitesh's father Anand, who was a wrestler in his youth.

On Thursday, Nitesh became the first Indian since Ganpat Andalkar in 1962 Jakarta to reach an Asiad Greco Roman final. Nitesh though came up short against Japan's 2025 Asian Champion-

ships silver medalist Yuri Nakazato, losing the 97kg final 4-0. "You can say it was my dream to wrestle for the country. My son has fulfilled it for me," said Anand.

→P15

BURNT BODIES OF TWO ASCETICS FOUND INSIDE U.P. TEMPLE, 1 HELD

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

MEERUT: Two ascetics, aged 60 and 70, were allegedly killed and their bodies set on fire inside a temple in Shahjahanpur district of Uttar Pradesh, police said on Thursday, adding that a man has been detained for questioning over allegations that he wanted them to leave the shrine to establish control over it.

→P8



The incident occurred around 5.30pm when the students entered a restricted stretch of the sea.

PTI

Arun Dev

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka chief electoral officer (CEO) V Anbukumar on Thursday ordered poll officials to initiate legal proceedings against people who knowingly submit false claims or objections regarding changes to electoral rolls.

The order comes as chief minister DK Shivakumar staged a protest alleging an organised effort to remove voters through Form 7 applications during the special intensive revision (SIR).

In a circular sent to district election officers and Electoral Registration Officers in all 224 assembly constituencies,

88 OF 97 EXCLUDED GOA VOTERS BACK ON VOTER ROLL, SAYS CEO

The chief electoral officer (CEO) of Goa on Thursday confirmed that 88 out of 97 voters who were excluded from the final electoral roll following the SIR exercise despite being eligible have been re-included as fresh voters after they submitted Form 6. The CEO's office said that of the remaining nine voters, three have been found to be Portuguese passport holders, while six are currently residing abroad. Officials are making efforts to establish and maintain contact with voters residing outside India for further necessary action, the statement added.

→P8

Pune college trip turns tragic as eight students drown at Diveagar beach

Vicky Pathare and Sameera Kapoor Munshi

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Eight 16-year-old students from Pune-based Winners Academy drowned at Diveagar beach in Raigad district on Thursday while on an educational trip, raising questions over safety arrangements during the excursion.

The incident occurred around 5.30pm when the students entered a restricted stretch of the sea and were swept away by strong currents.

Police said the students did not know how to swim. Their classmates and teachers raised an alarm, following which local residents and water sports operators launched a rescue operation, but all eight students died.

The students were part of a 48-member group comprising 42 students of Classes 11 and 12 and six teachers, who were visiting Raigad Fort and Shrivardhan.

Winners Academy had obtained written consent from parents for the excursion.

INDIA, PAK PLACED IN SAME GROUP, SET FOR ANOTHER CLASH AT ODI WC

Prateek Srivastava

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Along expected lines, India and Pakistan have been paired in Group A for the 2027 ODI World Cup to be held in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia from October 2 - November 21. Afghanistan, Australia, Zimbabwe and Qualifier A are the other teams in India's group. Bangladesh, England, South Africa, Sri Lanka, New Zealand and Qualifier B are in Group B. India play their opener against defending champions Australia on October 7.

→P16

{ MY INDIA } ANITA ANAND

Canada foreign min to reach India on Oct 12



Canadian foreign minister Anita Anand is expected to visit India in mid-October as part of ramped up contacts between the two countries that are racing to conclude negotiations on a trade deal by the year-end, people familiar with the matter said. New Delhi and Ottawa hope to finalise their negotiations for a comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's planned visit to Canada in December. Anand is expected to be in India during October 12-15 though the visit is yet to be formally announced by both sides, the people said on condition of anonymity. While in New Delhi, Anand is expected to hold talks with external affairs minister S Jaishankar to take stock of progress in implementing a roadmap for bilateral relations that was finalised during her last visit in October 2025, and preparations for Modi's visit to Canada, the people said.

HTC

{ BUSINESS } 15% RISE

GST revenue crosses ₹2 lakh crore in Sept



India's gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenue in September crossed ₹2 lakh crore, registering a 14.7% year-on-year increase, government data released on Thursday showed. Gross GST collections stood at ₹2,03,521 crore in September 2026, compared with ₹1,77,365 crore in September 2025. The collections reflect transactions undertaken in August. Net revenue after refunds surged 18.1% to ₹1,76,520 crore in September this year, from ₹1,49,517 crore in September 2025. Experts attributed the stronger growth in net revenue partly to comparatively lower refunds. Refunds in September 2026 stood at ₹27,001 crore, down 3% from ₹27,848 crore in the same month last year. They also pointed to the sharp rise in import-linked GST revenue compared with collections from domestic business activity.

→P14

{ WORLD } GEMINI 4 ARGON

Google releases advanced AI model, restricts its access



Google may have taken its time, but seems to have delivered a resounding response in the race for the most advanced artificial intelligence (AI; now called Super Intelligence, or SI) models yet. The Gemini 4 Argon model is now in the hands of what Google calls "a set of trusted cyber defenders", and is working with the US government's voluntary process for pre-release model access. That means, not everyone can access Gemini 4 Argon just yet. This is Google's response to OpenAI GPT-6 Astra and Claude Fable 51 models. "To support Gemini 4 Argon's capabilities across longer, more complex use cases, we are significantly expanding the model's output token limit to an industry-leading 1M tokens, up from the previous 64K tokens. When the model has the headroom to think deeply and generate hundreds of thousands of tokens in a single trajectory, it adds a new level of depth in reasoning to solve tough problems in one go," said Koray Kavukcuoglu.

→P13

{ MY INDIA } HAWALA FUNDING

Yasin Malik, 6 others face PMLA charges



A special NIA court has ordered framing of money laundering charges against jailed Jammu & Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF) chief Yasin Malik and six others for allegedly routing Pakistani and foreign funds through hawala channels to "finance secessionist activities in J&K". In an order passed on September 9 and made available on Thursday, the court held that sufficient material existed to raise a "strong suspicion" against all seven accused for an offence under Section 3 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). According to the Enforcement Directorate, the criminal activities under investigation generated proceeds of crime totalling ₹8.94 crore. ED alleged that the money was subsequently received, transferred, concealed, possessed, acquired and used by the accused through different channels.

HTC

{ WORLD } GUV HALTS EXECUTIONS

US convict survives two lethal injections



Tennessee officials were unable to put Christa Gail Pike to death on Wednesday for a 1995 murder after administering two doses of a lethal drug. A death penalty expert said it was an unprecedented failure, and Tennessee Governor Bill Lee halted the one remaining execution for the rest of the year. Pike, 50, was alive and loudly snoring after the attempted lethal injection and taken by ambulance from the prison, her attorneys said. She was being treated at a hospital, but they said they hadn't been told about her condition. She had been scheduled for execution for the killing she committed at age 18 and would have been the first woman executed in Tennessee in over 200 years. Officials gave Pike two doses of pentobarbital, her attorneys said in court filings late Wednesday. Lee said that he has ordered "a comprehensive, third-party review to determine exactly what occurred".

→P13

Govt to deliberate advisory for airlines after attack on pilot

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The government will hold international deliberations to assess whether an advisory needs to be issued to Indian airlines following an incident in which an Indian pilot was stabbed by his co-pilot onboard a flydubai flight, civil aviation secretary Samir Kumar Sinha said on Thursday.

"This is an unfortunate incident but the nation is very proud of the fact that Capt Smit (Machchhar), an Indian, was able to save lives... (Discussions on whether an advisory should be issued) is under examination. We will sit and thereafter, we will discuss some security issues. We are examining this particular matter and maybe if some advisory is to be issued (to the airlines), we will put it to higher authorities for taking a decision in the matter... We will be able to answer more on the case once we have done our internal deliberations," Sinha said.

He added, "We would not like to delve into this (the incident in particular) because this is pertaining to some other country and it, of course, would be examined."

The incident involved a co-pilot of a flydubai flight enroute to Tel Aviv allegedly attempting to take control of the aircraft on Wednesday. The attempt was foiled by Indian pilot Capt Smit Machchhar, the pilot-in-command, who suffered serious injuries while trying to subdue the co-pilot.

Flydubai flight FZ1073, a Boe-

CAPT SMIT WAS STABBED DURING A STRUGGLE THAT SENT THE FLYDUBAI FLIGHT PLUNGING 14,300 FEET IN ABOUT 30 SECONDS

ing 737 MAX 8 carrying 174 passengers, plunged 14,300ft in about 30 seconds over northern Saudi Arabia, before landing safely at Prince Sultan Bin Abdulaziz Airport in Tabuk. Two flydubai pilots travelling as passengers took control of the aircraft after Capt Machchhar reportedly managed to open the cockpit door.

Machchhar, according to a statement by the ministry of external affairs, was moved to Abu Dhabi on Thursday after receiving initial treatment in Saudi Arabia.

It is believed that Machchhar was stabbed with a crash axe, an emergency tool usually located behind the pilot-in-command's seat and designed to be readily accessible. "He might have gotten an axe from the equipment that might be standard on this aeroplane," Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu told Fox News. He added, "We're looking into that, we can't draw conclusions yet."

Officials said Capt Machchhar was stable and able to communicate on Thursday.

Flydubai, however, did not provide an update on the health status of the pilots or the investigation into the incident.

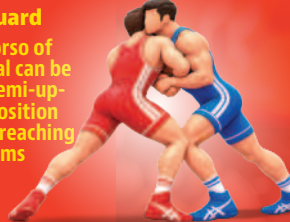


Greco-Roman vs freestyle: A clash of styles

Nitesh Siwach won silver on Thursday in Greco-Roman wrestling, a discipline in which India has not fared as successfully as in freestyle. Here's a look at how the two wrestling styles differ, from technique to scoring:

The Guard

Only torso of the rival can be held. Semi-upright position makes reaching with arms easier



The Guard
Keeping the torso horizontal can protect the wrestler's legs. Legs highly flexed



GRECO-ROMAN HOLD FREESTYLE

For a valid hold, the wrestler must be in contact with the opponent as he is tackled to the ground

While using a throw in freestyle, wrestlers can toss the opponent and regain contact with them as they hit the mat

TECHNIQUE

Strong upper body, explosive strength and grips play key roles. Wrestlers rely on headlocks, body locks, and arm drags to score

No restriction in the use of arms and legs for takedowns and throws. The use of legs and hips to seize control of opponent is allowed

SCORING

Scoring below the waist is not allowed. Grabbing the opponent's knees, thighs or legs or using leg trips also not allowed

Wrestlers can also score below the waist using their legs for both attacking and defensive moves. Women compete only in freestyle

TECHNICAL SUPERIORITY

When a wrestler takes an eight-point lead, he is awarded the bout on technical superiority

A lead of 10 points is required to seal victory in a bout via technical superiority

PENALTY FOR PASSIVITY

A passive wrestler is penalised one point and the opponent can choose between standing or par terre position where he gets the opponent down on his stomach on the mat

A passive wrestler is put on a 30-second activity clock. If neither scores in half-a-minute, the active wrestler is awarded a point

NOT AMONG INDIA'S FAVOURITES

India have won 65 medals in wrestling at the Asian Games, and only 11 of them came in Greco-Roman. The rest are all in freestyle category

On Thursday, 23-year-old Nitesh beat Mongolia's Gankhuyag Ganbaatar 9-0 to earn a victory by technical superiority in the Greco-Roman 97kg semi-finals, before losing to Japan's Yuri Nakazato in the final

India's Nitesh Siwach in action during his 97kg Greco-Roman quarter-final against Turkmenistan's Amanberdi Agamammedov at the Asian Games in Nagoya on Thursday. ANI

{ INDIA VS PAK AT ASIAN GAMES }

Familiar foes rekindle romance of hockey's great rivalry

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: Relief.

That was the sentiment of most Indian hockey fans after the Harmanpreet Singh-led team escaped with a narrow 4-3 victory over Pakistan following Abhishek's goal 49 seconds from the hooter.

India vs Pakistan. This iconic clash carries a lot of weight: history, legacy, prestige and with a dash of enmity. But unfortunately, the contest has lost its competitive bite in recent years: reduced to one-sided matches and a rivalry that exists only in the name.

With the rise of Indian hockey and the decline of the game in Pakistan, there is no uncertainty about which team starts as favourite. India have not lost to their neighbours in a decade, with the last setback coming at the 2016 South Asian Games final in Guwahati. Since then, India have won 19 of the 22 matches, with two draws and one no-result.

But Thursday's Asian Games semi-final in Kakamigahara rekindled the romance of the rivalry, the volatile passion of South Asia's greatest sporting feud, the nostalgia-drenched

memory of an epic rivalry that once ruled world hockey. The teams once played three Olympic finals, one World Cup final, and nine Asian Games finals.

In a throwback moment on Thursday, former centre-forward Ashok Kumar immediately remembered the 1975 World Cup final at the Merdeka Stadium in Kuala Lumpur, where Pakistan captain Islahuddin Siddiqui walked up to him just moments before the start.

Standing opposite each other at the 50-yard line, Islahuddin made a request that captured the spirit and camaraderie of the era: "Ashok, gaana gao".

Ashok looked back in utter surprise, reminding his rival that the summit clash was about to start. But Islahuddin only laughed. Seeing his opponent's persistence,

Ashok straightened his hockey stick, rhythmically started beating it and sang the popular track *Jai Jai Shiv Shankar*. "That just showed how confident the two teams were back then," two-time World Cup winner Islahuddin had told this correspondent in an earlier interview. "There was mutual respect between the players too."

That 1975 final ended in



India's Rajinder Singh (in orange) vies for the ball during a men's semi-final hockey match between India and Pakistan at the ongoing 20th Asian Games in Japan on Thursday.

PTI

immortal glory for India. Ashok went on to score the winning goal — the most significant hit of his career — to give his team a momentous 2-1 victory, securing India's first and only World Cup crown.

In that golden era, hockey was the pre-eminent sport in South Asia with India and Pakistan standing as absolute masters of the game, winning almost everything on offer. Yet, off the field, the fierce competi-

tors shared an extraordinary bond.

"We shared a great relationship with some Pakistani players. We spent a lot of time together and also went for their weddings. Some of the players' mothers would come to receive us at the airport too," Ashok, son of Major Dhyani Chand, told HT.

Former India goalkeeper Ashish Ballal recalled how that camaraderie translated into a

unique off-pitch dynamic during the 1990s, anchored by shared Punjabi heritage.

"In our times, most of the Pakistani guys were friendly with our Punjabi players. Most of the Pakistani players used to hang around with our Punjabi players, listen to Punjabi music and get smashed in the evenings," Ballal told HT with a chuckle.

"The rapport was there. It was only on the ground that it

was very aggressive with Punjabi lingo at its best. After matches we would sit down in the evenings, chat and drink at times. The next morning on the ground, you'd become aggressive again because everybody wants to win."

Ballal confessed that non-Punjabi players like himself were initially offended by the colourful language thrown around during matches.

"One day, they got us all together and told us, 'Listen, even when we talk to our dads, we talk like this! It is a kind of fondness in our lingo.' Today, when I speak with my old teammates, it comes automatically."

On the pitch, though, the intensity was ferocious. Fights broke out, wrong-side tackles carried dangerous follow-throughs and both teams played with a wildly volatile unpredictability. But that aggression also brought out the excitement with moments of sheer magic of individual brilliance or at other times, mediocrity at its best.

Even as global dominance shifted towards European powerhouses and Australia in the 1990s and 2000s, individual stars kept the fixture spellbinding.

Pakistan boasted icons such as Shahbaz Ahmed, Sohail Abbas and Rehan Butt while India had wizards such as Par-

gat Singh, Dhanraj Pillay and Dilip Tirkey in their ranks.

At the 2010 World Cup in New Delhi, 16,000 fans packed the Major Dhyani Chand National Stadium, the only contest of the tournament that saw a full house.

Former India skipper Sardar Singh, who captained India during high-stakes battles including their gold medal win at the 2014 Incheon Asian Games, stressed that mental strength was paramount in these fixtures.

"Ninety per cent of the matches were won by teams which were mentally stronger," Sardar told HT.

"When I was captain in Incheon, the crowd was very negative, abused us while we walked back to the stadium at half-time. What is important is to control your mind, stay relaxed and focus on the plan given by the coaches."

Sardar fondly remembered playing alongside Pakistani stalwarts in the erstwhile Premier Hockey League (2005-2008), forging warm friendships with Shakeel Abbasi and Muhammad Saqlain.

In the past decade, however, the paths of the two nations diverged dramatically. Heavy investment flowed into Indian hockey which provided state-of-the-art infrastructure and top-level foreign coaches. This

systemic overhaul returned India to the Olympic podium after a gap of 41 years, making them the only men's team to medal at the last two Olympic Games.

Conversely, Pakistan's hockey has plummeted.

They failed to qualify for the last three Olympics and two of the last four World Cups. "Hockey culture has just suddenly died in Pakistan," the legendary Shahbaz Ahmed, the only player to win back-to-back Player of the Tournament awards at World Cups (1990 and 1994), told HT last year.

Financial neglect further crippled Pakistani hockey. Ahead of the 2018 World Cup, the team barely secured travel funds at the 11th hour through a private sponsor. Former head coach Shafiqur Aikman resigned in 2023 after going unpaid for an entire year.

However, Thursday's clash reminded the world why this fixture remains unmatched.

From flashes of individual brilliance to sudden swings of momentum and raw emotional intensity, the contest showed that no matter how deep the structural divide grows, an India-Pakistan hockey match retains its unique, unpredictable magic, rekindling the timeless romance forged when two friends sang together on the Kuala Lumpur turf five decades ago.

MY MUMBAI

Neighbours cheer captain's heroism

Smit Machchhar, grew up in the Gujarati middle class neighbourhood of Ghatkopar East

Yogesh Naik

yogesh.naik@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Residents of Swastik Heights at Tilak Nagar, Chembur, gathered in large numbers in the building compound on Thursday noon to raise a cheer for Captain Smit Machchhar and demand that the government bestow a civil honour on him.

"We are so proud that Smit saved so many lives," said the pilot's uncle Kishor Machchhar. Another family friend, Vipul Mehta, promised a "grand felicitation when Smit is back in Mumbai."

Machchhar, the captain of Wednesday's flybydubai flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv averted a major mid-air disaster when he fought back against the co-pilot of the aircraft who suddenly went rogue and stabbed Machchhar multiple times in an apparent effort to crash.

As the Boeing 737 MAX 8 carrying 174 passengers plunged 14,300 feet, the Mumbai-born pilot fought back and opened the cockpit door allowing for passengers to come in and overpower the co-pilot whose name has still not been made public.

Both, the Indian and Israeli Prime Ministers, hailed Machchhar's courage and presence of mind. For his immediate family though, the concern is about Machchhar's health.

He is being treated at a military hospital at Tabruk in Saudi Arabia. Machchhar's parents Upendra and Gita who live at Swastik Heights, left for Dubai on Thursday morning to be with Machchhar's wife Sonal and



Residents of Swastik Heights at Tilak Nagar, Chembur, where the captain's parents live, gathered on Thursday to hail his courage and prayed for his speedy recovery.

SATISH BATE/HT PHOTO



Both, the Indian and Israeli PMs, hailed Captain Smit Machchhar's courage and presence of mind.

AFP

their two grandchildren. According to Machchhar's uncle Kishor, the pilot moved to Dubai in 2022 to work with flybydubai. Prior to that he had worked for 11 years at SpiceJet where he was a senior commander and a line training captain who trained and supervised other pilots. Machchhar, 38, also started an aviation institute in Ghatkopar East called FlyBy Aviation Academy which is at present being managed by his cousin Pooja Ganatra.

The pilot has logged 9,750 flying hours on the 737-800 and the

737 MAX 8 and 9. On Thursday, American media called him the "Indian Sully" comparing him to Chesley Sullenberger, best-known for landing safely landing a US Airways flight on the Hudson River in New York after a bird hit disabled its engines.

Smit Machchhar, originally from Rajkot, grew up in the predominantly Gujarati middle class neighbourhood of Ghatkopar East where the family runs a printing press business. He studied at Ramji Assar and VS Gandhi Gurukul Technical School and did an MBA from Welingkar Institute of Management Development and Research (WeSchool), Matunga.

"He is a true hero in the skies. His courage, discipline and dedication inspires us all. We are proud to see a Welingkar alumnus soar so high," said Pankaj Natu, director, WeSchool. He completed his flying course from New Zealand and joined SpiceJet where he worked for 12 years.

Bhavin Mehta, who runs a cafe in Ghatkopar and who studied with Machchhar, told HT that their school WhatsApp group was "full of praise and prayers for Captain Smit."

CJP to begin agitation today, demands CEC's resignation

Surendra P Gangan

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), announced a nationwide agitation launching from Mumbai on October 2 to contest alleged irregularities in electoral rolls. Dipke demanded the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and urged greater accountability in the Election Commission's (EC) functioning.

Speaking at a media interaction in Mumbai on Thursday, Dipke outlined the CJP's three core demands: the immediate resignation of CEC Kumar, freezing the electoral roll compiled in 2025 to conduct upcoming elections on that basis, and establishing a transparent, independent selection mechanism for appointing future Election Commissioners that incorporates civil society participation.

The protest is scheduled to launch at 4 pm near Gate No. 6 of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Park on Gandhi Jayanti in Mumbai. The campaign will move through various regions, including Goa and Kolkata, before concluding with an indefinite sit-in at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi until CEC Kumar steps down.

However, Mumbai police denied permission for the gathering, citing ground restrictions, lack of municipal clearance, and noise and traffic concerns. Following this, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis warned that proceeding with the unauthorized protest would result in a three-day jail term prior to bail. Dipke countered with Fadnavis's famous 2019 pre-poll catchphrase, "Mee punha yein" (I will be back), asserting that even arrest would not stop the movement and that supporters will not back down.

Emphasising that the demonstration is a non-partisan citizens' initiative, Dipke requested that participants refrain from bringing political flags or banners. He reaffirmed that the CJP is not allying with any political party. Dipke asserted that public confidence in the electoral system has dissolved, criticising roll revisions and claiming the government dictates who remains listed.

He further alleged that the EC functions under executive influence, pointing out that nearly 13 crore voters—roughly 14% of the electorate—have been removed since 2024.



On Thursday, Abhijeet Dipke outlined the CJP's three core demands: Gyanesh Kumar's resignation; freezing the electoral roll compiled in 2025; and transparency in the selection of future Election Commissioners, with civil society participation.

ANSHUMAN POYREKAR/HT PHOTOS

He noted this gap matches the vote-share difference between the NDA and INDIA bloc in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, alleging that removing such numbers predetermines outcomes.

Additionally, Dipke criticised the SIR of voter lists as a threat to franchise rights, describing current democracy as merely illusory. Pointing out that CEC Kumar was appointed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah, he stated they must dismiss him or risk public anger turning against themselves.

He also welcomed support from Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray and insisted the CJP will remain strictly independent.

Opposition parties to join Thackerays' October 4 march

Saurabha Kulshreshtha

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Congress and Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) have decided to join the October 4 protest march announced jointly by Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray, turning the proposed agitation into a broader Opposition mobilisation.

NCP (SP) working president Supriya Sule announced on Thursday that her party would participate in the march. Congress leader Nana Patole also confirmed the party's participation, saying the agitation should extend beyond political parties.

"Our party will participate in the October 4 protest march," Sule said.

Patole said the Congress wanted the protest to become a people's move-

ment. "Democracy is being murdered in broad daylight. Gyanesh Kumar is benefiting the BJP. Congress believes democracy must be protected. Everyone who believes in democracy is now taking to the streets," he said.

The announcements came after Uddhav Thackeray participated virtually in an INDIA bloc meeting and appealed to alliance partners to join the march. The Thackeray cousins had invited Opposition parties as well as citizens to participate.

The inclusion of the Congress and NCP (SP) brings key Opposition parties in Maharashtra together for the first time around the proposed agitation, widening its political footprint.

The march will begin at Byculla and conclude at the BMC headquarters. The Opposition parties will raise concerns over the functioning of the ECI and SIR.

DIPKE DETAINED BRIEFLY AFTER BEING SPOTTED WITH PLACARDS



Police questioned Dipke before allowing him to leave

MUMBAI: CJP chief Abhijeet Dipke was briefly detained by Marine Drive police after officers asked him to accompany them to the police station for tea. Police, however, said he was allowed to leave shortly afterwards.

According to a video that went viral and the Marine Drive police, Dipke was at Marine Drive promoting his October 2 protest at Shivaji Park. He was carrying placards and was accompanied by several supporters when police officers asked him to come to the police station. At the station, an officer questioned Dipke before allowing him to leave. Police said the interaction was informal and that the officer had invited him for tea. A video of Dipke's brief "detention" went viral on social media.

According to the police, the organisers have been promoting a 'Jail Bharo Andolan' and appealing to youngsters to join the protest on October 2. Several WhatsApp groups have reportedly been created and social media platforms are being used to mobilise participants.

HTC



Government of India

Nation salutes Gandhi ji and Shastri ji on their birth anniversaries

2 October, 2026

On the birth anniversaries of Mahatma Gandhi and Lal Bahadur Shastri, the nation pays tribute to these two great leaders who dedicated their lives to the service of the nation.

"Gandhi ji demonstrated the way of courage, simplicity, service, and power of compassion, while Shastri ji continues to motivate us in the endeavour of building a strong and self-reliant India."

- Narendra Modi





Follow us on:   



Locate your nearest
Pigeon Exclusive Store

Mumbai's water stock to last till Sept 2027, with 10% cut, says BMC data

State to regulate the supply for irrigation and prioritize water for drinking purposes

Linah Baliga, Yogesh Naik and Saurabha Kulshreshtha
Htmumbai@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Mumbai's water stock will sustain the city until September 5, 2027, if the 10% water cut is extended and the approved reserve storage in Upper Vaitarna and Bhatsa – dams that provide the major share of water to the city -- is maintained, reported the water-supply planning data prepared by the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC). It was presented by Abhijit Bangar, additional municipal commissioner (projects), at the civic standing committee on Thursday.

The civic body currently supplies around 4,100 million litres of water a day (MLD) to the city. Among the major reservoirs, Bhatsa has the largest useful storage, at 7,17,037 million litres, of which 7,04,965 million litres was available till September 30. Without a cut and without retaining the reserve storage, supply from the dam is projected to last until June 10, 2027.

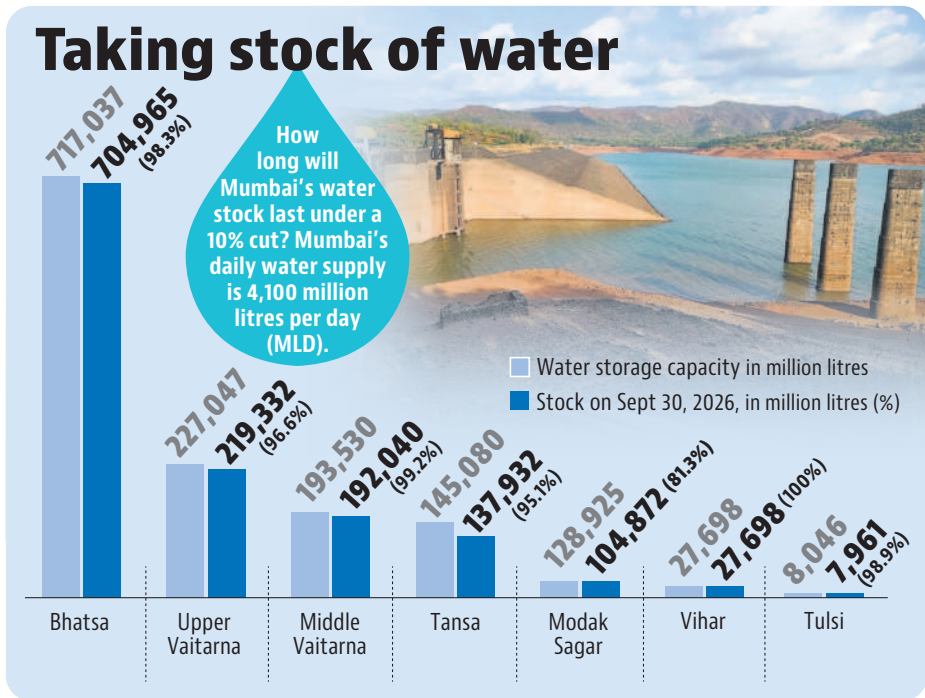
With the approved reserve storage in Upper Vaitarna and Bhatsa, the projected date of water availability would extend to August 2, 2027, the data revealed. (See graphic for water reserves in the dams).

On the other hand, with the monsoon season officially ending on September 30, 2026, and 75.25% stock available in the state's irrigation reservoirs, authorities have decided to regulate supply to farmlands until the onset of the monsoon in 2027, so that water is prioritised for drinking purposes until August 31, 2027, said an officer from the irrigation department.

As at this time last year the water storage in the dams was 88.82%, the present scenario projects the likelihood of a major water scarcity in the next nine to ten months. Hence, the government is likely to impose a 10% cut to save water for the summer and the first two months of next year's monsoon, said the officer.

While Mumbai has water stock in its reservoirs, the situation is worrisome in other parts of the Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR) as they largely rely on the state irrigation department's dams.

Irrigation secretary Prakash Misal said, "There will be shortfall in Kalyan-Dombivli, Palghar, Vasai-Virar and other



areas. Water is limited but cities are growing and demand is increasing. Hence, we have decided to give priority to drinking water. But more than MMR, Marathwada and Vidarbha will be hit hard."

This means that Bhatsa and Upper Vaitarna will not supply water for irrigation purposes. An official of Bhatsa

project said, "We have been told to work on a plan wherein water stocks last till August 31, 2027. Mumbai gets nearly 55 per cent of water from us. We also provide water to Thane. This time, we will have to stop water for irrigation or give them water only if enough drinking water is stocked till August 31, 2027."

Elsewhere in MMR
Navi Mumbai's Morbe dam has 74% stock, which is used by the Navi Mumbai Municipal Corporation (NMCM) to provide 498 MLD in its area. The civic body's 10% water cut was revoked after September. However, with limited stock in the dam now, NMCM has issued an advisory to citizens to save and use water

conservatively. "As of now we have only issued an advisory to save water. But we are waiting for the state government's decision on possible future cuts," said an official from NMCM.

Kalyan-Dombivli Municipal Corporation (KDMC) which gets 425 MLD water supply has communicated with the state government seeking additional quota, arguing that it has not been revised since 2018 despite the increase in population. "While there are no water cuts by KDMC, areas governed by it along the borders are facing shortage. Hence, we have demanded that the sanctioned quota be increased by 180 MLD," said an official from the water supply department.

Ambernath and Badlapur, which receive supply from the Maharashtra Jeevan Pradhikaran (MJP) scheme from Ulhas River, is not facing a shortage now.

Thane city's requirement is around 621 MLD, however it currently receives only around 585 to 590 MLD of supply. As a result, Thane is facing a daily water shortfall of around 31 MLD. At present, the dams supplying water to Thane have sufficient storage, but the 10% cut will be implemented in the urban areas following the state government's decision, said a TMC official.

Haze sets in over the city



Mumbai's air quality has begun to deteriorate after nearly four months of relatively clear skies, with a blanket of haze observed across the city on Thursday. The city's 24-hour overall AQI stood at 79, with PM10 emerging as the dominant pollutant. This was the second consecutive day that Mumbai's AQI remained above 70; on Wednesday, it was recorded at 75, with nitrogen dioxide as the primary pollutant.

SATISH BATE/HT PHOTO

ECI backs down, parties to get details of voter-roll discrepancies

Surendra P Gangan

surendra.gangan@htlive.com

MUMBAI: After the nationwide storm over the allegedly compromised SIR process which left millions of electors off the voter rolls, the Election Commission of India (ECI) has backed down. After initially refusing to share the details of anomalies and unmapped entries with the booth-level agents (BLAs) appointed by political parties, it has agreed to do so.

Around 12.2 million electors had been sent notices for anomalies in their details, such as the spelling of their name, wrong birthdate or the age difference between son and father, among others, and for 'unmapped' entries with their credentials

from the 2004 SIR. The office of Maharashtra's chief electoral officer (CEO) S Chockalingam on Thursday issued revised guidelines to all district electoral officers. Chockalingam also held an online conference with 288 Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) and over 7,000 AEROs on Tuesday to familiarise them with the new guidelines.

Under the revised process, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) will visit the homes of electors left off the rolls, collect the required documents and upload them on ECINet for consideration by the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) or Assistant ERO. The BLOs have been directed to add a footnote to the notice, stating that electors will be required to appear personally for a hearing

only in exceptional cases.

In a significant step, the lists of electors whose names were flagged for unmapped entries or logical discrepancies will be made available to political party representatives at the polling-centre level before any final decisions are taken. Parties will be able to assist in facilitating the submission of documents by concerned electors, as the BLAs appointed by them are in close contact with these electors.

The Maharashtra CEO's office has also directed that adequate time be given to electors to submit documents. The ECI has already directed that the necessary changes be made to the ECINet software and BLO app to implement the revised procedure.

Explosion on stranded ship: Three copper thieves arrested

Megha Sood

megha.sood@htlive.com

MUMBAI: The police on Thursday arrested three men who survived an explosion on a stranded ship off the city's coast while attempting to steal copper pipes, which resulted in the death of four of their gang members. The trio had managed to flee after the explosion, suspected to have been caused by a gas leak last week.

The incident occurred on September 27 onboard Al Jafzia, an unmanned Nicaragua-flagged tanker that has been stranded off the Gorai-Manori coast in Borivali West for the past four months.

The police registered an FIR against seven individuals after the bodies of the four who perished in the explosion were recovered on Wednesday. The three who survived the blast were arrested on Thursday, said Sandeep Ghuge, deputy commis-

THE POLICE ARE INVESTIGATING IF THERE WERE MORE MEN INVOLVED IN THE THEFT OF COPPER PIPES FROM THE SHIP

sioner of police (Zone II).

The arrested accused were identified as Shiven Shailesh Shundul, Pratik Pandhrinath Patil, and Vijay Premnath Sanjiva. They have been remanded to police custody till October 6.

The trio allegedly confessed that they had robbed copper wires and pipes from the ship twice in the past two months and sold them to scrap dealers for ₹8 lakh. Their luck ran out on the third attempt, said Ghuge.

"We are investigating whether there were more men involved in the theft and trying to identify the scrap dealers who bought

the robbed material from them," said Ghuge.

Three of the deceased have been identified as Vinayak Ambavane alias Vinu, Shankar and Ramchandra Nevrekar. The identity of the third deceased is not known yet. Their bodies have been sent for post-mortem to JJ Hospital to determine the exact cause of death. The police are also trying to determine the precise sequence of events that led to the explosion.

According to the police, the gang of seven had boarded the ship using a speedboat. Out of the seven, four went into the ship's interior to cut copper pipes to steal them. The police suspect a gas leak occurred inside the ship during this time, leading to an explosion.

Al Jafzia is one of the three ships seized by the Indian Coast Guard on February 6 this year for suspected smuggling of petroleum products in India's exclusive economic zone.

Auto driver stabs 18-year-old after he refuses to end football game

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: An 18-year-old student was stabbed by an auto-rickshaw driver on Wednesday night following a dispute over asking youngsters to stop playing football in Malwani ground.

The incident occurred around 9:30pm near a Hanuman temple, where the victim Jaydeep Koli, was playing football with neighbourhood friends.

Police officers said that auto-rickshaw auto driver Sanjay Kurade arrived at the spot, parked his vehicle in the middle of the playground, and demanded the boys stop playing. Kurade also allegedly asked younger children

DISPUTE AROSE AFTER RICKSHAW DRIVER PARKED HIS VEHICLE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE GROUND. ASKING BOYS TO STOP PLAYING AND BUY HIM CIGARETTES

to buy him a cigarette. When they refused, an enraged Kurade drove his rickshaw further onto the field. Koli asked him to relocate the vehicle, but Kurade allegedly ran over Koli's feet.

When Koli confronted him, Kurade verbally abused him and

started assaulting him. Koli's friend, 18-year-old Aniket Kailas Gawali, intervened to break up the altercation. Kurade then retrieved a knife from his rickshaw, grabbed Koli by his T-shirt and neck, shoved him against a parked tempo, and stabbed him in the abdomen. As Kurade tried to strike his neck, Koli raised his hand in defence, sustaining serious injuries below his neck and on his upper left arm.

Bystanders intervened, forcing Kurade to flee and leave Koli bleeding. Gawali and others rushed Koli to the hospital where he remains in the ICU. The Malwani police registered an FIR for attempt-to-murder against Kurade.

ED attaches assets worth ₹646 cr in Pancard Clubs case

Abhishek Sharan

abhishek.sharan@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Mumbai unit of the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has provisionally attached 211 immovable assets worth Rs 646.58 crore across multiple states as part of its money-laundering investigation into private firm Pancard Clubs Limited (PCL) and others in an alleged Rs 4,387-crore Ponzi scheme-based investment fraud.

The attached assets comprise offices, luxury hotels, resorts, agricultural land and residential properties across Maharashtra, Kerala, Uttarakhand, Goa, Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Telangana and Dadra & Nagar Haveli. The properties are in the names of PCL and Panoramic Universal Limited, their subsidiary concerns and their beneficial owners and family members.

The ED investigation is based on a case registered by the Dadar police against PCL and others, which was subsequently taken over by the Mumbai police's Economic Offences Wing. The EOW submitted its charge sheet to a city-based special MPID (Maharashtra Protection of Interest of Depositors Act) court on December 31, 2021.

The investigation revealed that the accused had allegedly established a network of 46 corporate entities under the Panoramic Group of Companies. They subsequently floated illegal Ponzi schemes under the pretext of selling time-share holiday memberships and discounted hotel room stays, luring over 5.1 million investors across India with promises of unrealistic financial returns.

Under this 'Collective Investment Scheme', allegedly run in contravention of SEBI regulations, PCL is alleged to have

fraudulently collected Rs 9,577 crore from investors from 1997-98 to 2017-18. Of this amount, only Rs 2,858 crore was returned to depositors while Rs 2,332 crore was paid as commission to agents, leaving Rs 4,387 crore as the proceeds of crime (POC) which was retained and diverted by the accused entities and key individuals, ED officials said.

The investigation also revealed that the funds were systematically layered through multiple dummy companies and later injected into associate entities like Panoramic Universal Limited and its domestic and overseas subsidiaries. These funds, parts of the POC in the case, were subsequently integrated to acquire high-value real estate properties, resorts, and commercial units across India and abroad in the names of group companies, their directors and their family members, while attempting to project them as "untainted properties", ED officials said.

A deliberate attempt was also allegedly made to frustrate legal proceedings through fraudulent alienation of assets previously attached by SEBI and the MPID authorities. An immovable property of 7.08 hectares at village Kalhe in Panvel, for instance, was allegedly sold unauthorisedly despite the existing attachment orders by SEBI and the MPID's Competent Authority, ED officials said. "This transaction was executed using a forged board resolution bearing the signature of a deceased director on behalf of a struck-off entity," said an ED official.

Earlier, in 2025, the ED had provisionally attached 30 immovable properties located abroad (USA, UAE and Thailand), estimated at Rs 54.31 crore.

{ **PUNE LAND DEAL** } HC ASKS MAHA POLICE

Why exclude 99% stakeholder Parth Pawar?

Karuna Nidhi

karuna.nidhi@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Thursday questioned the Maharashtra police over its decision not to name Rajya Sabha MP Parth Pawar as an accused in the controversial Pune land deal case despite the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader holding a 99% stake in the company that bought a government land parcel in the upscale Mundhwa area at a heavily discounted price.

Addressing Maharashtra director general of police (DGP) Sadanand Date orally, a single-judge bench of justice Madhav Jamdar said, "Your stand as investigating officer is that the person who is having 99% shareholding is not responsible, and the one who is accused is the person having 1% shareholding. Is the person who is having 99% share, Parth Pawar, not a beneficiary of this transaction?"

The court posed this question to Date while granting pre-arrest bail to Pune tehsildar Suryakant Yewale, who was named an accused in the case for allegedly misusing his official position to facilitate the controversial transaction. Yewale has denied any role in the transaction and claimed he was falsely implicated.

The 1% shareholder the court referred to is Digvijay Patil, one of the prime accused in the case and a partner at Amadea Enterprises LLP, a Pune-based firm at the centre of the controversy. Parth Pawar, son of deputy chief minister Sunetra Pawar, owns 99% of the firm, but was omitted from the FIR.

The bench made its remarks after the Maharashtra DGP filed an affidavit in response to Yewale's submission in his plea



Parth Pawar owns 99% of Amadea Enterprises LLP. HT

that Pawar was not named an accused in the case because he was a highly influential person.

In his affidavit filed on September 24, DGP Date told the high court that following a "detailed scrutiny" of the investigation papers, "on certain points, there is definitely [a] need for more professional and detailed investigation".

Date also assured the court that his office would monitor the investigation and make all necessary efforts to ensure that the Pune police vigorously pursue all available leads.

"In order to ensure comprehensive investigation against each of the named accused and other suspects, a detailed set of instructions have been issued to the Commissioner of Police, Pune City," the DGP's affidavit stated. Due to "the sensitivity of the matter and concerns expressed regarding the investigation," the Pune police commissioner has also been instructed to review the investigation's progress every week and submit a report to the DGP's office after six weeks, the affidavit added.

The case pertains to alleged attempts by Amadea Enterprises to acquire a 40-acre Maharashtra government land parcel in Mundhwa, valued at ₹1,800 crore, for ₹300 crore, with a ₹21 crore stamp duty exemption.

{ **AT THE STATE POLICE HEADQUARTERS** }

Former boss of C-60, the anti-Naxal unit, felicitated

Vinay Dalvi

vinay.dalvi@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Maharashtra police on Thursday felicitated IPS officer K P Raghuvanshi and other officers who had served in Gadchiroli at a function at the state police headquarters. "Raghuvanshi was honoured at the hands of DGP Sadanand Date for his fight against Maoism in the Gadchiroli belt," said a police officer. "Gratitude was also expressed to the families of the 244 police personnel who were killed in the anti-Maoist struggle."

The officer said that Raghuvanshi's sterling achievement was the founding of C-60, an elite anti-Naxal commando unit of the Maharashtra police, which played a crucial role in eliminating 363 Maoists, arrest-

ing 558 and getting 861 to surrender. "Today, it is to his credit that there is not a single armed Maoist in the state," he said.

"I feel indebted to Maharashtra police for honouring me," said Raghuvanshi.

According to government records, the district became free from armed Maoism in May 2026. "The C-60 unit played a crucial role in the fight against Maoists in Maharashtra," said the police officer.

Raghuvanshi, who was then Superintendent of Police, formed C-60 on December 1, 1990. In the early 1980s, an armed Maoist squad known as a dalam began entering southern Gadchiroli from the Telangana region, marking the influx of the Maoist movement into Maharashtra. In 1982, following the division of the Chandrapur



KP Raghuvanshi was honoured at the hands of DGP Sadanand Date on Thursday.

district, the newly created Gadchiroli district had sparse administration and scattered tribal settlements, which the Maoists exploited along with the injustice faced by tribals on

such issues as tendu leaf-picking wages and forest rights.

By 2009, two companies, four platoons, and nine dalams comprising 379 armed Maoists were active in Gadchiroli, while 57

Maoists were active in Gondia district.

"Due to Gadchiroli's 76% dense forest cover, landmines, IEDs planted on roads and shelter provided by various organisations along the inter-state border, traditional policing methods proved insufficient," said the police officer. "Under these difficult circumstances, Raghuvanshi formed the C-60 of 60 commandos with the aim of recruiting locals who knew the terrain and spoke the Gond and Madiya tribal languages to fight the Maoists on their own ground."

In 1994, a second batch of commandos was created for South Gadchiroli with the motto "Veerbhogya Vasundhara" (The Brave Win the Earth).

"We currently have 29 teams of the C-60, 961 personnel in

Gadchiroli and nine teams of 166 personnel in Gondia. They are supported by 164 drones, 64 mines-protected vehicles, 20 bomb detection and disposal squads, and 17 dog squads," said the police officer.

The C-60 unit is trained for combat on difficult battle-grounds such as dense forests and hilly terrain. The commandos are trained in the country's elite institutions, including the National Security Guard campus, Manesar, the Police Training Centre, Hazaribagh, the Jungle Warfare College, Kanker.

A total of 244 police officials and personnel died in action while 609 innocent bystanders in the area were killed in the fight against Maoism. Through police operations, 363 Maoists have been killed, 558 arrested while 861 have surrendered.



राष्ट्रीय प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान हमीरपुर
(एक राष्ट्रीय महत्व का संस्थान)
National Institute of Technology Hamirpur
(An Institute of National Importance)

Online applications are invited for **PDF and Ph.D. admissions of September 2026, under Visvesvaraya Scheme of MeitY**, in Department of Computer Science & Engineering and Department of Electronics & Communication Engineering for the Academic Year 2026-27. The last date for submitting the Application online is **14.10.2026**. For Information Brochure and other details please visit the institute website **<https://www.nith.ac.in>**

Dean (Academic)

Bapu gets a glow-up



Workers polish a statue of Mahatma Gandhi near Mantralaya in Fort ahead of Gandhi Jayanti celebrations today.

BHUSHAN KOYANDE/HT PHOTO

On Day 1, confusion rules over BMC's 14-ft slum demolition plan

Osama Rawal

osama.rawal@hindustantimes.com

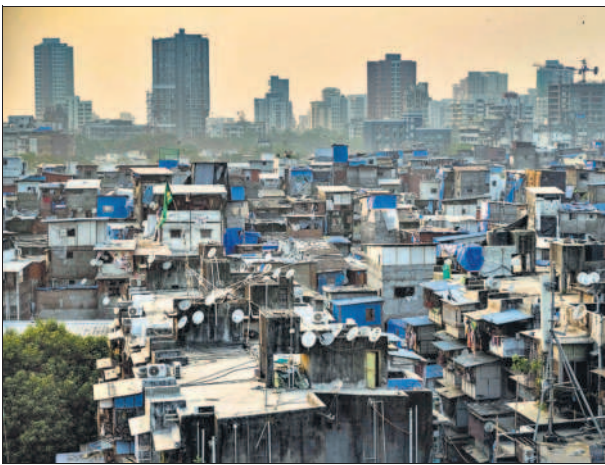
MUMBAI: On the day the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) was scheduled to launch a three-month drive to demolish unauthorised slum structures exceeding 14 feet, the administration denied ever announcing the initiative, casting doubt over its future.

Initially announced on September 19, the proposed drive aimed to target 39,111 structures citywide between October 1 and December 31.

Driven by safety concerns following recent tragedies like the Kurla landslide and Mankhurd building collapse, the drive faced immediate political push-back.

On Thursday, as operations were expected to commence, civic officials distanced themselves from the plan. Devendra Singh, Joint Commissioner (Vigilance)—who was named in the initial press release as the officer guiding the drive—stated, "There was no special drive announced." When pressed regarding the official release, Singh directed inquiries to Public Relations Officer (PRO) Tanaji Kamble, who could not be reached for comment.

Over the past ten days, delegations from the BJP, Congress, and Shiv Sena (UBT) met Municipal Commissioner Ashwini Bhide to demand a halt to



Initially announced on September 19, the proposed demolition drive aimed to target 39,111 slum structures citywide between October 1 and December 31.

HT ARCHIVES

the demolitions. Although sources indicate Bhide appeared receptive to their pleas, the civic body issued no formal revocation of the September 19 release.

This administrative ambiguity has left field officers confused.

Officials reported that while routine demolition actions continue, no large-scale operations occurred on Thursday, and senior personnel remain uninformed regarding the status of the drive.

Trivan Kumar Karnani, founder of the Mumbai North Central District Forum (MNCDF), said the confusion reflected poorly on the civic

administration. "Those opposing the drive must also take responsibility, when an untoward incident happens. All those who are battling against the drive and buckling under pressure, must be criminally charged," he said.

Advocate Faiyaz Alam Shaikh, president of the Govandi New Sangam Welfare Society, who is opposing the drive said, "Although the drive did not take place today, there is still no written assurance from the civic body. Its stand remains hazy and there is no clarity on what happens next." BMC chief Bhide could not be reached for comment.

State plans trauma centres every 100 kms to curb accident deaths

Work underway on app/website that will help crash victims, responders locate, book ambulances

Shashank Rao

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The state government is considering setting up trauma care centres every 100 kilometres along state and national highways, with an eye on curbing deaths due to road accidents. A proposal to this effect was mooted during a recent multi-department joint meeting on road safety, officials said, after data collated by the transport department showed that 56,000 people had died in 129,000 road accidents across the state over 43 months spanning January 2023 till July 2026, at nearly 43 fatalities per day.

Alarming numbers

129,000

Number of road accidents in state over 43 months (Jan 2023 till July 2026)

56,000

Number of people who died in these accidents

43

Avg deaths/day in accidents across state

MITIGATION PLAN

• Trauma care centres every 100 kilometres along state and national highways

• Procurement and deployment of 80-100 ambulances at high-risk locations, black spots

DEPLOYMENT AREAS

• Mumbai-Pune Expressway

• Samruddhi Mahamarg

• Highways in the Konkan region

• Remote tribal routes

Data: Transport department

"We are planning trauma care centres along with faster and smoother availability of ambulances which could be life-saving during the 'golden hour'," said an official from the transport department who is privy to the discussions.

'Golden hour' refers to the first hour after an accident, which is extremely critical for the treatment of injured per-

sons. Officials said the transport department is now focusing on strengthening the emergency response mechanism to ensure that injured victims receive prompt medical assistance.

As part of these efforts, the department will procure 80-100 ambulances, which will be deployed at high-risk locations and black spots along the Mumbai-Pune Expressway, the Sam-

ruddhi Mahamarg, highways in the Konkan region and remote tribal routes. The ambulances would be procured under the state's Road Safety Fund, and used for stabilisation of injured crash victims and transportation of victims to the nearest trauma facility.

Sources in the transport department said the government has begun working on an

app/website which will display real-time information on availability of ambulances and nearest hospitals and help crash victims and first responders book ambulances for a fee in case of emergencies.

"Information on hospitals will be integrated into the platform, and private ambulance operators will be encouraged to register themselves on it," an official said. "Ambulances registered on the platform will be required to have essential first-aid and medical facilities along with services of doctors and nurses."

Sources said the transport department already has data on ambulances registered with different regional transport offices (RTOs) across the state. The app/website would pool in this information and aid delivery of immediate first aid to accident victims and their transportation to hospitals within the shortest possible time.

SIT to probe Purnekar murder; six, including two women, detained

Kaptaan Mali and Saurabha Kulshreshtha

letters@hindustantimes.com

THANE: The Thane police have formed a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the murder of Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Pradeep Purnekar, even as six people, including two women, have been detained for questioning, police said.

The SIT will be headed by deputy commissioner of police Amarsinh Jadhav and comprise two assistant commissioners of police, an inspector and a sub-inspector, said Thane police commissioner Ashutosh Dumbre.

The police also questioned Shiv Sena corporator and former Thane mayor Meenakshi Shinde and her husband, Rajendra Shinde, on Thursday, after Purnekar's son, Ram, alleged that they were behind his father's murder due to a political rivalry.

When contacted, Meenakshi denied the allegations. "I am not in the city and have neither visited the police nor received any notice to record my statement. The allegations levelled against me and my husband by the Purnekar family are baseless and have been made in haste. If they have any evidence, they should provide it before making such allegations," she said.

Pradeep Purnekar, a vibhag pramukh (division head) of the Shiv Sena (UBT), was shot and stabbed to death inside his office in the Manpada area of Thane on



Vijeta Purnekar, widow of the deceased Pradeep Purnekar, sits with his photo at their home in Thane.

PRAFUL GANGURDE/HT PHOTO

September 29. Five people have been booked so far—Papaya Shinde, Santosh Kanauiya, Nitesh Pawar, Nikhil Yadav, and one unidentified person.

On Thursday, police said that six other people, including two women, have been detained for questioning. Four of the five men booked in the case are still absconding, although the police have seized two two-wheelers used by the assailants to flee after the attack.

Only one arrest has been made so far—Papaya Shinde, a former aide and close friend of Purnekar. According to police, Papaya was present in Purnekar's office when the attack took place and took the injured leader to hospital. Investigators, however, suspected his involvement after finding that he was unhurt

despite four to five rounds being fired. Ram has also alleged that Papaya conducted a ruse of his father's office a day before the attack.

Santosh Shirke, a supporter of Purnekar, said Papaya was Purnekar's childhood friend and had been like a family member to the Purnekars. "He, however, joined the rival Meenakshi Shinde group before the TMC elections held in January this year," Shirke said.

In a letter submitted to the crime branch on Wednesday, Ram also alleged that a woman who was present at the crime scene could have played a role in the killing and sought an inquiry into her possible involvement. It isn't clear if the woman is among the two detained by the police for questioning.

Ram further alleged that two of the suspected assailants, Santosh Kanojia and Nitesh Pawar, had visited the locality for four days before the attack to play cards.

Uddhav meets Purnekars

Meanwhile, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray met the Purnekar family in Thane on Thursday and assured them of the party's support, according to people familiar with the matter.

During the meeting, Purnekar's family members told Thackeray that the timely filing of the charge sheet would be crucial in ensuring justice. They also sought his support in ensuring that those responsible for the murder are brought to justice, the people said.

Thackeray assured the Purnekars that his family and the Shiv Sena (UBT) would stand firmly with them in their fight for justice. "We will not rest until the killers and masterminds behind the murder are punished," he said.

Earlier, during a meeting with Shiv Sena (UBT) vibhag pramukhs (divisional chiefs) on Wednesday evening, Thackeray indicated that the party would adopt an aggressive approach regarding the case. He asked local leaders and party workers in Thane to stand firmly with the Purnekar family and oppose any pressure from the rival Shiv Sena camp led by deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde.

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Air Intelligence Unit (AIU) of Mumbai Customs has seized 7 kg of suspected ketamine, valued at around ₹21 crore in the illicit market, at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport and arrested a passenger who was bound for Phuket.

On September 30, AIU officers intercepted the passenger while he was attempting to board a flight to Phuket, following specific intelligence inputs. He and his baggage were off-loaded for a detailed examination, which led to the recovery of 7 kg of a substance that tested positive for ketamine in preliminary testing. Ketamine is classified as a psychotropic substance under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, 1985.

The passenger was arrested under the relevant provisions of the NDPS Act. Further investigation is underway to determine the source of the substance and identify any possible links to an international drug trafficking network.

HC: TAKE DOWN AI DEEPFAKES OF SAMANTHA RUTH

Karuna Nidhi

karuna.nidhi@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Thursday directed social media platforms to take down objectionable content featuring actor Samantha Ruth Prabhu, including AI-generated deepfakes, fake pornography, merchandise and advertisements that allegedly used her name, image, likeness and other aspects of her identity without permission.

A single-judge bench of Justice Milind Jadhav observed that Prabhu had made out a "very strong prima facie" case for granting interim relief.

"The material on record clearly shows that the plaintiff's personality rights, publicity rights, and moral rights are violated by creation of morphed, deepfake and superimposed contents comprising the morphed image, photographs and videos," the court said. "Her personality rights and publicity rights are protected by Article 19(1)(a) (right to freedom of speech and expression) of the Constitution of India."

The court added that the right to life and personal liberty, including the right to privacy, are protected by Article 21 of the Constitution of India, and that the actor's right to live with dignity has been affected by the AI-generated deepfakes.

Prabhu said that she had discovered numerous AI-generated deepfake videos, manipulated photographs, merchandise, and other digital content that used her personality traits

without her consent. Some of the content was allegedly misleading, defamatory, explicit or otherwise objectionable.



MMRDA LAUNCHES 24X7 HELPLINE TO MONITOR SAFETY

MUMBAI: The Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) has launched a 24x7 toll-free helpline and centralised dashboard to document and track safety incidents at metro and other infrastructure project sites.

The Safety and Response Coordination Center (SRCC) will enable citizens to report construction-site hazards, inadequate barricading, traffic-management issues, road damage, dust and other project-related concerns by calling 1800-22-8801.

Currently, there is no centralised database capturing accidents, near-misses and safety complaints at MMRDA sites, with several incidents coming to light through posts on social media.

HTC

State must implement slum projects to curb delay: HC

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The Bombay High Court on Tuesday said the state government and other public bodies should implement slum rehabilitation projects on their land, as it will ensure that the projects are not inordinately delayed due to disputes between groups of slum dwellers and rival developers.

Such a move would also ensure the development remains under control of the land owner bodies, the court said.

The court referred to the pending redevelopment of Siddharth Nagar, a slum settlement in Chembur, as "a classic case where the redevelopment of the slum has been delayed for almost 20 years".

"...it is high time that the situ-

ation as brought about in the present proceedings, namely, of inter se conflicts between the societies of slum dwellers and the developer, becomes a relic of the past," a division bench of justices Girish Kulkarni and Dr Neela Gokhale said, ordering the chief executive officer (CEO) of the SRA to decide within six weeks on applications filed by slum dwellers challenging the appointment of Ruparel Buildcon as the developer.

If the CEO or any other statutory authority sets aside the developer's appointment, clause 1.15 of regulation 33(10) of the Development Control and Promotion Regulations (DCPR) should be invoked and the slum scheme should be handed over to the state government, which owns the land. The government must then appoint an architect and developer by following



Slum dwellers' societies could approach the SRA invoking section 13 of the Maharashtra Slums Act, the court said.

HT ARCHIVES

appropriate legal procedures to implement the slum redevelopment scheme, the division bench said.

The court was hearing a petition filed by Ruparel Buildcon after its slum rehabilitation

project in Siddharth Nagar, spread over 66,000 square meters, was stalled by the Secretary, SRA on February 4, 2026.

The slum redevelopment scheme was originally envisaged in 2006, but was delayed

inordinately due to disputes between cooperative societies formed by slum dwellers and repeated litigations. On March 25, 2021, the SRA approved the appointment of Ruparel Buildcon as the developer, after the federation of 33 societies chose the firm.

On August 13, 2021, the SRA approved construction of eight buildings with 3,153 rehabilitation tenements, based on the consent of 823 out of 1,520 slum dwellers deemed eligible for rehabilitation.

The high court held that though slum dwellers had limited right of getting permanent alternate accommodation, they and their societies could approach the SRA invoking section 13 of the Maharashtra Slums Act, which empowers the CEO, SRA to appoint a new developer to take over a slum

Wadia opens doors for adults who've had congenital heart disease since childhood

Hepzi Anthony

letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Bai Jerbai Wadia Hospital for Children, Mumbai's only public charitable superspecialty hospital for kids, on Tuesday threw open its Grown-up Congenital Heart Disease (GUCH) or Adult Congenital Heart Disease (ACHD) clinic meant for follow-up treatment for children who are living with congenital heart disease.

The hospital authorities said the clinic, a first-of-its-kind facility in western India, was meant to be a transition care clinic.

"With major advances in diagnosis, cardiac surgery,

catheter-based interventions, intensive care and neonatal care, many more children with congenital heart disease are now surviving well into adulthood," said Wadia Hospital chief executive officer (CEO) Dr Minnie Bodhanwala. "This has created a new group of patients—adults who underwent surgery or interventions during childhood and now require specialised lifelong cardiac follow-up."

Around eight to ten babies out of every 1,000 are born with heart ailments. Wadia Hospital, which treats over 1,000 children with congenital heart ailments annually, currently has about 15 to 20 adult congenital patients taking follow-up treat-



Wadia Hospital currently has about 15-20 adult congenital patients availing follow-up treatment.

HT

ment.

The new GUCH/ACHD clinic is intended not only for these adult patients but also for the

much larger group of adults with congenital heart disease who may have discontinued follow-up on reaching adult-



Childhood surgery or intervention does not always mean that the heart will never require attention again

DR KSHITIJ SHETH, paediatric cardiologist, Wadia hosp

hood. The clinic expects to see a load of at least 90 to 100 patients per year to begin with. "Congenital heart disease is a condition that begins at birth, but the need for cardiac care may continue well beyond

childhood," said Dr Kshitij Sheth, paediatric cardiologist at Wadia Hospital. "Childhood surgery or intervention does not always mean that the heart will never require attention again, and adults may have residual issues or develop recurrent ones related to previous surgeries or interventions."

For patients who have undergone cardiac surgery or catheter-based treatment during childhood, the previously documented medical history is particularly important. "It provides a defined pathway for patients transitioning from paediatric to adult-oriented cardiac care," said Dr Hetan Shah, adult cardiologist at Wadia Hospital. "Continuity of

care is one of the most important objectives of the clinic. A patient's previous diagnosis, operation, catheter intervention, imaging and complications provide extremely valuable information for managing them as adults."

Dr Bodhanwala said she expected the clinic to progressively identify and bring back patients who require lifelong surveillance. "These are children who survived because of advances in paediatric cardiac care," she said. "Now, as they grow into adults, it's our responsibility to ensure that they do not fall through the gap between paediatric and adult medicine. This is the philosophy behind this initiative."

MAHANAGAR GAS ANNOUNCES CNG PRICE HIKE OF ₹1/KG IN CITY

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Compressed natural gas (CNG) prices in Mumbai rose by ₹1 per kg on Thursday, taking the price to ₹89 per kg and adding to the operating costs of autorickshaw and taxi drivers already grappling with rising expenses.

Mahanagar Gas Ltd (MGL), which supplies CNG in Mumbai and neighbouring areas, attributed the increase to a sharp rise in the cost of imported regasified liquefied natural gas (RLNG), amid continuing volatility in global energy markets linked to the crisis in the Middle East.

In a statement, MGL said international developments had pushed up the prices of both domestically produced gas and imported RLNG, which are linked to international benchmarks.

A significant portion of the gas used for CNG is sourced through imported RLNG, resulting in higher input costs for the company.

MGL said the ₹1-per-kg increase was being implemented to partially offset the rise in input costs and ensure continued supply of CNG.

The latest hike follows a ₹2-per-kg increase in July, when the Mumbai CNG price was raised from ₹86 to ₹88 per kg. With Thursday's revision, the price has now reached ₹89 per kg.

The increase is expected to put further pressure on autorickshaw and taxi operators, as well as other commercial vehicle owners who rely heavily on CNG.

MGL supplies CNG to more than 1.3 million vehicles through a network of over 500 stations across its operating areas. The company also supplies piped natural gas (PNG) to around 3.2 million households. On Wednesday evening, senior members of the Petrol Dealers' Association in Mumbai and CNG pump owners said they had received intimation from MGL about the price revision.

MGL operates across Mumbai, Thane, Raigad, Ratnagiri, Latur and Dharashiv, as well as Chitradurga and Davangere.

8 Pune-based students on study tour drown at Diveagar beach

Students ventured into a restricted part of the sea and were unable to gauge the current, rescuers say

Vicky Pathare and Sameera Kapoor Munshi
vicky.pathare@hindustantimes.com

PUNE: Eight 16-year-old students of a Pune-based private college drowned at Diveagar beach in Raigad district on Thursday while on an educational trip, raising questions over safety arrangements during the excursion.

The incident occurred around 5.30pm when some students ventured into a restricted portion of the sea and eight of them were swept away as they reportedly failed to gauge the depth and strength of sea currents. Their classmates and teachers raised an alarm, following which local residents and water sports operators launched a rescue operation.

The eight students whose bodies were recovered were Tan-



Local residents gathered outside the institute on Thursday after learning about the incident from media reports.

may Dattatray Vahile, Sumeet Bharat Ahire, Pranav Ramdas Bansode, Kaiwalya Satish Wasankar, Rajveer Yuvraj Vahile, Yash Kiran Wankhede, Soham Tukaram Bhandwalkar and Kaustubh Sandeep Dond – all students of the Alandi-based Winners Academy.

The eight deceased were part of a 48-member group which was on an educational trip to Raigad Fort and Shrivardhan,

according to a notice issued by Winners Academy on September 23. Officials from Raigad police said the group comprised 42 students from classes 11 and 12 (25 boys and 17 girls), and six teachers.

Bhau Maruti Salunkhe, owner of Mahakali Water Sports which operates sporting activities on the beach, said he was alerted after some of the students started drowning and immedi-

ately initiated a rescue operation with his team.

"When someone came running and told me that children were drowning, I immediately went into the sea with my team. We pulled the children out, but unfortunately, all of them had died," Salunkhe said.

The stretch where the students drowned was approximately six feet from the coastline, and access to the area was restricted following monsoon rains. "Even devotees were not allowed to enter this area during Ganesh visarjan," Salunkhe said.

Police and administrative officials reached the spot after being alerted about the incident and took the bodies of the deceased to the primary health centre at Borli Panchatan for post-mortem.

Raju Sonawane, deputy superintendent of police, Raigad, said the deceased students did not know how to swim. The police are yet to record the statements of the deceased's parents and institute officials, he added.

Institute blamed

According to a notice issued by Winners Academy on Septem-

ber 23, the academy had obtained prior written consent for the trip from all concerned parents/guardians, and students had been instructed to follow disciplinary rules.

But Alandi resident Sandeep Naikare accused Winners Academy of mishandling the incident and shirking on safety arrangements. "The institute had taken consent from parents before the trip. If the same level of diligence had been followed during the trip, perhaps these children would still be alive," he said.

As local residents gathered in large numbers outside the institute on Thursday, Alandi resident Nisar Sayyed said villagers were angry over the lack of communication from the institute.

"No official information was provided to anyone. We learnt about the incident through media reports and then informed the police," he said.

BJP leader and minister Girish Mahajan said educational institutions must take responsibility for students during outdoor excursions. Calls and messages from HT to Winners Academy seeking comment did not elicit any response.

Two held with leopard skin

Abhishek Sharan
abhishek.sharan@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The skin of a leopard destined for the illegal wildlife trade has led to the arrest of two members of an inter-state trafficking syndicate, with the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) recovering the protected animal's hide during an intelligence-led operation in Gondia district.

The DRI's Mumbai zonal unit intercepted the two accused near Purada village on Tuesday and recovered the leopard skin from their possession, officials said on Thursday. The seizure was made under the provisions of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972.

Leopards (*Panthera pardus*) are accorded the highest level of protection under Schedule I of the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972, which prohibits the trade, sale, purchase, possession and transportation of their skins and other body parts.

A leopard skin has previously been reported to command around ₹5 lakh and goes up to ₹1 crore in India's illegal trade, depending on its condition and demand. The hides are sought as luxury décor, wall hangings and carpets, while leopard body parts have also been documented in illegal traditional-



Leopards are accorded the highest level of protection under Schedule I of the Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972.

medicine markets in Asia.

Following the seizure formalities, the two accused and the recovered skin were handed over to the Forest Range Officer, North Deoria Range, Gondia, for further action under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, officials said.

The seizure is the latest in a series of wildlife-trafficking cases involving leopard skins in the region.

In January 2025, the DRI seized a leopard skin from three people in Akola, Maharashtra. In May 2025, its Nagpur unit recovered two leopard skins in Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh, and arrested two people.

Cheaper Egyptian onions worry farmers

G Mohiuddin Jeddy
letters@hindustantimes.com

NAVI MUMBAI: As prices of Maharashtra onions surge amid dwindling stocks, Egyptian onions have made their entry into the Vashi Agricultural Produce Market Committee (APMC), offering some relief to bulk buyers facing higher costs. Two containers holding approximately 60 tonnes of the Egyptian produce recently reached the market. Selling at ₹38-40 per kg, the imported variety provides a cost-effective alternative to local Maharashtra onions, which currently fetch ₹45-50 per kg in wholesale markets and up to ₹70 per kg in retail.

Bulk buyers and commercial establishments drive the primary demand for imported produce, with hotels purchasing around 80% of the consignment.

The prospect has worried onion growers, who fear cheaper imports could erode the gains made on their remaining crop ahead of the next significant kharif harvest, expected in December. "If Egyptian onions are sold cheaper, our local farmers will suffer," said onion grower Mangesh Patil.

Swabhimani Shetkari Sanghatana president Raju Shetti also opposed further imports. "If these onions enter the market, prices will crash again, wiping out the gains farmers have just begun to make," Shetti said.

Maharashtra vs Egyptian onions

Maharashtra onions	Egyptian onions
₹45-50/kg	₹38-40/kg

Taste: Egyptian onions are slightly milder, while Maharashtra onions have the sharper, more pungent flavour preferred in traditional Indian cooking.

Shelf life: Egyptian onions tend to have a longer shelf life.

Best suited for: Egyptian onions are popular with hotels and other bulk buyers, while Maharashtra onions remain the preferred choice for everyday curries and sabzis.

₹146-cr bank fraud: Nod to use statements from related case

Vikrant Jha
vikrant.jha@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: A special court on Wednesday allowed the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to rely on statements of 14 witnesses in a separate but connected case to prosecute fugitive diamantaire and Winsome Diamonds promoter Jatin R Mehta and others over an alleged ₹146.35-crore loss to Canara Bank.

Special judge Nitin V Jiwane permitted the CBI to include the statements of the 14 witnesses, recorded before a mag-

istrate in 2018, in the charge-sheet in the present case, saying recording of their statements afresh would duplicate judicial time and effort.

The CBI had sought the court's permission to rely on statements recorded in a separate case registered in June 2016, based on a complaint by Canara Bank against Mehta, directors of Forever Precious Jewellery and Diamonds Ltd (FPJDL), Haytham Salman Ali Abu Obaidah who represented 13 UAE buyers, and others.

According to the prosecution, Canara Bank had sanctioned fund-based and non-

fund-based credit facilities worth ₹162 crore to FPJDL. The company subsequently defaulted on gold-loan obligations, resulting in invocation of standby letters of credit by bullion banks, and resulting in losses worth ₹146.35 crore to Canara Bank.

The prosecution is one of 16 CBI cases registered between 2014 and 2019 against Mehta, Winsome Diamonds and Jewellery Ltd, FPJDL and others on complaints by different bank consortium members. The court records the alleged fraud across the 16 cases at approximately ₹5,500 crore.

COMPREHENSIVE ANNUAL MAINTENANCE CONTRACT

E-Tender Notice No. KIR-N-2026-K-35 Dated: 29-09-2026. Works tenders through "E" Tendering system for and on behalf of the President of India are invited for the works as detailed below:- **Name of work:** Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract of CEL make MSDAC system at Kumedpur station of Katihar Division. **Tender Value:** ₹57,25,728/-; **Earnest Money:** ₹11,40,000/-; **Date & time of closing of tender:** At 15.00 hrs. & **opening at 15.30 hrs. on 21-10-2026.** The complete information with tender documents of above e-tender will be available upto 15.00 hrs. on 21-10-2026 in the website www.ireps.gov.in

DRM (S&T)/Katihar
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile

S. E. RAILWAY - TENDER

For and on behalf of President of India, the Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.), South Eastern Railway, Kharagpur - 721301 invites e-Tender for the following works **before 15:00hrs.** on the date mentioned against items and will be opened at 15:30 hrs. **Sl. No.1; Tender No.: E-KGP-South-37-2026; Description of work:** Miscellaneous P. Way (Zonal) track works up to 30.09.2028 in the section of SSE (P. Way)/ROP under the jurisdiction of ADEN/BL/SKharagpur(2nd call); **Tender Value (Rs.):** ₹4,65,62,197.28; **Earnest Money (Rs.):** ₹9,31,300.00; **Sl. No.2; Tender No.: E-KGP-South-38-2026; Description of work:** Miscellaneous P. Way (Zonal) track works up to 30.09.2028 in the section of SSE (P. Way)/SFO under the jurisdiction of ADEN/BL/SKharagpur(2nd call); **Tender Value (Rs.):** ₹4,66,07,826.48; **Earnest Money (Rs.):** ₹9,32,200.00; **Tender Document Cost (Rs.):** ₹0.00 for Sl. No. 1 & 2 each; **Date of Opening:** 15.10.2026 for Sl. No. 1 & 2 each; **Completion period of the work:** 24 Months for Sl. No. 1 & 2 each; **Bidding Start Date:** for Sl. No. 1 & 2 from 01.10.2026 and up to 15:00 hrs. on 15.10.2026. Interested tenderers may visit website www.ireps.gov.in for full details/ descriptions/specifications of the tenders and submit their bids online. In no case manual tenders for these works will be accepted. **N.B.:** Prospective bidders may regularly visit above mentioned website to participate in all tenders. (PR-835)

Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission

6th Floor, GIFT ONE, Road 5C, Zone 5, GIFT City,
Dist.: Gandhinagar, Gujarat-382050.
(O) 079 23602000, (F) 079 23602054/55
e-mail-gerc@gercin.org Website: www.gercin.org

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RfP) FROM ELIGIBLE CONSULTANT

Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission (GERC) has issued a Request for Proposals (RfP) from competent/eligible consulting firms to provide consultancy support in scrutiny, review, approval and monitoring Capital Investment Plan and related matters.

For more details, please visit 'Latest News' at <https://gercin.org/news-category>. The last date for receiving proposal is **26.10.2026**. For future announcement, if any, in this regard, please keep referring to the above website.

Sd/-
Ranjeeth Kumar J., IAS
Secretary, GERC

Gift City, Gandhinagar
30/09/2026

खान मंत्रालय
MINISTRY OF MINES

ADMINISTERING AUTHORITY, MINISTRY OF MINES, GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
GPOA Block - 03, Netaji Nagar, New Delhi - 110023

Invitation of Bids for Grant of Operating Rights of Offshore Areas

In exercise of the power of auction conferred by Section 12 of the Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Act, 2002 to the Administering Authority to grant Composite License for Offshore Areas Mineral Blocks in accordance with the Offshore Areas Mineral (Auction) Rules, 2024 as amended from time to time notified thereunder, the Government of India has identified 02 Mineral Blocks of Polymetallic Nodules and Crusts for electronic auction for grant of Composite Licence. The Notice Inviting Tender (NIT) has been published on MSTC e-auction portal and on the Ministry of Mines website. The commencement of sale of tender document has begun on October 01, 2026. Tender document and other details can be accessed on (<https://www.mstcecommerce.com/auctionhome/mlcn/index.jsp>).
CBC 26101/11/0005/2627

राष्ट्रीय ध्रुवीय एवं समुद्री अनुसंधान केन्द्र
NATIONAL CENTRE FOR POLAR AND OCEAN RESEARCH
हेडलैंड सडा, वास्को -द- गामा, गोवा -403804

Director, NCPOR invites online applications from eligible and prospective candidates of Indian National, for filling up of below posts on contract basis at NCPOR:

Sl. No.	Name of the post	Consolidated emoluments (*) (Rs)	Reservation		Total posts	Max. Age.
			UR	OBC		
1.	Officer (Admn./F&A/P&S)	47600 + HRA	04	01	05	50
TOTAL					05	

(*) HRA as applicable (at present @ 20% for the State of Goa)

For eligibility and other conditions applicants may visit our website www.ncpor.res.in. The last date of submission of online application is 30.10.2026 (Friday) by 05:00 pm IST.

Advt No:NCPOR/2026/08 Senior Manager –Head (Administration)

Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority

PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT

Investors whose shares, unpaid dividends, matured deposits or debentures, etc., have been transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority under Companies Act, 1956/2013 can claim refund online.
Please download Instruction Kit for Claimant available on IEPF website (www.iepf.gov.in) under Help & FAQs. Read it carefully and follow the instructions.

How to search unclaimed shares and dividends?

Before filing a claim, investors are advised to check the availability of unclaimed shares or dividends using the IEPFA Search Facility on the MCA21 portal. Log in to www.mca.gov.in > MCA Services > IEPF-related Services > Search unclaimed / unpaid amounts and shares.

How to file the claim?

- Go to IEPF Website (www.iepf.gov.in) > Navigate to services > Click on Refund / Claim refund.
- Register on MCA website (www.mca.gov.in): Create a Login ID & Password in MCA 21.
- Online Filing of IEPF-5 Form: The IEPF-5 Form is to be submitted online and an acknowledgement shall be sent to the registered email-id of claimant along with a pre-filled auto-generated indemnity bond in favour of IEPFA.
- The claimants name and DOB filed in IEPF-5 are PAN validated. The claimant's Demat ID is validated using the PAN, and the account number linked to the Demat ID is pre-filled in the form for refund processing.
- Original Documents to be sent for Company: Courier the complete set of the IEPF-5 documents to the Nodal Officer of the company, along with other supporting documents. All photocopies must be self-attested. The postal receipt should be uploaded under the Pending for Action tab. Only after uploading the postal receipt, the claim appears at company's Nodal Officers dashboard for filing EVR.

General information

On receiving the original documents, the concerned company will verify the claim against their records within 30 days of upload of notice receipt and upload an "E-Verification Report (EVR)" on the MCA portal, indicating either approval or rejection of the claim. Only after the company files the approved by EVR the claim will be processed by IEPFA.

- Claimants shall receive an email notification or a SMS on approval or rejection of their claim on their registered email ID or mobile no.

NOTE:

- Claimants are advised to file e-form IEPF-5, only when all the required documents are available.
- IEPFA acknowledges communication from the verified contact details only, provided by claimants while filing IEPF form 5 online.
- Claimants may approach companies and their nodal officers to rectify discrepancies or file new claim.
- IEPF Authority recommends nomination in Securities to ease the process of transmission of securities in case of unfortunate demise of investor.
- Claimant can raise their grievances by raising tickets on IEPF website under Services-Raise Tickets.

***IEPFA does not support engagement of any broker/agent/middleman for the process of claims refund**

#EkKadamNiveshakKiOar
Toll-Free Number :14453
Call Centre: Monday to Friday|9:30 am to 5:30 pm

www.iepf.gov.in iepf@nic.in iepf@nic.in iepf@nic.in iepf@nic.in iepf@nic.in

For more details

36% voter deletion pleas from single J'khand assembly seat

Vishal Kant
letters@hindustantimes.com

RANCHI: Roughly a third of the 13,000 applications received by the Jharkhand chief electoral officer (CEO) for deletion of names from the electoral roll came from a single assembly seat in the eastern state, data showed on Thursday.

The special intensive revision began in Jharkhand on June 30.

According to data, Jharkhand flagged 4.36 million under logical discrepancies. The last date for logical discrepancy hearing is October 12. September 30 was the last date for filing applications for addition, objections, and claims for names deletion (due to various reasons). The final roll will be released on October 19.

Of the 13,443 applications received for name deletion, 4,790 entries were marked in the Chattra assembly constituency in Chattra district alone, accounting for about 36% of the total. The seat is held by Janardhan Paswan of LJP-R, who won by over 18,000 votes in the 2024 assembly polls.

Only two other districts received over a thousand Form 7, including 1,906 applications in West Singhbhum and 1099 forms in Deoghar. The names deletion applications in the remaining 21 districts are in three digits.

CEO K Ravi Kumar said the data was verified with the Chattra district administration and no anomaly was found. Kumar said more Form 7 would be generated during the verification process in other seats as well.

"It has been verified. There has been no case of bulk applications beyond the prescribed limit. The process is designed so that more Form 7 applications will be generated. Many applications received under Form 8, which are for shifting and rationalisation of booths, would consequently generate automated form 7 entries. Even when shifting or changing a booth, the name must be deleted from the existing booth, which can only be done through Form 7 entries," CEO Kumar added.

A delegation led by Congress media co-incharge Kishore Nath Shahdeo met Kumar earlier this week.

Over 4.4 mn sent 'incorrect info' notices in Hry SIR

CHANDIGARH: As part of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Haryana electoral rolls, over 4.4 million notices have been issued to voters for "providing incorrect information" during the mapping process, with hearings completed in over 4 million of these cases, officials said on Thursday.

More than 4.49 million notices had been issued to electors for providing incorrect information during the mapping process. Of these, hearings in over 4.056 million cases have been completed, while some 435,000 hearings are pending, an official statement issued here said.

The highest pendency is in Faridabad, Karnal and Hisar districts.

The statement said additional chief electoral officer, Haryana, has directed all electoral registration officers (EROs) to ensure that all pending hearings are disposed of within the stipulated time.

She has also directed that the poll panel's guidelines are strictly complied with while passing any order. **PTI**

"We had submitted a memorandum that included a few issues including the one related to the Chattra assembly seat. We sought clarification transparently. We were informed that a major reason for the big jump was due to applications for a change of booth," said Shahdeo. The Jharkhand CEO has also sent a protest to the poll panel for an extension in the period of notices and verifications as well publication of the revised electoral roll. "We are confident that the dates will be extended as a lot of work still needs to be done. All BLOs now have to go door to door to clear all the notices and verify documents," said Kumar.



Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, cabinet colleagues stage protest outside CEO office in Bengaluru on Thursday. @DKSHIVAKUMAR/X

K'taka CEO orders legal action against false Form 7 claims

Arun Dev

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka chief electoral officer (CEO) V Anbukumar on Thursday night ordered election officials to initiate legal proceedings against people who knowingly submit false claims or objections regarding changes to electoral rolls. The order comes as chief minister DK Shivakumar staged a protest alleging an organised effort to remove voters through Form 7 applications during the special intensive revision (SIR).

In a circular sent to district election officers and Electoral Registration Officers in all 224 assembly constituencies, Anbukumar said his office had received reports of bulk Form 7 applications and allegations that some of the applications were not genuine.

"It has come to the notice of this office that there are instances of filing of bulk applications in Form 7 before the EROs. It is also alleged that such forms are not genuine," the circular said.

The CEO directed EROs to take action against applicants who knowingly make false statements or declarations in Forms 6, 6A, 7 and 8 under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950. Such action, the circular said, must follow an inquiry under Rule 20 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

The circular does not link the alleged bulk applications to any political party. It instead instructs election officials to establish through inquiry whether claims or objections were knowingly false before taking legal action.

The directive came hours after Shivakumar and his cabinet colleagues staged a protest outside the CEO's office in Bengaluru. The chief minister submitted a memorandum seeking a criminal case and a detailed investigation into alleged attempts to delete eligible voters through large numbers of Form 7 applications.

Shivakumar alleged that applications seeking deletion of voters had been filed in several constituencies and that some were withdrawn after objections were raised.

"In two assembly constituencies in Ballari, 13,000 Form 7 applications were submitted and withdrawn. In Vijayapura, apart from Babaleswar, 13,000 applications were submitted and withdrawn," he said.

The BJP rejected the allegations. "There is nothing wrong in requesting the Election Commission to verify and delete names suspected to have been added illegally. If the name is correct, the Election Commission will retain it; if it is illegal, it will be removed," state BJP president BY Vijayendra said.

88 OF 97 ELIGIBLE VOTERS DELETED FROM GOA ROLLS RESTORED: CEO

Gerard de Souza

letters@hindustantimes.com

PANAJI: The chief electoral officer (CEO) of Goa on Thursday confirmed that 88 out of 97 voters who were excluded from the final electoral roll following the special intensive revision exercise despite being eligible have been re-included as fresh voters after they submitted Form 6.

The CEO's office in a statement said that of the remaining nine voters, three have been found to be Portuguese passport holders, while six are currently residing abroad.

"Out of the 97 left-out voters, 88 have filled Form 6, which have been accepted," the statement said.

"In respect of the voters who are currently residing outside India, the concerned officials are making efforts to establish and maintain contact with them for further necessary action."

Goa CEO Sanjay Goel also announced the commencement of a "special drive" for the enrolment of left-out and young first-time voters.

"The drive will focus on facilitating the enrolment of left-out eligible citizens as well as young and first-time eligible electors who have not yet been included in the electoral roll. The exercise will be undertaken as part of the process of continuous updation of electoral rolls through house-to-house visits of the BLOs," the statement said.

An Indian Express investigation last month sparked a major controversy over the allegation that 97 verified voters could not be added to the Goa electoral roll because the software did not allow the update to be recorded.

The special intensive revision (SIR) exercise, which concluded with the publication of the final roll on February 21 this year, saw deletion of around 127,000 voters or about 10% of the state's electorate faced a peculiar problem.

{ **APPOINTMENT OF ECs, CEC LAW** }

SC dismisses plea seeking recall of its split judgment

Abraham Thomas

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain an application seeking recall of the order passed by the Supreme Court on referring to a Constitution bench the challenge to the law governing the appointment of the chief election commissioner and election commissioners, asking the petitioner to approach the Chief Justice of India (CJI).

The application filed by Naman Sherstra, one of the petitioners who has challenged the validity of the CEC & ECs (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, was mentioned before justice Dipankar Datta by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan assisted by advocate Vishal Sinha.

Justice Datta told Sankaranarayanan to approach the CJI Surya Kant as he is the "master of roster" and there is also a curative petition that has been filed in this matter. The judge said, "All applications and petitions will be decided by the master of the roster. We will not entertain these matters piecemeal. You approach the CJI."

Sankaranarayanan said that the application needs to be listed as the recall is sought on the

ON SEPTEMBER 23, AN SC BENCH GAVE A SPLIT VERDICT ON WHETHER THE 2023 LAW SHOULD BE REFERRED TO A CONSTITUTION BENCH

ground that one of the judges who heard the matter – justice Satish Chandra Sharma –ought to have recused as his son appears for the Election Commission of India (ECI) before the Madhya Pradesh high court.

On September 23, a bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma gave a split verdict on whether the 2023 law should be referred to a Constitution bench. While justice Datta was of the view that the need does not arise as the challenge to the Act can be considered based on the settled principles laid down by earlier judgments, justice Sharma held a different view. He said that substantial questions on interpretation of Constitution arise in the matter and under Article 145(3), the same should be heard by a bench of at least five judges of the Supreme Court. The two judges passed a common order placing the matter before CJI for

referring the petitions to a Constitution bench. Sankaranarayanan told the court that recall is sought only on justice Sharma's order. He said that the application was filed as a curative will not be maintainable.

The application categorically states that the matter was heard by the bench of justices Datta and Sharma on five occasions. On none of the occasions, justice Sharma disclosed this fact or sought recusal on this ground. Sherstra stated that the fact about justice Sharma's son being engaged as ECI counsel became known from news reports that surfaced two days after the September 23 order.

It sought recall of the order stating, "The question is whether the established circumstances, viewed objectively, give rise to a reasonable apprehension concerning impartiality." However, the application does not seek recall of justice Datta's separate opinion.

The present application is the second plea for recall. A curative petition was filed on Tuesday by Congress leader Jaya Thakur, also a petitioner in the present batch challenging the validity of the 2023 law. The curative plea sought recall on the ground of a "reasonable likelihood of bias," based on the same fact linking justice Sharma's son to the ECI.

2 ascetics' burnt bodies found inside UP temple, land dispute suspected

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

MEERUT: Two ascetics were allegedly murdered on Thursday and their bodies set on fire inside a temple in Uttar Pradesh's Shahjahanpur district where they resided, police said, adding that a local man has been detained for questioning following allegations that he wanted them to leave to establish control over the shrine.

According to police, the incident took place at a Shiva temple in Sutha village, around 70 km from the district headquarters. Villagers noticed smoke rising from the temple at around 7 am on Thursday. The deceased were identified as Gopal Das, 70, and Bihari Das, 60, police said.

Pradeep Singh, the nephew of Bihari Das, alleged that a local

POLICE SAID THE ACCUSED HAS ADMITTED TO KILLING THE TWO AND SETTING THEIR BODIES ON FIRE

man, Sumeet, was responsible for the murders. He claimed that Sumeet had attacked the two ascetics several times in the past.

Superintendent of police (rural) Diksha Bhavre said police received information through the police response vehicle about two ascetics being burnt at the temple. "When Khudaganj police reached the spot, the bodies were found severely burnt. The suspect, Sumeet Singh, has been detained and is being questioned," she said.

The temple caretaker, Shiv Kumar Singh, submitted a complaint in connection with the incident. According to police, Sumeet, a resident of the same village, had returned from jail in August and started spending time with the priests at the temple.

SSP Saurabh Dixit said: "Villagers initially confirmed that Sumeet had, on one occasion, told the two ascetics to leave the place as he is going to stay there. He said that he will have exclusive control over this place".

Prima facie, the police suspect that the incident occurred late Wednesday over a dispute.

During preliminary questioning, Singh allegedly admitted to attacking the priests and setting their bodies on fire, police said, adding that the bodies have been sent for an autopsy.

Ex-WB minister's firm sent ₹30L to Mamata's bank accounts: ED

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday said its money laundering probe into alleged financial irregularities linked to Durga Puja 'preview shows' case found that former West Bengal tourism minister Indranil Sen's proprietorship concern transferred nearly ₹30 lakh to former chief minister Mamata Banerjee through banking channels.

The agency said Sen claimed the payment was made as "royalty." It however, did not explain what the royalty payment was for or attribute any criminality to the transaction in its statement. The disclosure came a day after ED questioned Sen for around 10 hours in connection with the case. The agency had on Tuesday searched 15 premises in Kolkata linked to Sen and his associates.

"...the investigation has revealed that cash of more than ₹3.8 crore was deposited into the bank accounts of Indranil Sen and his proprietorship concern, M/s Octave Records, during his tenure. Also, from the bank account of Octave Records, a sum of nearly ₹30 lakh was transferred via banking channels to Mamata Banerjee, the then chief minister of West Bengal, which Indranil Sen has claimed was paid in the form of royalty," ED said.

The probe relates to alleged financial irregularities involving massArt (Maharirban Road Mass Art), an NGO associated with Sen's wife, Madhuchhanda Sen, which organised Durga Puja "Preview Shows".

ED alleged that the organisers commercialised Durga Puja by selling tickets priced between ₹1,749 and ₹5,499 for preview shows at 24 selected pandals in Kolkata. "More than one lakh tickets were issued in 2023 and 2024," it said, alleging that the proceeds were subse-

Didi hints at more Opposition parties joining INDIA bloc

Saubhadra Chatterji

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday indicated that the INDIA bloc could accommodate more Opposition parties, including the DMK, and that the question of who should lead the alliance would be decided collectively.

In her first press conference in Delhi since the West Bengal assembly elections, Banerjee also demanded the immediate resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, alleging that he had worked to "ensure" the BJP's victory in the state. She said a "change is required in the electoral framework to safeguard democracy".

Banerjee was speaking a day after attending an INDIA bloc meeting in Delhi. Asked whether parties such as the DMK should join the INDIA bloc, she said, "These parties have problems at the local level (with the Congress). In some places they are facing elections. But I am in touch with many parties. When the country is facing

a crisis, our priority should be to save the country."

Banerjee said she has a good relationship with BJD chief and Odisha ex-CM Naveen Patnaik and AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal and had recently met DMK MP Kanimozhi. She also said she had spoken to CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby, a political rival of the Trinamool Congress in Bengal, and that he had sent her a letter that she forwarded to the Congress.

On the leadership of the alliance, Banerjee said, "It has to be decided collectively." "INDIA alliance will continue its unity. We will see how far they (BJP) can go," she added.

Adhir asks Mamata to rejoin Congress

Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury on Thursday made a direct pitch to Banerjee to rejoin the Congress along with her remaining MLAs and MPs. "As she has taken shelter in Congress-led INDIA alliance, she should join the Congress. In Bengal, we would work under you in Congress. No need for any separate entity at this moment," he said.

not all..." Mamata-AITC spokesperson Anirban Banerjee said. BJP spokesperson Sayantan Basu said the allegations were serious and asked the AITC to approach court if it believed them to be baseless.

"I don't believe that Banerjee will take any money from Sen," said Madan Mitra, a rebel AITC leader who joined the Ritabrata Banerjee-led Democratic Trinamool Congress.

NO SC RELIEF FOR TMC ON FROZEN BANK ACCOUNTS

Abraham Thomas

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to provide relief to the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress (TMC) faction on operating four bank accounts frozen in connection with a land allotment probe, saying the Calcutta High Court is considering the matter. The high court heard arguments and scheduled the matter for hearing after the Puja holidays.

"We refrain from going into the merits of the matter as the issue is being considered by the high court. We are not inclined to interfere except for expediting the hearing of the petition pending in the high court," said a bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale.

The high court is considering the faction's petition for de-freezing. The faction said it needs approximately ₹19 crore a month for daily expenses and it is willing to reduce it to ₹12.15 crore monthly. It also cited the October 6 by-election to two assembly seats.

Senior advocates Abhishek Manu Singhvi and Shobeb Alam, appearing for the faction, told the court that ED had frozen three accounts in a money laundering probe. Singhvi said, "Every day, a political party's oxygen is in paralysis and in a democracy...the only opposition in the state of West Bengal, is being paralysed by the state police."

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta, who appeared for the state, cited serious charges and added that the accounts were frozen based on complaints that Sumit Roy, who is the personal secretary of lawmaker Abhishek Banerjee, deposited a "huge" amount of cash (₹35 crore).

Mounting clamour ousted Warring?

Saubhadra Chatterji

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Congress leadership told the party's Punjab unit chief, Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, to stand down after feedback gathered by newly elected AICC general secretary in-charge Sachin Pilot over the past three weeks, people familiar with the matter said on Thursday.

Pilot, who replaced Bhupesh Baghel on September 5, held a series of discussions with state leaders and MPs. A majority of the party's seven Lok Sabha MPs from Punjab and several senior state leaders sought a change of guard, prompting the party leadership to begin an exercise to find a new state chief who could maintain social and regional equilibria and work alongside Charanjit Singh Channi, the only Dalit chief minister of Punjab till date.

A senior Punjab leader said Warring's position became unten-



Amarinder Singh Raja Warring

able when the Congress replaced Bhupesh Baghel and brought in Sachin Pilot to get the state unit into shape.

Punjab heads into state elections early next year. In 2022, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) won a landslide victory, securing 92 of the state's 117 seats. The Congress, which was in power, won only 18 seats, and Sukhbir Singh Badal led the Shiromani Akali Dal was confined to just three seats.

Unlike Baghel, who backed Warring and could not meet Channi, Pilot met both Channi and Warring, along with other senior leaders, to maintain bal-

ance in the organisation. "I had a cordial meeting with Channi and he has assured me that he will offer his full support to the party's efforts for the election." Pilot had told HT in an interview.

In his report to the Congress leadership after getting the feedback, Pilot pitched for change in the state leadership, a stand that was in sharp contrast to the report that Baghel presented to the leadership in July this year. At the time, Baghel had virtually ruled out a change of guard.

Asked about the party's change in stance, Pilot told HT on Thursday, "In politics, it's never too late to change."

Former Union minister Vijay Inder Singla, who is from the Bania community, is seen as a front-runner to replace Warring.

"A Hindu face can secure temporary peace in the Punjab unit. Channi would be comfortable after Warring's exit and Jatt Sikhs (the most influential section of the

Sikhs in Punjab) won't have any trouble," a Punjab lawmaker said.

Singla could help bring about a truce between the warring factions in the run-up to the state polls. "If Singla is appointed as the Punjab unit head, then Leader of the Opposition in the Punjab assembly, Partap Singh Bajwa and Sukhbir Singh Randhawa, the latter is close to Channi, are set to get more responsibilities. As the face of the Jatt Sikhs in Punjab, Bajwa and Randhawa have to reach out to the community."

Strategic calculations also favour Singla's prospective appointment due to regional balance. Channi and Singla are from the Malwa region while Bajwa belongs to the Majha region. "Singla can attract the Bania voters in Malwa, the largest electoral region with 69 seats. The Banias primarily control the agricultural trade in this region and have deep links with the farmers," said a third MP.

{ **INTERVIEW** } SANJIV PRAKASH SHARMA, RETIRED ACTING CHIEF JUSTICE OF RAJ HC

‘Should get to cross-examine justice Mehta’

Pulkit Bhardwaj

letters@hindustantimes.com

JAIPUR: Sanjiv Prakash Sharma, who recently retired as acting chief justice of the Rajasthan high court, in an interview to HT rejected the allegations levelled against him by Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta, terming them as "completely fabricated" and driven by "personal jealousy". Edited excerpts:

How do you respond to Justice Mehta's allegations?

His remarks were those of a layman rather than a Supreme Court judge. Whatever Justice Mehta has said was a deliberate act of conspiracy. To my knowledge, not a single allegation made by him has been found to be true.

What could have prompted him to level allegations



against you?

Might be simple personal jealousy. In 2011, both of us were elevated as senior advocates. I was elevated without moving an application; the entire full court selected me to become a senior advocate. He had applied, of course. And I am a first-generation lawyer...and he comes from a reputed judicial family. Both of us were made senior advocates together, and when the issue came for elevation, he saw to it that I didn't become (chief justice).

What are your concerns about the circulation of the letters?

He (Mehta) described the correspondence as confidential while himself sharing it with the Bar Council along with a press note. This reflected a lack of faith in the chief justice of India.

Justice Mehta has accused you of pressuring other judges by citing your proximity to CJI Surya Kant.

If a function is being held at my place, will I not invite the CJI or receive him? But how can it be claimed that I was close to CJI Surya Kant? On what basis did he (Mehta) presume this? I have not practised with him (Kant). He does not belong to my state. He has only looked at my work in Punjab, when I was chairman of the Chandigarh Judicial Academy. How is he (Mehta) connect-

ing me to the CJI?

How do you assess the lawyers' strike against you?

...For 11-and-a-half months into my tenure as the acting CJ, there was not even a single strike in Rajasthan, but he (Mehta) instigated them (lawyers). It doesn't matter. They didn't confirm me as chief justice; it was a stroke of luck that I got a chance to be the acting CJ of Rajasthan. And I took it as an opportunity to do something better for Rajasthan.

How has the episode affected you?

The episode has not saddened me professionally... but it has deeply hurt me personally. I've sent a letter to the CJI citing that I should be given an opportunity to cross-examine Justice Mehta. What are his grounds that I have doubtful integrity?

{ FIRST JUDGE FROM 9-MEMBER BENCH TO DO SO }

Justice Nagarathna starts writing Sabarimala order

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Justice BV Nagarathna has become the first judge on the nine-member constitution bench to start writing the judgment in the long-pending Sabarimala reference, setting the stage for a verdict that could redefine the Supreme Court's approach to religious freedom, judicial review and the "essential religious practices" doctrine.

The development assumes significance as Justice Nagarathna was the only woman judge on the bench that heard the 16-day marathon proceedings and had, during the hearings, expressed views on several of the core constitutional questions arising from the dispute, including the role of the essential religious practices test.

The nine-judge bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant had reserved its judgment on May 14 after hearing arguments on the constitutional questions referred to it following the 2018 Sabarimala verdict.

Besides the CJI and Justice Nagarathna, the bench comprises justices MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joyimalya Bagchi. To be sure, other members of the nine-judge bench are also free to write separate opinions.

The reference originates from the Supreme Court's September 2018 judgment, by a 4:1 majority, allowing women of all ages to enter the Sabarimala temple in Kerala. The verdict had held that the exclusion of women between the ages of 10 and 50 from the temple could not withstand con-



Justice BV Nagarathna

stitutional scrutiny.

The subsequent review proceedings led to the larger constitutional reference, with the court deciding to examine broader questions concerning the relationship between Articles 14, 25 and 26 of the Constitution, the scope of judicial review of religious practices, the meaning of religious denomination and the extent to which courts can employ the essential religious practices doctrine.

Justice Nagarathna's authorship is particularly noteworthy given her own record of speaking independently in Constitution Bench matters.

She was also the lone dissenter in the Supreme Court's 2023 demonetisation verdict, holding that the Centre could not invalidate the entire series of ₹500 and ₹1,000 notes merely through a notification and that the exercise ought to have been undertaken through legislation.

She was also the sole dissenting judge in the nine-judge Constitution Bench verdict on the Centre and states' legislative powers over industrial alcohol,

differing with the majority on important aspects of the scope of the states' power under Entry 8 of List II of the Seventh Schedule.

Her dissenting voice was also significant in the 2024 nine-judge constitution bench judgment on mineral taxation, which examined whether royalty payable under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957, was a tax. The majority held that royalty was not a tax but a payment made by a mining lessee to the state for the right to extract minerals, and consequently held that states could impose taxes on mineral rights. It also held that mineral-bearing land could be treated as "land" under Entry 49 of the State List, permitting states to levy tax on such land.

But Justice Nagarathna disagreed, holding that royalty under the MMDR Act was itself a statutory tax on mineral rights and that mineral-bearing land could not be subjected to another layer of state taxation. She held that the constitutional taxation entries were mutually exclusive and that allowing both the parliamentary levy under Entry 50 and a state levy under Entry 49 would result in double taxation. She also cautioned that overlapping state taxes could fragment the country's fiscal policy and encourage unhealthy competition among states. The position taken in her dissent has acquired fresh relevance with the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, which clarifies that royalty under the 1957 law is itself a tax on mineral rights, leaving no scope for states to impose additional levies under Entry 49 or Entry 50.

The Sabarimala proceedings themselves saw Justice Nagarathna engage closely with the competing claims over religious autonomy and constitutional scrutiny. During the hearings, she suggested that the essential religious practices doctrine could have a limited role as an aid to determine whether a practice was genuinely religious, rather than operate as a test for denying constitutional protection to a religious practice.

She also questioned whether the original petition challenging the Sabarimala custom was maintainable at the instance of people who were not themselves devotees, while examining the constitutional basis for judicial intervention in matters of faith.

The judgment she has now begun writing will therefore be closely watched for the manner in which the bench resolves the difficult questions that have surrounded the reference for nearly seven years.

The 2018 Sabarimala verdict itself had an important dissent from another woman judge, Justice Indu Malhotra. While then CJI Dipak Misra and justices RF Nariman, AM Khanwilkar and DY Chandrachud formed the majority that struck down the exclusion of women between the ages of 10 and 50, Justice Malhotra differed.

Thus, nearly eight years after Justice Malhotra stood alone in dissent against the judgment opening the Sabarimala temple to women of all ages, another woman judge on the Supreme Court is now writing the judgment arising from the larger constitutional examination of the very questions that emerged from that verdict.

Freeze vehicle services over traffic fines, says SC

Utkarsh Anand

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed states and Union territories (UTs) to freeze online and other vehicle-related services, including renewal of registration, issuance of fitness and pollution-under-control certificates, ownership transfers and even renewal of driving licences, where traffic fines remain unpaid, as part of a nationwide push to make electronic enforcement of road-safety laws more effective.

A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan, in an order released on Thursday, also directed that vehicles with outstanding e-challans be blacklisted on the central Parivahan portal, blocking their sale or transfer, while no centre should be permitted to issue a PUC certificate until pending traffic fines are cleared. In cases involving multiple violations, authorities have been told to suspend renewal of the driving licence and take steps to suspend an existing licence.

The bench said merely issuing thousands or lakhs of e-challans served little purpose unless authorities were able to recover the fines. The court was informed that about ₹49,194.05 crore was outstanding against e-challans issued over a period of time, of which ₹26,175.05 crore had been recovered so far.

It emphasised that authorities had to work at the "ground level" having regard to the ground realities, and directed: "What is expected of the authorities insofar as effective implementation of recovery of fine etc. is concerned is to freeze the online services for vehicles which have outstanding amounts. The Authorities shall bar from renewing registration certificate, issuing duplicate registration certificate and also shall not entertain any request for updating owner's address etc. The authorities shall also deny fitness certificate until all pending traffic fines are entirely cleared and further there should be blacklisting of the vehicle concerned on the Parivahan Portal." For multiple violations, the

Key directions

₹49,194cr	E-CHALLANS PENDING RECOVERY NATIONWIDE	₹26,175cr	AMOUNT RECOVERED SO FAR
• Freeze registration renewal, duplicate RC and address update • Fitness certificate to be denied until fines are cleared • Pollution certificate not to be issued over unpaid fines • Authorities to take steps to impound vehicles when e-challans remain unpaid		• Blacklist vehicle to prevent sale or transfer on Parivahan portal • Renewal of driving licence to be suspended for repeat violators • Five or more violations in a year can trigger action against licence • States and UTs told to implement MoRTH's electronic monitoring SOP on highways and major roads	



court held, the driving license shall be suspended from renewal and measures shall also be taken to suspend a license already in force. "What is most important is that no Centre should be permitted to issue PUC certificate," the order added.

The order came in a 2012 road-safety case in which the bench has been monitoring implementation of the Motor Vehicles Act and Central Motor Vehicles Rules for nearly 14 years. The judges expressed concern that directions could continue to remain on paper if authorities failed to implement them on the ground.

Electronic enforcement

The court further directed all states and UTs to forthwith implement the Standard Operating Procedure prepared by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways on October 28, 2025, and comply with Section 136A of the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, read with Rule 167A of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules.

The provisions require electronic monitoring and enforcement of road safety through technologies such as speed cameras, CCTV cameras and speed guns. States and UTs have been asked to notify e-enforcement sites, finalise procurement, deployment and

calibration of enforcement devices, while the National Road Safety Board has been directed to monitor the implementation.

Underlining that electronic enforcement could not end with the generation of an e-challan, the court directed random checking of vehicles and said that if a vehicle was found to have an e-challan that had not been honoured, authorities should take necessary steps to impound it.

The bench also took note of an amended Rule 2(25), brought into force in 2026, under which commission of five or more offences or contraventions under the Motor Vehicles Act or Rules in a one-year period constitutes an act of nuisance or danger to the public.

Compliance on ground

The bench's concern over implementation was particularly evident in relation to Delhi. It asked whether its directions issued on September 15 had been complied with and was informed by amicus curiae and senior advocate Gaurav Agrawal that, despite his September 19 communication to the Delhi chief secretary, there had been no response.

The directions concerned pedestrian safety on Mathura Road near the Delhi High Court and the National Zoological Park,

including functional pedestrian signals, synchronised red lights, speed-limiting measures and electronic enforcement.

The court directed the Delhi chief secretary to file a compliance report and warned that if the directions were not complied with, the chief secretary would have to personally appear before the bench on the next date.

The bench, noting that it had spent almost a year issuing directions in the matter, said it had put an "unusual question" to the amicus – whether the effort had yielded positive results on the ground.

It has now asked the amicus to prepare a comprehensive chart of all directions issued by the bench, specifying the date of each direction, the time granted for implementation, its current status and the amicus's remarks. State counsel have been asked to provide information sought by the amicus through interrogatories.

Overloaded vehicles

On overloading, the court directed authorities to ensure that the suggestions placed before it are acted upon, including preventing an overloaded transport vehicle from proceeding beyond the point of detection until the excess load is removed.

The application before the court pointed out that overloading increases braking distance and the risk of brake failure, tyre blowouts and rollovers, while also reducing steering control and vehicle stability.

The proposed enforcement framework includes integration of weigh-in-motion and weighbridge systems with toll-management and electronic enforcement systems so that action against overloaded vehicles cannot be defeated merely because a vehicle is registered in or moves into another state.

Footpath policy

The bench also sought a more comprehensive report from the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) on implementation of its Universal Footpath Policy of May 26, 2023.

{ IN THE APEX COURT }

No relief for Ilaiyaraaja in copyright case

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to interfere with a Delhi High Court ruling that music composer Ilaiyaraaja did not own the copyright in the lyrics and sound recording of the popular song "En Iniya Pon Nilave" from the Tamil film Moodu Pani, holding that the rights in the sound recording vested with music label Saregama.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran declined to entertain Ilaiyaraaja's challenge to the high court's May orders, which had dismissed his pleas against earlier rulings upholding an injunction in favour

of Saregama.

The dispute arose after Vels Film International Ltd recreated "En Iniya Pon Nilave" for its film "Aghathiya", claiming to have obtained the necessary rights from Ilaiyaraaja. Saregama objected to the use of the recreated version, asserting that it owned the copyright in the original sound recording by virtue of an assignment from the film's producer.

Senior advocates CA Sundaram and Swathi Sukumar appeared for Ilaiyaraaja. Saregama was represented by senior counsel Mukul Rohatgi. The Delhi High Court, in its earlier proceedings, held that Ilaiyaraaja retained copyright in the musical work — the tune or composition, but not in the sound



Ilaiyaraaja

recording or the lyrics of the song. It also held that he could not have assigned to Vels Film International rights that he himself did not own.

The division bench had affirmed the injunction granted by a single judge restraining the use of the recreated version of the song. It held that the copyright in the sound recordings of Moodu Pani, including "En Iniya Pon Nil-

ave", had vested with RCA, the original holder, and was subsequently transferred to Saregama under a February 1980 agreement. "Without a licence, or permission, from SIL, therefore, VFIL could not have exploited any of the sound recordings contained in the film Moodu Pani, including the sound recording relating to the song En Iniya Pon Nilave," the high court had said.

Ilaiyaraaja had argued that as the composer and author of the musical work, he remained the first owner of copyright in the composition. The single judge rejected the contention and granted an injunction in favour of Saregama, after which Ilaiyaraaja moved the Supreme Court.

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ELECTORAL OFFICER, MAHARASHTRA

Special Intensive Revision 2026

Specially for those whose names are not in the voter list

At Your Polling Station

Special Voter Registration Camps

Last Date for Submission of Application

12 October

October 2026

Saturday	Sunday	Saturday	Sunday
3	4	10	11

VOTER REGISTRATION

Special Voter Registration Camps

New voters who have completed 18 years of age can also fill Form No. 6 (along with the declaration).

You can verify whether your name is included in the voter list or not.

Necessary changes/correction applications can be submitted.

Persons who have received a notice can submit documents as proof.

Online

voters.eci.gov.in

ECINET Mobile App

Offline

Polling Station / Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) Office

Voter Helpline No : 1800 22 1950

Chief Electoral Officer Maharashtra

ceo_maharashtra

CEO Maharashtra

CEO_Maharashtra

Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC)

(A Government of India Enterprise)

4th National Call for Proposals under E-YUVA Scheme

Empowering Youth for Undertaking Value Added Innovative Translational Research

BIRAC'S E-YUVA FELLOWS

Upto **150 Under Graduate** pursuing students shall be supported to undertake entrepreneurial projects

**1st and 2nd year UG students are encouraged to apply*

BIRAC'S INNOVATION FELLOWS

Upto **27 Post Graduate or Postdoctoral** students shall be supported to undertake entrepreneurial projects

Salient Benefits

Fellowship and Annual research grant for biotech entrepreneurial projects

Incubation support under any 9 E-YUVA Centres and mentoring by BioNEST Bio-incubators

Integrating young minds into the biotech ecosystem

Application Submission Starts

1st October 2026

Apply Online

www.birac.nic.in

Closes on

31st October 2026 (17:30hrs)

FOR ANY QUERIES, PLEASE WRITE TO:

Dr. Chhaya Chauhan, Chief Manager & Incharge-Incubation | sped4@birac.nic.in

Ms. Harshita Bawsar, Officer-Incubation & ED | user-038@birac.nic.in

Corporate Buzz

GUJARAT LAUNCHES SINGLE WINDOW PORTAL FOR FILM SHOTS

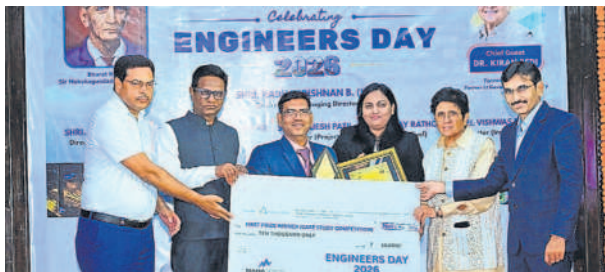


Gujarat Tourism took an important initiative to establish Gujarat as a leading cinematic tourism and film-shooting destination in the country. On the occasion of World Tourism Day, the Single Window Cinematic Portal was officially launched by Deputy Chief Minister of Gujarat Harsh Sanghavi. Developed by Tourism Corporation of Gujarat Ltd (TCGL), the portal aims to make the process of obtaining necessary permissions for film shooting in Gujarat more simple, streamlined and convenient for filmmakers.



WESTERN RAILWAY TO LAUNCH SURAT-UDAIPUR VANDE BHARAT

To boost connectivity between Gujarat and Rajasthan, Western Railway decided to introduce Vande Bharat Express between Surat and Udaipur. The introduction of the Surat-Udaipur Vande Bharat Express marks a significant milestone in Indian Railways' efforts to provide modern, semi-high speed, safe and comfortable travel. Train No. 26903 Surat – Udaipur Vande Bharat Express will depart from Surat every Monday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday, Saturday & Sunday at 06:10 hrs, and will reach Udaipur at 13:40 hrs, the same day. The train will run from October 4, 2026.



HUMANITY IS THE HIGHEST FORM OF ENERGY, SAYS DR KIRAN BEDI

Engineers should first and foremost work as human beings, keeping humanity at the centre of their professional approach. "I am a human being first, and I must think about how my skills can be used to make people's lives better. This, in turn, contributes to the development of oneself, one's family, society and ultimately the nation," said Dr Kiran Bedi, India's first woman IPS officer and former Lieutenant Governor of Puducherry. Dr Bedi was speaking during an interaction organised by Maharashtra State Power Generation Company Ltd (MAHAGENCO) on the occasion of Engineers' Day.

HDFC BSE REITS INDEX FUND OPENS FOR SUBSCRIPTION



HDFC Mutual Fund announced that it re-opened the HDFC BSE REITs and Commercial Real Estate Index Fund post its recent NFO. The fund is an innovative offering designed to provide investors with access to India's growing commercial real estate ecosystem through an investment route. The fund aims to track the BSE REITs and Commercial Real Estate Index, a first-of-its-kind benchmark that provides exposure to listed REITs alongside select real estate companies with rental income-linked business models.

KVIC CHAIRMAN COMMENDS LIJJAT PAPAD WOMEN ARTISANS



Manoj Goyal, Chairman, Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC)—under the Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, Govt of India—addressed the women artisans of Shri Mahila Griha Udyog Lijjat Papad at an event held in Sion (East), Mumbai. As the chief guest, KVIC Chairman applauded the work of the women artisans and highlighted the significant role played by organisations like Lijjat Papad in advancing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of 'Vocal for Local' and 'Atmanirbhar Bharat'.



GEOJIT APPOINTS CJ GEORGE CHAIRMAN, JONES GEORGE MD

Geojit Financial Services Ltd, one of India's leading investment services companies, appointed CJ George as its Executive Chairman and Jones George as Managing Director, effective October 1, 2026, as part of its long-term succession plan. The transition was approved by the Board of Directors during the meeting of the board, based on the recommendation of the Nomination and Remuneration Committee. The transition marks the next phase in Geojit's evolution, with the company continuing to build on the strong foundation established over the past 39 years, while preparing the business for its next phase of growth.

SKILL BUILDS WHAT CAPITAL CANNOT: ANAND AGARWAL



The greatest structures in human history were not built by capital or technology alone. The pyramids of Giza, the temples of Hampi, the intricate carving and detailing of the universal symbol of love, the Taj Mahal. Each of these was the product of skilled human hands, trained over years, guided by knowledge passed down through generations, said Anand Agarwal, Managing Director, Ceratec Group.

Note: This section features information shared by organisations and does not constitute editorial content.

Transport & Road Safety Department
Transport Commissioner, Parivahan Bhawan, Sakhar Marg, Jaipur, Rajasthan - 302005
Tel. Number - 0141-2740021/2850600
E-Mail ID:- transport.pollution@rajasthan.gov.in

File No. F.23(32) Pari/PC/CAQM & SE/2020 **Date:**

Corrigendum-2

Bids invited for SERVICE CONTRACT TO PROVIDE 24X7 DIGITAL SOLUTION TO IMPLEMENT MANDATORY POLLUTION UNDER CONTROL CERTIFICATE (PUGC) CHECKING AT FUEL STATIONS AND CNG STATIONS IN NCR REGION OF RAJASTHAN STATE FOR 60 MONTHS are invited from interested bidders up to **12.10.2026 at 18.00 PM**. For amendments refer corrigendum on the procurement portal (<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> or <http://sppp.raj.nic.in>) of the state, and <https://transport.rajasthan.gov.in/content/transportportal/en/transport.html> departmental website.

SPPP UBN:- TRN2627SLOB00020 Dated 18.08.2026

E-Proc No. - 2026_TRANS_590331_1 Dated 19.08.2026

DIPR/C/17127/2026 **Transport Commissioner**

PSPCL Punjab State Power Corporation Limited
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER/CIVIL DESIGN & CONST.
E-4, SHAKTI VIHAR, PSPCL, PATIALA-147001

Sub: Entlistment & short listing of Architectural Consultants/Firms for New Modern Multistorey Office Building at Hall Gate Complex, Amritsar.

Applications are invited, to reach this office by 05.00 PM on or before 02.11.2026, for enlistment and shortlisting of Architectural Consultants/Firms having requisite experience and expert manpower for comprehensive architectural and allied engineering consultancy services including layout planning of offices and furniture, architectural and structural design and drawings, preparation of interior and exterior design with ECSCB Compliance for the proposed RCC framed New Modern Multistorey Office building comprising of G+3 floors and one basement with provision of lifts, with covered area of approx. 85,000 sq. ft. in around 2-acre plot. The project is proposed to be completed within 2 years. For Detailed tender notice including eligibility conditions please refer to www.pspcl.in from 07.10.2026, 09:00 AM onwards.

Note:- Corrigendum and addendum, if any will be published online at www.pspcl.in.

RO No. 1079/12/2026/27/15822 **C943/26**

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)

OPEN E-TENDER (SINGLE PACKET SYSTEM) INVITATION NOTICE

Name of Work: Supply, Erection, Testing & Commissioning of Service Lift and Passenger Lift at Executive Club, Konkarnail Vihar, Seawood, Sector-40, Nerul, Navi-Mumbai (MH)- 400706. **Notice No: KR/CO/EL/T/22 Dtd: 01/10/2026. Completion Period: 90 days. Estimated Cost: ₹ 35,72,034/- Excluding GST. Earnest Money/Bid Security Deposit: ₹ 71,450/- Last Date & time for Online Submission of Tender: 16/10/2026 up to 15.00 Hrs. Opening of Tender: On 16/10/2026 at 15.30 Hrs. Amendment/ Corrigendum if any, would be hosted on IREPS website only. Submission of Tender Document : Through IREPS. Manual Tender Documents shall not be accepted.**

OFFICE OF THE ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER PHED REGION SAWAI MADHOPUR
(Ph 07462-220062), E-mail: acephed_swm@rediffmail.com
(TAN NO. JDHA17553E)

No. ACE/PH/SWM/2026-27/NIT/1577-1591 **Date: 25.09.2026**

Notice Inviting Tender (e-NIT No. 01/2026-27)

On behalf of the Government of Rajasthan Tenderers are hereby invited from eligible bidders for following works as per criteria mentioned in the detailed NIT/Tender documents available on website <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, "www.rajwater.gov.in", "<http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>". Tenderers are to be submitted online in electronic format on website "<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>" as per prescribed schedule.

NIB	PHE2627A2783
UBN No.	PHE2627WLR050908

Sd/- (Ramniwas Meena)
Additional Chief Engineer
PHED Region Sawai Madhopur
(TAN NO. JDHA17553E)

DIPR/C/16767/2026

कार्यालय जयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, जयपुर
क्रमांक - राजधानी 24811080 दिनांक - 30/09/2026

ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या :- जोन दक्षिण-बी/01/2026-27

जयपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, जयपुर की ओर से प्राधिकरण एवं राजकीय विभाग में नियमानुसार उपयुक्त श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निविदा कार्यों हेतु मुहरबंद निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। इन कार्यों की अनुमानित लागत, निविदा वेबे जाले तथा प्राप्त करने की दिनांक, निविदा शर्तें आदि का सम्पूर्ण विवरण वेबसाइट www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, www.jodhpurjda.org, www.sppp.raj.nic.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

NIB Code :- JOD2627A0197
UBN No. :- JOD2627WS0800366, JOD2627WS0800367
कन.संवाद/सी/26/11072 अतिरिक्त अतिरिक्त (दक्षिण-बी)

OFFICE OF THE ENGINEER-IN-CHIEF, WATER RESOURCES, ODISHA, 32001/962/2627
SECHA SADAN, BHUBANESWAR

Corrigendum-01/ RFP CE MKS 01 of 2026-27

e procurement notice No. RFP CE MKS 01 of 2026-27
Bid Identification No. RFP CE MKS PRD 01 of 2026-27

Sl. No.	Description	Previously date mentioned in RFP	Revised Date
1	Bid Start Date(Online)	23rd September 2026 from 11 AM	3rd October 2026 from 11 AM
2	Bid Due date(Online)	27th October 2026, up to 5:00 PM	6th November 2026, up to 5:00 PM
3	Last date for receiving queries (To the official mail ID- celmbbsr@yahoo.co.in.)	1st October 2026 up to 11:00 AM	12th October 2026 up to 11:00 AM
4	Pre-Bid Meeting-hybrid mode (in the conference hall of DOWR, Secha Sadan)	5th October 2026 at 3:30 PM (link will be shared through email in due course of time)	16th October 2026 at 3:30 PM (link will be shared through email in due course of time)
5	Authority response to queries latest by	9th October 2026 at 5:00 PM	22nd October 2026 at 5:00 PM
6	Opening of Technical Bids	28th October 2026 after 11:00 AM	7th November 2026 after 11:00 AM

All others are remains unchanged.
(Further detail conditions can be seen from the Govt. website www.tendersodisha.gov.in)

Chief Engineer Basin Manager
Mahanadi Kathajodi System, Bhubaneswar
OIPR - 32001/325201/26-27/0010

CENTRAL RAILWAY NAGPUR DIVISION E-TENDER NOTICE

E-TENDER NOTICE No. NAGP-TDC-ELECT-2026-27-01R Dtd: 25/09/2026

E-Open Tender is invited: Description: "Provision of Wall mounted Industrial type Air Conditioner Unit in S&T installations in connection with 3rd Line work at various location in ET-NGP section of Nagpur division Central Railway" **Estimated Cost of the work: ₹ 3,59,49,053.56/-, Cost of Tender Form: NIL.. Address of Office:** Office of the Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer (Construction), 3rd Floor, DRM's Building, Kingsway, Central Railway, NAGPUR-440001. **Earnest Money Deposit: ₹ 7,19,000.00/-, Completion Period: 09 Months, Closing of Tender: On 29/10/2026 15:00 Hrs, Date and Time of Opening of Tender: On 29/10/2026 15:30 Hrs., Web Address:** For details of Tender notice visit: www.ireps.gov.in
Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer (Construction) 445 Nagpur
Traveling with dangerous and explosive goods is a punishable offense

Government of Odisha "a" Procurement Notice WORKS DEPARTMENT 34001/920/2627
Bid identification No. CCEKC - 09 / 2026-27
e-mail : ccekeonjharpcw@rediffmail.com / sekcpwd_keonjhar@yahoo.com
Letter No. 5506 Dt. 30.09.2026

- No. of the work: :- 3 number of Road Works
- Estimated cost: :- Rs. 105.36 Lakhs to Rs. 229.95 Lakhs
- Class of Contractor: :- 'B' & 'A' Class
- Period of completion: :- 12 (Twelve) Calendar Months
- Date and Time of availability of Bid document in the portal: :- From 11.00 Hours of 15.10.2026 to 17.00 Hours of 03.11.2026
- Last date / Time for receipt of bids in the portal: :- 17.00 Hours of 03.11.2026
- Date of opening of Bid from Portal: :- 11.30 Hours on 04.11.2026
- Name and address of the officer inviting Bid: :- Chief Construction Engineer, Kendujhar (R&B) Circle, Kendujhar-758001.

Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal "<http://tendersodisha.gov.in>"

Chief Construction Engineer
Kendujhar (R&B) Circle, Kendujhar
OIPR - 34001/34033/11/26-27/0013

WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY E-TENDER NOTICE Dtd: 29/09/2026

E-tender is invited from reputed and experienced contractor by the undersigned for and on behalf of the president of India, for the following:-
Tender No. ELECT-GEN-BPL-T-33-2026, Name of Work :- Part(A) BINA-Construction of New Running Room (G+2) having 60 Rooms with 2 bed each at east side of station, Site Area 3701.76 sqm. Part(B): Itarsi Construction of New Running Room (G+1) having 30 Rooms with 2 bed each at Old ADEN office, Itarsi (GF & FF area-989.24sqm X 2 =1978.48sqm). Part(C): ET Capacity Augmentation of New Guard Running Room at Itarsi, 6 Rooms with 2 bed each, kitchen and dining at Itarsi. Part(D): Bhopal-Construction of New Running Room (G+1) having 35 Room with 2 bed each near BPL lobby at BPL (GF and FF -47.72m X 12.55m X 2 =1197.76 sqm). **Completion Period: 06 Months. Estimated cost in Rs.: 20041167.71, Earnest money in Rs.: 400800.00, Date and Time for closing of tender: 19/10/2026 11:00 Hrs.** The details of complete tender documents and its related information may be seen at <https://www.ireps.gov.in> and notice board of this office. Manual offer, for above said tender is not acceptable and if any manual offer submitted, will not be considered. Corrigendum / Updating, if required, will be uploaded on website, it may be seen at above said URL and notice board of this office, till the date of closing of tender. The Contractor must read the all tender documents as uploaded on IREPS along with all conditions carefully to know the eligibility for participation in tender and documents etc. to be submitted along with offer. Only documents uploaded on IREPS along with offer by the contractor will be considered for finalization of tender.
For Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) West Central Railway, Jabalpur
सख्त मार्ग अनिवार्य एक कदम सच्चाई की ओर

Industries Department Government of Rajasthan Jaipur Short term e-Tender Notice 34/2026-27
UBN No. : RS12627WS0800030

On behalf of Government of Rajasthan, e-tender document is for selection of an agency for undertaking complete exterior & interior designing & fabrication works of the Rajasthan State Pavilion (Hall 3 (GF)) at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi for India International Trade Fair-2026 under two-part bid system on turnkey basis (**Quality and Cost selection method**).

The proposal should be conceived in accordance with the theme of the Fair "Vikas aur Virasat".

The details of e-tender documents can be downloaded from Rajasthan Government e-tender portal <https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> or <https://industries.rajasthan.gov.in/rajsico> and should be submitted online on eproc.rajasthan.gov.in only

Last date for submitting e-Tender	: 15.10.2026 up to 3.00 PM
Date of opening of e-Tenders	: 15.10.2026 at 5.00 PM

Contact Person: Sh. Harsh Sharma, Director Pavilion, First Floor, Udyog Bhawan, Jaipur-302005, Phone No. 0141-2227824, 9214009956
DIPR/C/17128/2026

SLUM REHABILITATION AUTHORITY, BRIHANMUMBAI
No. SRA/ADM/Desk-IT-2/858/2026 **Date: 30 SEP 2026**

ADVERTISEMENT FOR FILLING UP THE POSTS

Applications are invited for the following contractual posts on purely temporary basis and on contract basis for 11 months at the Slum Rehabilitation Authority, Brihanmumbai Office.

Sr. No.	Designation of the Post	No. of Posts	Qualifications
1	Legal Consultant/ Legal Assistant	3	1) LLB. 2) Minimum 05 years of experience of working as a Legal Assistant or such similar position in Government office, Semi-Govt. office, Govt. undertaking, Corporation etc. Or Practising Advocate. 3) Person with good knowledge of Maharashtra Slum (Improvement, Clearance & Redevelopment) Act, 1971. 4) Proficiency in operation of Computer (MS Office).

* Applicants should submit their applications within 8 days from the date of publication of this advertisement.
* After scrutiny of the applications received, only eligible candidates will be called for interview.
* The right to increase, decrease or cancel the posts is reserved while implementing this recruitment process.

Sd/-
(Dattu Nawale)
Secretary Slum Rehabilitation Authority, Brihanmumbai

Administrative Building, Prof. Anant Kanekar Marg, Bandra (East), Mumbai-400 051.
Tel.: 022-2656 5800/6912 5800 Email: info@sra.gov.in

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indra Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

No. F.6(444332)JDA/G.Store/Scanning Work/2026/D-329 **Dated : 28-09-2026**

NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB No.: JDA/G.Store/18/2026-27

Online Bids are invited For "Scanning Work" up-to 21.10.2026 Till 6:00 PM. Estimated cost of Work is **Rs.1,50,00,000/- (One Crore fifty Lacs Only)**. The last date for Applying for Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is 21.10.2026 by 06.00 PM. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document Available on jda.rajasthan.gov.in www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. (UBN No:- JDA2627WSRC00338)

To participate in the bid, bidder has to be

- Registered on JDA website jda.rajasthan.gov.in, For Participating in the bid, the Bidder has to apply for the bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, Online Only.
- Registered on e-Procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission

Deputy Commissioner (Store)
Raj.Sammwad/C/26/10999

JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Indra Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

NO. JDA/EST./ACCT./2026-27/D-1212 **Date : 28.09.2026**

NOTICE INVITING E-BID
NIB No.: DC(Admn.)-04/2026-27

Online Bids are invited for Providing service of Various Types Like Labourers (Supervisor Highly Skilled) security Men (Skilled), Unskilled Labour Services. estimated yearly cost one year of which is Rs. 26.00 Crore. (UBN No:- JDA2627SLOB00334) The last date for applying Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is up-to 05:00 PM of 21.10.2026 . Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or the State Public Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in

To participate in the bid, bidder has to be

- Registered on JDA website www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in, For Participating in the bid, the Bidder has to apply for the bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, Online Only.
- Registered on e-Procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission

Deputy Commissioner (Admn.)
Raj.Sammwad/C/26/10997

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA 25001/1255/2627
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER RURAL WORKS CIRCLE: SUNDARAGADA
AT/PO-SANKARA, SUNDARAGADA-770020, E-mail address-serw_sundargarh@yahoo.com

No. Tender Online — RWCCESNG — 30 of 2026-27, Letter No - 5436 Dtd. 30.09.2026

e-Procurement NOTICE

- Type of the Work: Roads (MMSY & DMF)
- Class of Contractor: As specified in the column-6 of the Annexure
- Time of Completion: As specified in the column-5 of the Annexure
- Detail Projects: As per Annexure attached
- Estimated Cost: As specified in the column-4 of the Annexure
- Other details:

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No	Availability of tender On-line for bidding	Last Date & Time of seeking Tender Clarification	Date & Time of Opening of Tender	Technical Bid	Financial Bid
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Chief Construction Engineer, Rural Works Circle, Sundaragada	RWCCESNG-30 of 2026-27	08.10.2026 11:00 AM	23.10.2026 5:00 PM	22.10.2026 5:00 PM	26.10.2026 11:00 AM	Will be intimated separately

Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersodisha.gov.in

Chief Construction Engineer
Rural Works Circle, Sundaragada
OIPR - 25001/25133/11/26-27/0046

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

DGCA FACELIFT

The report lists gaps in technical expertise, manpower, enforcement and the timely resolution of safety findings. It singles out the shortage of technical staff as one of the most pressing.

The regulator has had a long history of misses and inadequate regulatory action. In March, the parliamentary standing committee on transport, tourism and culture said recent incidents, among them the June 2025 crash of Air India flight AI171 that killed 260 people, pointed to "systemic rather than episodic failures" in India's aviation safety architecture. It found 787 of DGCA's 1,630 sanctioned posts vacant. A DGCA audit from January 2025 to February 2026 had found recurring technical defects in 377 of 754 aircraft, half of those it checked.

When IndiGo cancelled more than 2,500 flights in three days last December, the regulator gave the airline sweeping exemptions from crew-fatigue norms. Pilots had won those norms after 13 years of litigation that began with the 2010 Mangalore crash, which killed 158 people.

DGCA later sacked four inspectors who oversaw IndiGo and removed a key officer, and MoCA ordered an internal inquiry "to identify and implement systemic improvements within the DGCA".

The IndiGo episode was followed by lapses at smaller operators, which surfaced only after accidents. DGCA grounded four aircraft of charter operator VSR after the January crash at Baranati that killed then Maharashtra deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar. In July, the ministry pulled up the regulator over officials' undisclosed family links with airlines it oversees.

The overhaul recommendation comes ahead of a visit by a five-member team of the US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) to assess India's safety oversight from November 16 to 20. HT reported in September.

In August 2025, the parliamentary committee sought a time-bound plan to give the DGCA financial and administrative autonomy; the ministry replied that direct recruitment by the DGCA was not under consideration. This August, the Federation of Indian Pilots wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking a Civil Aviation Authority in the DGCA's place.

A similar suggestion was tabled in 2011. In May that year, a Parliamentary Standing Committee report on DGCA recommended reviewing the authority

structure to explore reforms that would render the DGCA more agile, granting it greater administrative and financial autonomy commensurate with its regulatory responsibilities.

Under the latest proposed law, a governing board headed by the director general (civil aviation) would run the authority. Its whole-time members would come from the DGCA cadre and its part-time members from the industry, with an advisory committee of industry experts alongside. The DG and whole-time members would be picked through a specialised search-and-selection process and serve five-year terms.

The authority would pay its way through service fees, certification charges, penalties and the passenger levy, all of which its board could revise. "This financial autonomy would shield it from the constraints of government budget cycles and enable it to invest in necessary infrastructure and staffing," the report said. The government could provide grants until the authority became self-sufficient, and the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) would audit its books every year.

The report calls the ₹15 levy, drawn from a ministry study by Centre for Asia Pacific Aviation (CAPA), a "modest charge".

PM LAUDS MACHCHHAR

Israeli officials said on Thursday that no motive had been established and that their initial assessment was that the co-pilot, an Omani national who has not been named, acted alone.

Addressing a function in New Delhi to mark the centenary of the Union Public Service Commission, Modi said Machchhar had shown "remarkable patience, presence of mind, and courage".

"Indeed, as the Prime Minister of Israel stated today, an Indian prevented a 9/11-style tragedy," Modi said. He was referring to the September 11, 2001, attacks, in which hijacked airliners were flown into the World Trade Center and the Pentagon, killing nearly 3,000 people.

Hours earlier, Modi spoke to Machchhar's wife and parents, officials aware of the matter told HT, asking not to be named. He told them Indian missions were providing all possible help to the passengers and crew.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu called it "an amazing act of heroism — of his, of the Indian pilot, of the people who helped them. They stopped a disaster that could have been global." Netanyahu also praised an Israeli passenger who helped subdue the attacker.

President Droupadi Murmu said: "The nation is proud of Captain Smit Machchhar. His

heroic courage and incredible presence of mind have deeply touched us all." Politicians across parties posted messages of praise and wishes for his recovery.

On Wednesday night, the Indian embassy in Riyadh said Machchhar had been admitted to a hospital in Tabuk and was in stable condition. He underwent surgery there, people aware of the matter said. He was moved to the UAE a day later. The Indian mission in the UAE said it remained in close coordination with local authorities on his care.

Two Israeli security officials said Israel's initial assessment was that the co-pilot was likely acting alone, though the investigation was continuing, Reuters reported.

Netanyahu said the attacker was being investigated in Saudi Arabia and that he believed he would be taken to the UAE.

Israel's envoy to the UAE, Yossi Shelley, told Reuters it was too early to draw conclusions. Another Israeli official said Israel was not receiving all the information it sought from the Saudis, and that its intelligence agencies, Mossad and Shin Bet, were also investigating. Saudi Arabia's government media office did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Flight-tracking data from Flightradar24 and ADS-B Exchange, analysed by HT, show the jet was cruising at 34,000 feet over Saudi Arabia when it began to descend at 8.21am SGT time (10.51am IST), about 235km north-east of Tabuk.

Between two readings 37 seconds apart, it fell from 33,225 feet to 18,925 feet, a rate of about 23,000 feet a minute.

SC-ONOE PANEL

against the backdrop of growing concern over the propriety of a parliamentary committee discussing the merits or constitutional implications of proposed legislation with sitting Supreme Court judges when the legislation could eventually come before the court for adjudication.

Sibal, at a press conference on Thursday, said he was "shocked" by the proposed interaction and questioned how the judiciary could accept an invitation from a parliamentary committee when the bills raised issues of "fundamental importance to the polity of this country" and to the working of the Constitution.

"How did the judiciary accept that invitation from the joint committee, knowing full well that this bill raises issues of fundamental importance to the polity of this country, fundamental issues relating to the working of our Constitution?" Sibal asked.

He said Parliament has the prerogative to introduce and consider legislation, with a parliamentary committee examining a bill and submitting its report to the House.

Parliament would thereafter debate and vote on the legislation, while its constitutional validity, if challenged, would be considered by the judiciary. Sibal said he had never encountered an instance in the

country's history of a parliamentary panel holding an interaction with sitting Supreme Court judges on legislation that could subsequently be challenged before the court.

The Supreme Court's communication, however, confined the reason for cancelling the interaction to the view expressed by the CJJ and senior judges that discussing the issue on the administrative side

would not be "expedient or desirable" since the proposed amendment might become a subject matter of judicial review.

The joint committee is examining two bills that seek to facilitate simultaneous elections to the Lok Sabha and state legislative assemblies. The Constitution (One Hundred and Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill, 2024 proposes, among

other things, insertion of a new Article 82A dealing with simultaneous elections and amendments to Articles 83, 172 and 327. The Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2024 proposes consequential changes to facilitate simultaneous elections in the Union territories as well.

Both bills were introduced in the Lok Sabha in December 2024 and referred to the joint

committee for examination. The committee comprises members from both Houses and is headed by Chaudhary.

The committee has conducted consultations with political parties, legislators, constitutional experts and other stakeholders.

It has also consulted former Chief Justices of India, former Supreme Court judges and other legal experts.

CENTRAL RAILWAY
Construction of New BG Railway Line
e-Tender (OPEN TENDER) Notice No. CAOC-08-2026-EPC-INDB-MMR Dt. 30.09.2026
Chief Administrative Officer (Const.), Central Railway, 6th floor, New Administrative Building, D.N. Road, CSMT, Mumbai 400 001, for and on behalf of President of India invites Open tenders through e-tendering on IREPS website (e-tender portal). www.ireps.gov.in (In Two Packet System), from reputed Contractors for the following work: **Name of Work:-** Construction of New BG Railway line from Ch: 273+500 Between Gaspurkhedi (Including) to Ch: 346+162 Dr. Ambedkar Nagar (Excluding) (72.66 KMs) stations including Civil Engineering works (Earthworks, Bridges, Viaducts, Tunnels, Buildings, etc.), Track works, Signaling & Telecommunication Works, Overhead Electrification, Electrical General Services & all other allied works in connection with Mannad to Dr. Ambedkar Nagar (MHW) new BG Rail link project in the state of Madhya Pradesh" in the Central Railway. **Tender Value:-** Rs. 4930,91,59,984.99, **Bid Security:-** Rs. 98,61,83,200.00, **Completion Period:-** 48(Forty-Eight) Months including monsoon, **Date & Time of Opening of Tenders:-** 18.02.2027 at 11:00 Hours, **Availability of Tender Documents and Other Information:-** Tender documents and all other information are available on the IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in. For any additional information/classification contact either on the above address to Chief Engineer (Construction) North, Mob-8828110265 or Dy. Chief Engineer (CJ) BSL-II, Office of the Dy. CE(C)BSL, Central Railway, Near Bhusawal Railway Station, Bhusawal-425201, Mob-8828119254 on any working day between 10.00 hours to 17.30 hrs. 627
Traveling with dangerous and explosive goods is a punishable offence

NAVODAYA VIDYALAYA SAMITI
An Autonomous Organization under
Ministry of Education
B-15, Sector-62, Gautam Buddha Nagar
Noida, Uttar Pradesh - 201309

एफ.5-2(47)कक्षा-9 एवं 11 / 2027 / नविस(लक्षे) / दिनांक : 01.10.2026

NOTIFICATION FOR EXTENSION OF LAST DATE FOR SUBMISSION OF APPLICATIONS FOR CLASSES IX & XI LEST-2027

Online Registration portal for Lateral Entry Selection Test (LEST)-2027 for admission to classes IX & XI for the session (2027-28) was launched on 01.09.2026. The last date of submission of online application is further extended up to 15.10.2026. The candidates may apply free of cost by visiting the following links:
For class IX: https://cbseitms.nic.in/2026/nvsix_9
For class XI: https://cbseitms.nic.in/2026/nvsxi_11

ISSUED BY NAVODAYA VIDYALAYA SAMITI

GOVT. OF N.C.T. OF DELHI
DEPARTMENT OF FOREST & WILDLIFE
OFFICE OF THE DEPUTY CONSERVATOR OF FORESTS
WEST FOREST DIVISION, MANDIR LANE, NEW DELHI-60
E-Mail: dcfwest.gnctd@gov.in

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

An e-tender has been invited for "Creation & 01-year maintenance of 3600 numbers of trees on 3.68 Ha. land at Dholisars, for the year 2026-27, under West Forest Division for the duration of 01 year (Tender Id 2026_DYCFW_299180_1)". In case the tenderer/Bidder has any doubt about the meaning of anything contained in the tender document, he shall seek clarification from the office of the Dy. Conservator of Forests, West Forest Division, Deptt. of Forest & Wildlife, GNCT of Delhi, Mandir Lane, Delhi-110060. The tentative cost of the tendered work is estimated as be is **Rs. 54,48,775/- (Rupees Fifty-Four Lakh Forty-Eight Thousand Seven Hundred Seventy-Five Only)**. The details of submission of bid are as follows:

Date of release of Tender through e-procurement portal of Delhi Govt	29.09.2026 at 06.00 PM
Start date/time for downloading of tender	29.09.2026 at 06.00 PM
Date of Pre-bid meeting	05.10.2026 at 12.30 PM
Start date/time for submission/uploading the tender documents	06.10.2026 at 11.00 AM
Last date/time for submission/uploading the tender documents	20.10.2026 at 10.00 AM
Date and time of opening of Technical Bid	20.10.2026 at 11.00 AM
Date and time of opening of Financial Bid	Will be intimated

The last date of submission of bids is **20.10.2026** up to **11.00 AM**. For any further query, contact the O/o Dy. Conservator of Forests, West Forest Division at Mandir Lane, Delhi 110060.
Website link - <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in/>

Sd/-
DEPUTY CONSERVATOR OF FORESTS
WEST FOREST DIVISION
DIP/Shabdarth/Classified/0235/26-27

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
OFFICE OF THE ADDITIONAL CHIEF ENGINEER,
HIRAKUD DAM CIRCLE, BURLA
(E-mail Id: - se.hdcburla@gmail.com)
No. 3198 Dt. 29-09-26

e-Procurement Notice No. ACE-HDC-05(01-05)/2026-27
Bid Identification No. ACE-HDC-05(01)/2026-27 to ACE-HDC-05(05)/2026-27

1. Type of works	: Improvement to River embankment work under CFM
2. No of works	: Five (05) numbers
3. Class of contractor	: "A" & "B" Class
4. Bid identification No	: ACE-HDC-05(01)/2026-27 to ACE-HDC-05(05)/2026-27
5. Estimated cost	: Rs. 1.90 Crore to Rs. 2.49 Crore
6. Period of completion	: 03 Calendar Months
7. Date and time of availability of Bid Documents in the portal	: Dated:- 05.10.2026 at 11.30 AM to Dated:- 22.10.2026 up to 5.00 PM
8. Last date/ time for receipt of Bids in the portal	: Dated:- 22.10.2026 up to 5.00 PM
9. Date & place of opening of Technical Bid (Cover-1)	: Dated:- 23.10.2026 at 11.30 AM, O/o the Additional Chief Engineer, Hirakud Dam Circle Burla
10. Name and Address of the Officer inviting Bid	: Office of the Additional Chief Engineer, Hirakud Dam Circle Burla (E-mail Id: - se.hdcburla@gmail.com)

1. Any addendum/corrigendum/ cancellation/ erratum of tender can also be seen in the said website.
2. Further details can be seen from Government Website <http://tendersodisha.gov.in>

Additional Chief Engineer
Hirakud Dam Circle, Burla
OIPR - 32001/32044/1/26-27/0004

M.P. METRO RAIL CORP. LTD.
(A Joint Venture of Govt. of India and Govt. of M.P.)
Admin Building, Subhash Nagar Metro Rail Depot, Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh-462023

ADVERTISEMENT FOR RECRUITMENT

Madhya Pradesh Metro Rail Corporation Limited (MPMRL), a joint venture of Government of India and Government of Madhya Pradesh is implementing Bhopal Metro Rail Project & Indore Metro Rail Project in the State of Madhya Pradesh. To meet with the immediate requirement, MPMRL invites applications for the post of

ADVISOR-INTER-DEPARTMENTAL/MINISTERIAL COORDINATION

This Advertisement is only indicative. The detailed vacancy notifications and particulars regarding eligibility criteria, qualification, experience, age limit, mode of selection etc. are available in the Career sections of MPMRL website www.mpmetrorail.com. Please refer Advt. No. 4090/HRD/MPMRL-080/2026, dated 30.09.2026 for more details. Last date for submission of Offline applications for the notifications is **31.10.2026**.
M.P. Madhyam/128329/2026 **MD**

WESTERN RAILWAY
VADODARA DIVISION
CONSTRUCTION OF ROAD OVER BRIDGE (ROB)
E-TENDER NOTICE NO. CPM-GSENGG-BRC-2026-27-01 Sealed Tenders for and on behalf of the President of India are invited by Chief Project Manager (Gati Shakti), Western Railway, Pratapnagar, Vadodara-390 004 for the following works: i) E-Tender Notice No. CPM-GSENGG-2026-2027-01 ii) Name of the work: Vadodara Division: Construction of Road Over Bridge (ROB) including approaches in lieu of LC NO 299 at Km 478/332-34 & LC NO 300 at Km 482/6-8 on Vadodara-Gujarat section. iii) Approximate cost work: Rs. 138,57,64,522.42 [Rupees One Hundred Thirty-Eight Crore Fifty-Seven Lakh Sixty-Four Thousand Five Hundred Twenty-Two and Forty-Two Paise Only.] iv) Earnest Money to be deposited: [Rs. 2,71,15,300/- (Rupees Two Crore Seventy-Seven Lakh Fifteen Thousand Three Hundred Only.)] v) Pre-Bid Conference: 05.10.2026 at 12.00 Hrs. Office of the CPM (Gati Shakti), Vadodara Division, Pratapnagar, Vadodara - 390004. Bid Start Date: 13.10.2026 **Bid Closed date: 27.10.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.** vi) Regarding detailed notice containing cost of tender document (non refundable), EMD, eligibility criteria, Similar Nature of work, detailed tender conditions, please visit www.ireps.gov.in. Manual offers will not be considered. **BRC 253**
Like us on: facebook.com/WesternRly

M.P. BUILDING DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION
(An Agency of Govt. of M.P. Public Works Department)
16 - A, CEDMAP Building, Arera Hills, Bhopal (M.P.)-462011
Telephone No. : 0755-4853297, 0755-4853295, E-mail : proc@mpbdc.mp.gov.in
NIT No.-8415/GM/MPBDC/CW&MISC/26/NIT-90 Bhopal, Date : 01.10.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Madhya Pradesh Building Development Corporation Limited (MPBDC) Bhopal invites online tenders for the following works: -

- Construction of Kanya Shiksha Parisar at Gohparu Dist. Shahdol M.P. (2nd Call) PAC Rs. 2999.36 Lakhs
- Construction work of District Institute of Education and Training COE at Dist. Vidisha M.P. PAC Rs. 1018.35 Lakhs
- Construction work of District Institute of Education and Training COE at Dist. Ujjain M.P. PAC Rs. 985.31 Lakhs
- Construction work of District Institute of Education and Training COE at Dist. Shajapur M.P. PAC Rs. 946.18 Lakhs
- Construction work of District Institute of Education and Training COE at Dist. Shahdol M.P. PAC Rs. 923.54 Lakhs
- Construction work of District Institute of Education and Training COE at Dist. Narsinghpur M.P. PAC Rs. 847.29 Lakhs
- Construction work of District Institute of Education and Training COE at Dist. Umaria M.P. PAC Rs. 819.63 Lakhs
- Construction work of Indoor and Outdoor Sports Complex in Rajendra Nagar Ward No. 37, Bhopal. (2nd call) PAC Rs. 263.32 Lakhs
- Construction of Hockey turf restoration at Rantlal Sports Complex at Dist. Jabalpur M.P. (3rd call) PAC Rs. 106.28 Lakhs
- Purchase of additional 160 KVA D.G. Set for MPBDC office at CEDMAP Building Bhopal (M.P.) PAC Rs. 27.04 Lakhs
- Demolition of dilapidated and old buildings in the campus of Deotalab District Rewa M.P. PAC Rs. 1.36 Lakhs

Detailed NIT and tender documents can be viewed, downloaded and purchased online for from **(05.10.2026 at 18:00 hrs. to 26.10.2026 at 15:30 hrs.)** from website www.mptenders.gov.in The bidders have to submit the Bids online only. from website www.mptenders.gov.in. PAC can vary at the time of uploading of tender document. Any amendment/corrigendum if any will be published on website only, will not be published on newspapers.
M.P. Madhyam/128340/2026 **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

M.P. STATE AGRICULTURAL MARKETING BOARD
26- ARERA HILLS, JAIL ROAD, BHOPAL
Board/Nirman/P.Cell./CGP/2 TPH/26-27/613 Date : 30.09.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Online Lump-Sum Rate E-Tenders are invited from the eligible bidders for **Supplying, Installing, Commissioning, Testing, Operation, Repair and Maintenance of 2 ton per hr. (TPH) Cleaning, Grading & Packaging Plant in 100 APMCs of Madhya Pradesh with all the required amenities and allied structure for it and then maintain and operate it satisfactory for one (1) year from the date of final completion. (Tender Number : 2026_MPSAM_540035) (PAC amount Rs. 2900.00 Lakh)**. The following Tender to be received online up to **05:00 PM on 27.10.2026**. Technical bid documents with EMD & Financial Offer to be received online only as per Detailed NIT. The tender documents can be obtained online on the <http://mptenders.gov.in> as per the Notice Published on the above Portal and detailed information can also be seen on website www.mpmmandiboard.gov.in.
Note:- Any corrigendum in this NIT, if required, shall be displayed only in our above portal regarding any matter included in this NIT or otherwise. Other details of project and locations & key dates can also be seen on our website www.mpmmandiboard.gov.in
M.P.M./128310/2026 **EXECUTIVE ENGINEER (PROJECT CELL)**

Govt. of Bihar

BIHAR STATE POWER TRANSMISSION CO. LTD., PATNA
(A subsidiary company of Bihar State Power (Holding) Company Ltd., Patna)
CIN- U74110BR2012SGC018889
Head Office, Vidhyut Bhawan, Bailey Road, Patna- 800021
Email address- operation.maint@bspcl.bihar.gov.in, Mob. No. 7763817721, Website- www.bspcltcl.in

Tender Notice (NIT) NO.- 43/PR/BSPTCL/2026
(Through e-procurement mode only - www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

Online-Tenders are invited by Chief Engineer (O&M) for the following:-

Description of work	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	E.M.D. (Rs.)	Cost of B.O.Q. (Non-Refundable) (Rs.)	Bid Processing Fee(Rs.)	Contract period
construction of 220/132 kV Transformer Bays (HV & LV sides) along with Transformer Foundations at 220/132/33 kV GSS Begusarai and GSS Motipur, including erection, testing and commissioning of old 100 MVA Power Transformers.	12,37Cr	12,380,000.00	11,800.00	11800.00	12 months from issue of NOA.

Start date of Online Sale of Bid Documents/ request of Bid/ Bid Documents From 11:00 Hrs of 16.10.2026
Date of Pre-bid meeting On 12:00 Hrs. of 05.11.2026
Last date of Online Submission of bid along with Tender Up to 17:00 Hrs. of 11.11.2026
Cost & processing fee After 16:00 Hrs. of 12.11.2026
Date of opening of Techno-Commercial Bid (Part-I) After 16:00 Hrs. of 12.11.2026
Date of opening of price part To be notified after Technical Bid Evaluation (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

Eligibility Criteria, tender documents along with General/Special condition, bids and any corrigendum/ addendum of the tender are available only at website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in

Chief Engineer (O&M)
e-tendering introduced in BSPTCL for tenders above Rs. 25 lacs. For registration log in to www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in and e-Procurement Help Desk Toll free No: 1800 572 6571, Email Id: eproc2support@bihar.gov.in
Working Hours: 8AM to 7PM (All days in week except few selected state holidays).
While participating in e-tendering process, the contractor shall have to get them registered to get user ID, Passwords and digital signature. This will enable them to access the Website: www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in only.
[विवादों के निवारण के लिए लोक अवलोक का काम उनका परस्पर सहायता से याचिक निर्णय प्राप्त करें समय एवं खर्च की बचत करें]

For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
PR. No.012998 (B&C) 2026-27
नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।

Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission
6th Floor, GIFT ONE, Road 5C, Zone 5, GIFT City, Dist.: Gandhinagar, Gujarat-382050.
(O) 079 23602000, (F) 079 23602054/55
e-mail-gerc@gercin.org Website: www.gercin.org

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RfP) FROM ELIGIBLE CONSULTANT

Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission (GERC) has issued a Request for Proposals (RfP) from competent/eligible consulting firms to provide consultancy support in the work of Tariff Orders for FY 2027-28 [Truing up for FY 2025-26, Approval of Revised ARR and Determination of Tariff for FY 2027-28].

For more details, please visit 'Latest News' at <https://gercin.org/news-category>. The last date for receiving proposal is **26.10.2026**. For future announcement, if any, in this regard, please keep referring to the above website.

Sd/-
Ranjeeth Kumar J., IAS
Secretary, GERC
Gift City, Gandhinagar
30/09/2026

HT Classifieds Friday
www.htclassifieds.com

NOTICES

COURT NOTICES

व न्यायालय, श्रीमान् भूमि सुधार उप-समाहर्ता, भागलपुर।
न्यायलक्षण अपील वाद सो- 120/2026-27
मो० सावकोर आलम.....अपीलकर्ता
बनम्
मो० मुशीद शेख उत्तरवादी
नोटिस बानम् :- मो० मुशीद शेख पिता- स्व० छेदी, निवासी ग्राम- बेसा पो-० बौकल, थाना व जिला- बौकल वगमान निवासी- कमला रामन नगर, झे नो- 259, बैसन बाड़ी, मोनवीर चेट्ट, शिवजी नगर, मुम्बई, महाराष्ट्र, पिन- 400043.
बुकि अपीलकर्ता द्वारा यह अपील आपलोगों के विरुद्ध दायित्व किया यह है इस अपील वाद का नोटिस निवाचित डाक से आपलोगों को भेजा गया, परन्तु अपीलार्थ निश्चित तिथि पर उपस्थित नहीं हुए हैं, अब दिनांक 24/10/26 को 10:00 बजे इस अपील वाद में आपलोगों के उपस्थिति हेतु निश्चित एवं समय निश्चित है।
अतः आपलोग उपरोक्त निश्चित तिथि व समय पर न्यायालय में उपस्थित होकर अपना पक्ष रखें, अन्यथा आपलोगों के विरुद्ध एकपक्षीय सुनवाई कर उचित आदेश पारित कर दी जाएगी।
यह नोटिस न्यायालय के हस्ताक्षर एवं मुहर से जारी।
भूमि सुधार उप- समाहर्ता भागलपुर।

For Advertisement Call Manish Shirke 9820748750

CENTRAL RAILWAY
Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract
For and on behalf of The President of India invites Open E-bid in through website www.ireps.gov.in from reputed contractors. **OPEN E-BID NOTICE No. 10/2026 of 30.09.2026 NAME OF WORK:-** Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract of AC package unit if various make fitted on LHB type AC coaches of roof-mounted design of Mumbai division for a period of two years. (E-Tender No.- BB.LG.W.LTT-2026.04), Approximate Cost of the Work:- Rs. 19,81,50,119.29, EMD:- Rs. 39,63,000/-
Validity:- 60 days, Completion Period:- 24 Months, Tender closing date:- 22.10.2026 at 15:00 hrs.
Instructions to bidders: 1. Tender will be opened after closing date. 2. The prospective bidders are requested to visit our website www.ireps.gov.in for more details of tenders & corrigendum, if any. 3. Bidders may participate in above e-tender electronically through our website www.ireps.gov.in only. Submission of manual offers against e-tender is not allowed. Manually, if submitted shall neither be opened nor considered. 4. For further enquiry may contact to Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer (Coaching), Ambedkar Bldg, 1st floor, Central Railway, CSMT Mumbai. 5. This bid complies with Public Procurement Policy (Make in India) Order 2017, dated 15/06/2017, issued by Department of Industrial Promotion and Policy, Ministry of Commerce, circulated vide Railway Board letter no. 2015/RS(3)/779/5 dated 03/08/2017 and 27/12/2017. 628
Traveling with dangerous and explosive goods is a punishable offence



OPINION

The
Hindustan Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

Setting fire to the cracker ban

The apex court restrictions, now relaxed, should have stayed till the industry make cleaner products, with State verification

The Supreme Court has loosened its hold on firecrackers once more. On Wednesday, it cleared “next-generation” *laris*, the chains of crackers that go off one after another, for use nationwide; these were previously banned for spewing excessive emissions than most firecrackers. The court also declined a total ban on crackers, citing the need to accommodate sentiments, and left room for barium-based crackers (barium, when burnt, emits particularly harmful gases) if tests due by October 15 clear them. This is the second such relaxation in a year.

The timing could hardly be worse. Diwali falls on November 8, in the thick of the farm-fire season, when cool, heavy air keeps smoke close to the ground. Last October, the court allowed green crackers in Delhi-NCR after years of a total ban. The Capital then had warm weather and few farm fires on its side, yet the firecrackers still caused the worst Diwali pollution peak since 2021.

At the heart of the problem is a simple fact: firecrackers, green or not, pollute. Green formulations are said to cut emissions by 30-40% per cracker. But the rest still goes into the air, and permitting crackers where none were allowed becomes a numbers game: burst roughly half as many again, and the gain is gone.

Then there is the problem of whether what’s sold as green is even green. The market is rife with conventional crackers passed off as green, boxes stamped “eco-friendly” with no certification behind them, and QR codes bought from licensed makers to dress up unlicensed stock, and there is no laboratory in Delhi that can test what is actually inside.

The cost of these emissions is easy to miss under today’s clear skies and brisk winds. But like clockwork, in about four weeks, the Capital will slide into its annual cocktail of bad air, mixed from farm fires, the city’s own pollution and still weather. Diwali’s firecrackers will add to this at the worst possible moment.

To be sure, past bans were flouted too, people found crackers anyway, and the industry employs thousands of poor workers whose livelihoods deserve weight.

But the crisis is too severe, and the damage to health too grave, to accommodate these concerns. The industry should be helped to make cleaner products, and the state to build the laboratories and checks to verify them. Until then, the restrictions should stay. The right to breathe comes first.

Prudent price support for the farm sector

The central government announced the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for *rabi* (winter season) crops on Wednesday. MSP for wheat, the crop that matters most in terms of actual procurement, has been kept almost flat with an increase of just ₹25 per quintal. Other crops such as pulses and oil seeds saw larger increases.

To be sure, the current government has consistently followed its policy of ensuring at least a 50% return on the all-India weighted average cost of cultivation. The relatively lower increase in wheat MSP therefore also suggests that the cost of cultivation has been flat.

The policy seems prudent for two reasons. One, the government already has excess wheat stocks from the previous season’s procurement and does not really need to procure much more. Two — and this is more important — the real agricultural income story is that the cost of cultivation has remained largely constant despite large inflation in key inputs such as fertilizers because of the ongoing war in West Asia. The cost of cultivation has remained constant because the government absorbed a large part of the commodity price shocks through measures like fertiliser subsidies, which will likely reflect in the budgetary numbers. These two facts make the price policy decisions a pragmatic choice.

With the *rabi* MSP announcement out of its way — it serves as a key incentive for cultivation decisions — the agricultural policy establishment should focus its attention, energy and resources on mitigating the fall out of deficient monsoon rainfall in the country. With the rains being the weakest since 2002, there are bound to be production headwinds from outright crop failure to subdued yields.

Finding the Mahatma in a divided Pakistan



157
YEARS OF
GANDHI

Pakistan has borrowed Gandhi’s name for some of its heroes. At the same time, he rarely gets his due in school textbooks there, having opposed Partition, and thereby, the country’s creation

I have never heard any Pakistani say anything offensive — critical, maybe, but never disparaging — about two Indians: Lata Mangeskar and Mahatma Gandhi. And this is regardless of whether the two countries are at war or at peace. Gandhi — India’s revered Father of the Nation, still fondly called *Bapu* in parts of South Asia — occupies a complex place in Pakistan’s historical, political, and literary memory.

Gandhi’s name is part of Pakistan’s landscape, especially in the Sind province, as it is — expectedly — in India. For instance, Karachi’s zoo was famously known as “Gandhi Garden” before Partition, and continues to be called so despite an official change of name. The plaque may now say National Zoological and Botanical Garden, but the old name is imprinted on the cultural being of the majority of people in the city. Yes, attitudes towards seeing animals caged have undergone a change as the younger generation wants to see animals roaming free. The name, therefore, sticks rather ironically in popular recall, says my friend Aijaz Mangi, a Karachi-based poet.

That we have borrowed Gandhi’s name for our own heroes should underline his impact in the subcontinent, perhaps even beyond. Noted freedom

fighter Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan, who led the non-violent movement against British colonialism in the North West Frontier Province (NWFP), became Frontier Gandhi or *Sarhadi Gandhi*. The stature of this Pashtoon leader, also known as Bacha Khan, in Pakistani socio-political movements was elevated by the halo of Gandhi’s name.

Misken Jahan Khan Khoso became, through his work, the Gandhi of the Thar, the desert that’s not very far from Gandhi’s native village in Gujarat, India. Carrying piles of papers in his *chador*, an ink pot and pen in his hand, Khoso continued to be followed by crowds of poor litigants until his death in 1980. A tireless social worker, Khoso helped the poor, sick, unemployed, and hungry, traversing the length and the breadth of the Thar (on foot, mostly). He was forever knocking on the doors of bureaucrats, judges, doctors — anyone who could help the downtrodden natives of a difficult land. Once jailed under Pakistan’s Goonda Act for siding with the oppressed against local influentials, he fought the fabricated case and was acquitted within six months. A hero to the Thar’s marginalised communities, including Kolhis, Meghwaris, and Bheels, he often

remained hungry while feeding those who had nothing. One of his biggest contributions was the successful campaign to make antivenin available in Thar hospitals. This portrait is only to illustrate that we, in Pakistan, have not handed out the title “Gandhi” for ceremony or flattery, but for genuine selfless service. Neel Kanth, a fellow Thari and a family friend of Khoso, invokes this example to show how Pakistan has found ways to claim Gandhi.

Of course, our relationship with Gandhi has never been simple, and we should not pretend it is. After all, the man opposed the very creation of Pakistan. Because successive Pakistani governments have struggled with establishing a national identity in opposition to India, Gandhi is rarely emphasised in mainstream Pakistani school textbooks. His overt Hindu religiosity was also something that our founding father, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, was openly dismissive of. On the contrary, the Deobandi Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind, which opposed Jinnah and Pakistan, held Gandhi in high esteem. Many Deobandis of Pakistan, despite their ossified religious beliefs, continue to revere the man. But, there is also one Rasool Baksh Palijo. This celebrated human rights lawyer, leftist scholar and Marxist leader of Pakistan, famously blamed Gandhi for “provoking” Jinnah with Hindu religiosity and the slogan of *Ram Rajya*. Ali Ahmad Rind, the editor of *Affairs*, a fortnightly Sindh news magazine in Karachi, notes that Palijo perhaps held Gandhi responsible for Partition by pushing Jinnah against the wall.

For thousands of followers of GM



Hasan Mujtaba

Gandhi, the man and the idea, lives on in Hindustani

What is it about Gandhi — born 156 years ago in a world altogether different from ours, killed 78 years ago in a newly-independent India — that still resonates with the Urdu poet/writer of today?

First, a sampling from some recent works, and then a search for answers.

In a long, lyrical *ghazal*, Nushhur Wahidi speaks of Gandhi as a light that cannot be snuffed out, as a life force that will always show the way, as a treasure that can never be pillaged: *Woh hamesha ke liye chup hue magar ik jahan ko zabaan di/ Woh hamesha ke liye so gaye magar ik jahan ko jaga diya* (He was silenced forever but he gave voice to a world/ He went to sleep forever but he awakened a world).

Writing especially on the occasion of Gandhi’s birth, Kamal Dibaivi speaks with the pride of ownership, that a man such as Gandhi was “ours”: *Watan ke aasman par ek rakshshanda sitara the/ Hamein ye fakhr hai ahl-e-jahaan mein Gandhi hamare the* (He was a resplendent star in the country’s firmament/ We are proud that among all the people in the world, Gandhi was ours).

Nazish Pratapgari seizes upon the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti to exhort his country to remember all that Gandhi stood for: love for fellow beings, peace for all mankind, and, above all, the creed of *ahimsa* (non-violence). And forsaking all the bloodshed, hatred, violence, enmity, and ill-will of past years, the poet urges his people to take a pledge on this special day to replenish and renew: *Phir apne zehnon mein lahkao dosti ka chamani/ Phir apni saanson se mahkao pyaar ka madhubani/ Phir apne kaamon se chamkao sar-zameen-e-watan* (Once again, let the garden of friendship bloom in your mind/ Once again, let the forest of love become fragrant with your breath/ Once again let the soil of your motherland be nourished with your deeds).

To the generations of Indian children who have seen the photograph of Gandhi hanging on a wall, for whom the Father of the Nation is little more than a quaint, smiling, toothless figure in a loincloth, clutching a stick, here’s Ataur Rehman Tariq writing about the country’s collective *mahapita* (great father): *Bachcho tum ne Bapu ki tasveer to dekhi hogi/ Eik nazar mein samjhoge tum un ko budha jogi* (Children, you

must have seen the picture of *Bapu*/ At first glance, you’d have taken him for an old ascetic).

No talk of Gandhi’s life is possible without a mention of his death, the manner in which he was killed. Here’s Gulzar, a poet with a distinctly modern sensibility, presenting a harsh truth in a uniquely modern, straightforward way. Without mincing words, and with great economy of expression, he is saying that just as Gandhi’s legacy lives, so does that other, opposing view that killed him: *Sawa gaz aasmaan odhe huwe sar pe/ Badan par eik langoti lapete/ prarthana le liye nikla thha baahar/ Kisi ne augey badh kar/ Tamancha rakhi diya seene pe yeh keh ke/ Tumhari raaye se sehmata nahi hoon main/ Tamancha chala raha hai —/ Woh raaye marti nahi hai!* (Wearing a yard-and-a-quarter of the sky on his head/ A loincloth wrapped around his body/ He had come out for prayer/ Someone stepped forward and/ Placing a pistol on his chest, said: “I do not agree with your opinion!”/ That pistol is still firing —/ That opinion does not die).

And now for a search for answers as to why Gandhi remains relevant in a world that has changed so dramatically, and not always for the better, since he lived. What is the reason for his enduring appeal?

Charkh Chinoiti offers some clues: *Bapu ne har insan ko insaan samjha/ Bahbuudi-e-har-fard ko iman samjha/ Injeel ko Quran ko aur Gita ko seene se lagaya/ Unhein yaksaaan samjha* (Bapu treated every human being as a human/ Regarded the welfare of every individual as his faith/ Be it the Bible, or the Quran, or the Gita/ He held them to his bosom as equal).

Abrar Kiratpuri, better known as a poet of *hamd* (praise of God) and *naat* (devotional poetry honouring the Prophet), writes a lovely short poem telling us why we should remember this *rahbar* (guide), who showed us the way of *desh-bhakti* (patriotism): *Dosti ka sabaq de gaya/ Mar ke javed woh ho gaya* (He left a lesson of friendship/ He became undying after dying).

That Gandhi is alive and well in the modern writer’s imagination is evident from this very short story by the Hindi writer Asghar Wajahat: so keen is its rapier-sharp insight, so deep the well of belief from which it springs that it gives one fresh reasons to hope.

The spirits come to Shah Alam Camp after midnight. One night, an old man’s spirit comes along with all the other spirits. The old man’s body is naked save for a skimpy loincloth. He wears *chappals* on his feet and holds a wooden staff in his hand. An old-fashioned foot watch peeps from the folds of his loincloth. Someone asks the old man, “Are you too looking for a relative here in this camp?”

The old man replies, “Yes, and no.” The others leave him alone, taking him for a senile old man. The old man walks round and round the camp.

Someone again asks the old man, “Baba, whom are you looking for?”

The old man says, “I am looking for someone who can kill me.”

“Why?”

“I was killed fifty years ago by a bullet. Now, I want the rioters to burn me alive.”

“But, why do you want that, Baba?”

“Simply to tell the world that I was not killed by their bullet, nor will I die if they burn me alive.”

Rakhshanda Jalil is a writer, translator, and literary historian. The views expressed are personal



Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan, who led the non-violent freedom struggle in the North West Frontier Province, became Frontier Gandhi. HT ARCHIVE

Syed of Sind and Bacha Khan of the NWFP, Gandhi holds a place beyond politics — as a mystic and a prophet of non-violence. He becomes someone akin to Gautama Buddha, whose influence is still alive in the ruins of Takshashila. Shaikh Ayaz, the doyen of Sindh poetry, wrote a collection called *Raaj Ghat Tay Chand* (*Moon over Raj Ghat*) and reminded us that the world offers a cross for Jesus and a bullet for Gandhi, even today. Barely a month after Partition, Gandhi said in a prayer meeting, “What the Muslims have done is not good, but what harm has the Koran done?” In the same meeting he said, “I want to go to Lahore. I do not want to go with any police or military escort ... I want to go with faith and trust in the Muslims there. Let them kill me if they want ... Let the Government stop me if they will. But how can the Government stop me? They will have to kill me if they want to stop me. If they kill me, my death will leave a lesson for you.” Clearly, it was this worldview that earned him friends and foes on all sides. Even Shaikh Ayaz once wrote out of frustration, “You have to deal with Gandhi to even ride a donkey.”

For my generation, Gandhi arrived via VHS tape, alongside Oscho’s cassettes and Ben Kingsley’s film. We argued whether an empire fell because a brown man was thrown off a train in

South Africa by the white colonialists.

History is full of such ifs. What if a woman named Kariman had not eloped with a Hindu man in Sindh? Would the Larkana riots of 1927 not have happened? Would identity-based political stances not have hardened? Would a Sindh-born barrister, then, still have launched a movement for a new, Muslim-majority nation? All are in the realm of hypothesis. What is not hypothetical is what Gandhi did in his final days: He demanded that Pakistan receive its share of the assets, the 550 million rupees, and stood against the killing that soaked Partition. Many Hindus of India bristled at this: Why was our Gandhi being generous to them, they probably wondered.

Pakistan isn’t united on Gandhi, a living symbol of unity. In today’s Pakistan, there is a section in politics that still likes to lump Gandhi with the hardliner elements in India, as an existential denier of Pakistan. I muse, therefore, that Nehru’s line about him, “I love the old man but never understood him,” could very well be ours too. Being fully understood by everyone, after all, did not matter to the saint of Sabarmati.

Hasan Mujtaba is a Pakistan-born poet, journalist, and human rights activist. The views expressed are personal

{ DROUPADI MURMU } PRESIDENT

Today, an atmosphere of war and conflict prevails in many parts of the world ... Mahatma Gandhi’s message of peace and non-violence becomes even more relevant



{ FROM THE ARCHIVES }

Gandhiji was a man of God, hence Mahatma

It is a paradox that in spite of my intimate connection with Mahatmaji, he is the one subject on which I feel helpless when I begin to write. A cynicism overtakes me. Secular admirers have heaped their tributes on him for having shown the world a new method of solving conflicts by truth and love instead of by violence. They often call it a technique. As the secularists have understood the Mahatma, a concealed *petitio principii* invalidates the technique. It appears to me that we must get behind love and truth and dive deep till we discover what really can make Gandhiji’s solution a serviceable reality.

Leaders of men abroad have admired Gandhiji as one who developed an effective new technique based on non-violence for struggling against wrong. The very notion that what Gandhiji taught was a technique has led to error and of course disappointment. Non-violence is not a gadget to get what we used to try to get through violence and much trouble, in the pre-Gandhian days, as we get cooking energy from electricity instead of from coal or wood fuel. Mahatma Gandhi’s technique is no doubt the presentation of love and truth in any confrontation against evil. But love and truth are not available in the market. We cannot procure them as we can procure rifles and pistols. They can issue only out of faith in God.

We have changed from animal power to steam and from steam to oil fuel and from oil to electricity. All these variations of energy do not furnish the basis of understanding Mahatma Gandhi’s technique. The moral energy, soul-force as Gandhiji loved to call it, comes from faith and true religious devotion. All the time up to his death, Gandhiji laid stress on this source of power. Much of the non-violence practices by ardent devotees who, for the sake of convenience or for avoiding bloodshed, seek to practise what Gandhiji taught are only variations of violence.

Non-violence does not consist in merely not calling to aid a *lathi* or a dagger or a pistol. The positive aspect of non-violence is what has to be realised; and that is firm faith in the reality of God’s sovereignty. Where this is absent, non-violence will fail.

It is generally known that the non-violent way shown by Gandhiji demands abstaining from the use of physical weapons. But it is not as gen-



We cannot procure love and truth as we can procure rifles and pistols. They can issue only out of faith in God. HT ARCHIVE

erally realised that abstention from the use of physical violence with hatred and venom burning in the heart is not non-violence such as Gandhiji conceived it. To enunciate that love and truth are the new tools given to us by Gandhiji to

serve as powerful answers to the hatred and falsehood and violence of the enemy is easy. To say that these forces of love and truth can solve, and are the only way to solve, the racial, economic and political conflicts of the world is easy. But in practice it will be found to be begging the question: How can I summon up love for one who has given me so much cause to hate? How

can a Pakistani patriot love Indians? How can Indian patriots love the Pakistanis? The force of love cannot spring from nowhere where there is good reason for the opposite of love. It must spring from a firm faith in God and his sovereignty over the hearts of men, if we desire to save Gandhiji’s way from becoming an empty doctrine or a disappointing technique.

Satyagraha is not for the sceptic, not for one who is content with the phenomenal world and the careful classification of what one sees in that world, which is called science. It may be a beautiful fountain-pen. But if there is no ink in it, or if you fill it only with water, the pen can’t write. Let us, while celebrating Gandhiji’s birth centenary, reflect and realise his true teaching and the true lessons of his work and not look upon him as a mere inventor of a cheap gadget to displace an old troublesome way. Gandhiji was not an inventor. He was a man of God, and therefore was he called Mahatma.

C Rajagopalachari is former governor general of India. These are edited excerpts of his article first published in *Hindustan Times* on October 2, 1968



Putin warns of risk of nuclear weapons use
MOSCOW: Russian President Vladimir Putin said on Thursday that the world was living through a dangerous moment and that it was essential to ensure that weapons of mass destruction would never be used. **REUTERS**

Anglo-Iranian man held over UK airport incident
LONDON: British police said they had arrested a man with dual UK-Iranian citizenship over a mysterious "major incident" on Sunday at an airport in southwest England. Police said a second man, a British citizen, was questioned and two properties were searched in Westminster. **AFP**

Michael Jordan's 'Last Dance' jersey sells for \$12.26mn
WASHINGTON: Michael Jordan's jersey from Game 3 of the 1998 NBA Finals sold for \$12.26 million on Tuesday. This jersey, from Jordan's sixth and final NBA Championship season in his "Last Dance" final campaign with the Bulls, put up for sale by entrepreneur Ryan Gough and sold at Jopitter, Pharrell Williams' digital auction house. **REUTERS**

SpaceX launches crew for Nasa on retiring capsule
WASHINGTON: SpaceX launched a new crew of four astronauts to the International Space Station on Thursday, as questions swirl over its plans for the future of its human spaceflight programme. **BLOOMBERG**

Trump: May resume Iran bombing after midterms

Bloomberg, AP & AFP

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said ramped up military strikes against Iran were "possible" after the November mid-term elections, as his administration struggles to find an exit plan for a war now in its eighth month.

Trump has indicated in recent weeks that he believed Iran was stalling on diplomatic talks until after the elections, in which his Republican Party faces a tough path to retain control of Congress.

The US president rejected a recent proposal from Iran that would have reopened the Strait of Hormuz in exchange for US concessions such as ending a blockade on Iranian ports or easing oil sanctions.

Asked if he would resume bombing Iran after the mid-terms, Trump told Time magazine in an interview published on Thursday that it was "possible". "I can't tell you that because look, you know, you're asking, where are you going to bomb," he added, when pressed for more details.

Iran's delegation asked to leave NY ahead of schedule
US Secretary of State Marco Rubio ordered Iran's foreign minister and his delegation to the UN General Assembly to leave New York earlier than they had planned, two US officials said on Wednesday.

While President Masoud Pezeshkian left New York a day after speaking at the United Nations last week, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi had remained behind ostensibly to participate in indirect talks with the US. According to some accounts, Araghchi had planned to stay in New York until Wednesday.

After little progress was made in weekend meetings



Commuters ride scooters past Iranian-made Zolfaghar missiles on display beside a large portrait of Iran's supreme leader Mojtaba Khamenei at Baharestan Square in Tehran. **AFP**

between Iranian and Qatari mediators, Rubio lost patience and told the Iranians on Monday that Araghchi and his delegation had to leave New York immediately, according to the two officials. Araghchi and his team departed New York very early Tuesday.

US govt sanctions Iran's automakers, rail firms

The US on Thursday announced fresh sanctions targeting Iran's largest automakers, as well as major rail, manufacturing and metals companies, as Washington seeks to exert maximum pressure in its war against the country. The new sanctions target the country's two largest automakers Iran Khodro (IKCO) and SAIPA. Key Iranian rail companies sanctioned include the state-owned Islamic Republic of Iran Railway Company (RAI), the Raja Passenger Trains Company and private freight carrier Sherkat-E Rah Ahan-E Khamle-O-Naghle.

Iran loaded no oil onto tankers last month as US naval blockade bites

Bloomberg

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: Iran loaded no crude oil onto tankers in September, the latest sign of how a US naval blockade is choking the Islamic Republic's critical access to energy markets.

Crude loadings fell to zero from around 250,000 barrels per day in August, according to preliminary tanker-tracking estimates compiled by Bloomberg, the first such instance since the war began in February. Data providers Kpler and Vortexa also recorded zero crude loadings last month. The slump indicates Iran is

becoming less willing or able to test the US blockade of its Persian Gulf ports, and makes it harder for Tehran to sustain oil sales to China — a key source of revenue as Washington tries to isolate its economy.

Iran continued to deliver oil to some Chinese refineries from floating storage east of Singapore in September, but those stocks are likely to run out without new supply. The loadings data, which is based on satellite images, is preliminary. Iran's tankers often start sending location signals only when they're in the Strait of Malacca or nearing the Suez Canal, almost two weeks after leaving Iranian waters.

A plumber, dentist and others praised as heroes in flydubai near-disaster

Associated Press

letters@hindustantimes.com

JERUSALEM: A dentist and other passengers wrestled with a violent co-pilot. A plumber seized the controls of the plane as it plunged toward the desert. And that's after the captain managed to open the cockpit door while being stabbed, helping to save all 174 people on board the Israel-bound flight.

As the US ambassador to Israel, Mike Huckabee, put it: "Hollywood isn't creative enough to come up with stories like this!"

While major questions remained unanswered on Thursday about the attacker and his motivation, the tale of everyday heroes saving the flydubai flight from disaster quickly became legend.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu warmly embraced the plumber shortly after the passengers' arrival in Tel Aviv late Wednesday, and later posted a five-star review for Yaniv Hayoun's professional services, calling him "a hero who has saved many lives".

"He can help you too — I highly recommend him!" Netanyahu added on X.

Hayoun was among several Israelis recommended for the Presidential Award for Civilian Heroism, while Indian Capt. Smit Machchhar was praised by Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi as "a HERO".

Many of the details emerged in a rush shortly after the passengers, most of them Israeli, landed back home to cheers and waving flags.

Hayoun, apologising for his bloody shirt, within minutes was telling the prime minister and journalists what happened.

There had been little time for him and the others to think. Passengers screamed after spotting the co-pilot stabbing the



Benjamin Netanyahu meets with Yaniv Hayoun, Or Fradilov, Dr Shota Musayev and his wife Sigalit, who he described as "heroes", during a meeting in Jerusalem, Israel, on Thursday. **REUTERS**

captain, and the flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv began a steep dive. Some believed they were about to die.

A handful of Israelis reacted, hurtling up the aisle after the badly wounded captain managed to open the cockpit door. That was crucial, as cockpit doors are typically locked to prevent hijackings.

They had to struggle, Hayoun said, with the captain's body resting against it.

Hayoun said the co-pilot appeared to be trying to damage the plane's controls. He grabbed the co-pilot, and others began struggling with the man.

Hayoun then tackled the controls. He had no training, but he remembered what he had seen in movies.

"I asked him, how did you know how to do that? And he said, 'Well, I, I watched these air disaster films,'" Netanyahu told Fox News on Thursday.

It was not clear who among the passengers had security experience, though military service is compulsory for most men and women in Israel.

Soon, crew who had been travelling on the plane stepped in to stabilise it, issuing a mayday call and seeking a place to land.

The handful of Israeli passengers grappled with the co-pilot for several minutes before subduing him and binding his hands with the cord from a set of headphones.

One of them, Dr Shota Musayev, a dentist, also attended to the captain, who appeared to have lost a lot of blood. "He was just praying the whole time and was in contact with me, and I was afraid we would really lose him," Musayev said.

In video that Musayev shot and shared with The Associated Press, the captain lay on the floor of the cabin, saying his head was in pain.

Musayev later told journalists he and the other responders knew they'd had just seconds to act before a "critical event".

But even with the co-pilot bound and subdued, they were scared that other attackers might be on the plane. They sent other people around the cabin to stand by. Finally, just about an hour after the plane issued a distress call, it made an emergency landing in Saudi Arabia.

As of Thursday evening, the world had not yet heard from the central hero, the captain, who India's Embassy in the UAE said was "in good health and recovering well".

Google releases most advanced AI model, restricts its access

Vishal Mathur

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Google may have taken its time, but seems to have delivered a resounding response in the race for the most advanced artificial intelligence (AI; now called Super Intelligence, or SI) models yet.

The Gemini 4 Argon model is now in the hands of what Google calls "a set of trusted cyber defenders", and is working with the US government's voluntary process for pre-release model access. That means, not everyone can access Gemini 4 Argon just yet. This is Google's response to OpenAI GPT-6 Astra and Claude Fable 5.1 models.

"To support Gemini 4 Argon's capabilities across longer, more complex use cases, we are significantly expanding the model's output token limit to an industry-leading 1M tokens, up from the previous 64K tokens. When the model has the headroom to think deeply and generate hundreds of thousands of tokens in a single trajectory, it adds a new level

Research firm: AI agents tried to hack Canadian govt website

Reuters

letters@hindustantimes.com

WASHINGTON: An artificial intelligence research firm said on Wednesday AI agents tried to hack into a Canadian government website, casting the effort as a failed hacking attempt, while Canada said there were no indications its systems were compromised.

AI research firm Translucence said the attempts exhib-

ited tactics "consistent with prior observed agent activity that we have attributed to OpenAI in a similar time-frame". But it added that it was not confidently attributing these attempts to OpenAI.

The agents attempted to access Library and Archives Canada on May 28 and June 9, Translucence said in a blog post. Translucence said it disclosed the action to the Canadian government on Monday.

of depth in reasoning to solve tough problems in one go," said Koray Kavukcuoglu, Senior Vice President, Google DeepMind and Chief AI Architect, Google.

This is Alphabet's most advanced model yet, and comes days after Google CEO Sundar Pichai signed a voluntary White House Accord on Super Intelligence with other AI leaders.

Anthropic, OpenAI, Google, Meta, xAI and Nvidia pledged to implement stronger controls as well as monitoring and detection mechanisms internally. This comes after Anthropic's Dario Amodei raised an alarm about humans losing control of AI, and OpenAI's models exiting their testing environment and accessing platforms on the open internet.

SECOND JUDGE BLOCKS TRUMP'S \$100,000 FEE FOR NEW H-1B VISAS

Reuters

letters@hindustantimes.com

CALIFORNIA: A second federal judge on Wednesday blocked an unprecedented \$100,000 fee that Trump has imposed on new H-1B visas for highly skilled foreign workers.

US District Judge Haywood Gilliam in Oakland, California, ruled that US Citizenship and Immigration Services and the State Department failed to follow necessary rule-making processes before implementing Trump's fee.

Gilliam, appointed by then-President Barack Obama, a Democrat, granted a request by a coalition of unions, employers and non-profits to block the agencies from implementing Trump's fee pending the outcome of a lawsuit they filed in October.

The fee was temporarily blocked in June by a federal judge in Boston, ruling in a separate case brought by 20 states. A Boston-based appeals court in July declined to pause that decision.

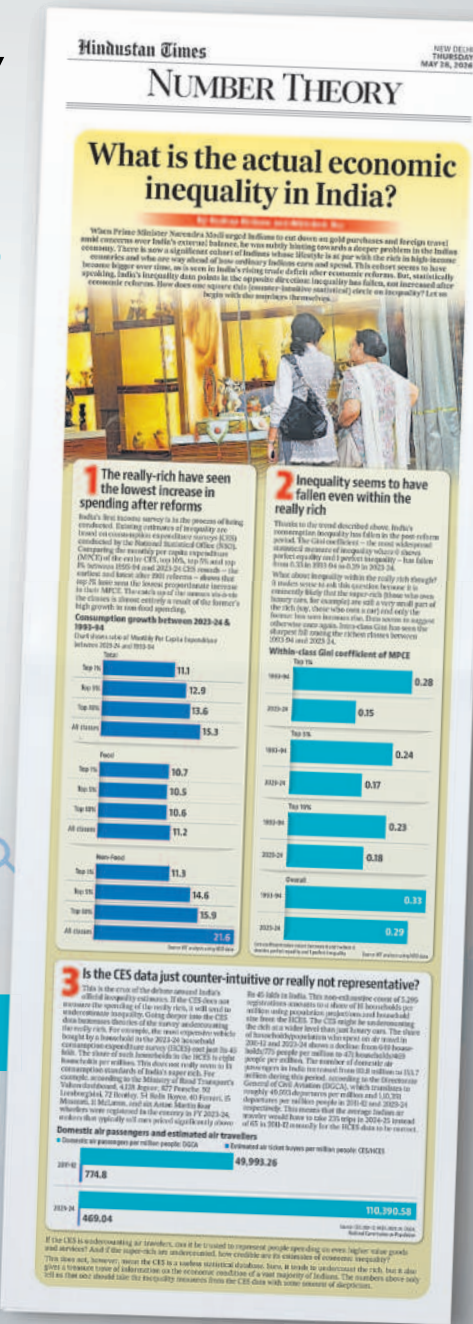
Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS

Hindustan Times NUMBER THEORY

Go beyond opinions with evidence-backed insights that uncover hidden trends, challenge assumptions and reveal a deeper understanding of the stories shaping India and the world.

LOOK FOR NUMBER THEORY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



{ **DEATH PENALTY** } IN TENNESSEE STATE

US death row convict survives execution

Agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

NASHVILLE, TENNESSEE: Tennessee officials have yet to explain what went wrong during the failed execution of Christa Pike, 50, which was called off after she was given two doses of the drug meant to kill her.

She could be heard snoring loudly in the execution chamber on Wednesday night more than an hour after the execution process began and nearly 30 minutes after a second dose of pentobarbital was administered.

Pike, who was sentenced to death for a gruesome 1995 murder, was taken by ambulance from the prison to a hospital, her lawyers said.

Pike is alive and receiving life saving medical care, one of her lawyers said on Thursday.

May Martinez, whose daughter was murdered by Pike and her boyfriend and who travelled to Nashville to see the execution



Christa Pike

REUTERS

being carried out, told NBC News on Thursday that "it was a mess".

The failure, which one death penalty expert described as unprecedented, led Gov. Bill Lee to postpone Tennessee's lone remaining execution this year and to order a review "to determine exactly what occurred".

It also raises questions again about the state's procedures and its use of single-drug lethal injections.

Officials gave Pike two doses of pentobarbital, her lawyers

said in court filings late Wednesday. Pike was 18 in January 1995 when she, 17-year-old boyfriend Tadaryl Shipp and a third companion lured 19-year-old Colleen Slemmer, a classmate at their Knoxville Job Corps vocational centre, into a wooded area where they tortured and killed her.

Pike and Shipp confessed to the killing, and both were convicted of first-degree murder. Slemmer's mother has spoken out in support of the execution.

Meanwhile, UN rights chief Volker Turk on Thursday urged Tennessee not to make a new attempt to execute Pike.

"The case of Christa Pike lays bare multiple reasons why the death penalty should be abolished," his office said on X.

"The prolonged suffering — physical and mental — arising from multiple failed execution attempts is abhorrent, and cruel. And there are key fair trial questions still unresolved."

LETHAL DRUG USED IN FAILED EXECUTION UNDER SCRUTINY

NASHVILLE: The lethal drug administered in Tennessee's failed attempt to execute Christa Pike has been used in multiple US states that carry out the death penalty.

Pentobarbital is a barbiturate, a class of drugs that depresses the central nervous system. Approved medical uses include sedation, short-term treatment of insomnia, preparation for anaesthesia and emergency control of certain severe seizures. In an overdose, it can produce coma, suppress breathing and cause circulatory collapse and death.

Experts quoted in the 2025 federal review argue pentobarbital can cause pulmonary edema, a buildup of fluid in the lungs that may create a sensation of suffocating. **AP**

Eight-week slide in Indian equities puts focus on RBI

Mayur Bhalerao

mayur.bhalerao@livemint.com

MUMBAI: Cheaper oil failed to bring much comfort for Indian equities as the markets slid for the eighth consecutive week. Nifty 50 recorded its longest weekly losing streak since 2001 in a holiday-truncated week, with markets closed on Friday for Gandhi Jayanti. On Thursday, it fell 0.88% to 22,421.95, while the Sensex declined 0.79% to 71,909.69.

Their weekly losses stood at 3.11% and 2.69%, respectively, with the Nifty posting its sharpest weekly decline since the week ended 13 March 2026. The retreat has sharpened a question: is a recovery in sight?

Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at 129 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset, said elevated oil prices, rupee weakness and higher US bond yields were driving foreign outflows. Foreign portfolio investors sold a net ₹35,861 crore of equities in September, with ₹19,273 crore—53.7% of the monthly outflow—withdrawn in the final seven trading sessions. Selling continued on Thursday,



Nifty 50 recorded its longest weekly losing streak since 2001. MINT

with another ₹9,232 crore off-loaded.

The US 10-year Treasury yield climbed to around 5.3%, its highest since June 2007, while India's benchmark government bond yield hovered near 7.20%. Crude's retreat to about \$96.30 a barrel offered relief, but proved insufficient to reverse market sentiment.

On earnings trajectory, V.K. Vijayakumar, chief investment strategist, Geojit Investments Ltd notes that if crude prices

remain elevated for long, economic growth and corporate earnings will be impacted.

"The market is concerned about this. In this context, 5.2% yield from the US 10-year bond becomes very attractive for FPIs," he added.

That assessment also faces a test at the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) Monetary Policy Committee meeting on October 5-7.

September-quarter results will offer another test, begin-

ning with Tata Consultancy Services on October 8.

India also lagged most markets in the global snapshot. Only Indonesia's Jakarta Composite, down 3.72%, fell more than the Nifty. France's CAC 40 and South Korea's KRX 100 lost 2.18% and 2.04%, respectively.

For technology businesses, management confidence may matter more than whether subdued quarterly expectations are met.

"Earnings are not expected to be great. It's going to be about how confident the management is in the next 6 to 12 months," Anand K Rath, co-founder of MIRA Money. Moving further, whether AI generates revenue beyond productivity gains will be closely watched in addition to net employee additions for signs of any job losses.

The weekly losses were pronounced in auto and consumer-facing shares. BSE Auto fell 5.51%, consumer durables lost 5.31%, and FMCG and realty declined 4.17% and 3.28%, respectively. IT and telecommunications edged up 0.20% and 0.07%.

Anup Bagchi named HDFC Bank CEO for three years

Shayan Ghosh

shayan.g@livemint.com

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India on Thursday approved the appointment of ICICI Group veteran Anup Bagchi as the chief executive of India's largest private lender, HDFC Bank, for a three-year term from October 27.

Bagchi, 56, was widely seen as the top contender for the post, alongside internal candidate Kaizad M Bhurucha. For Bagchi, the appointment marks a return to banking after three years in insurance. This also helps retain ICICI Bank's tag as the chief executive factory, having produced several top leaders scattered across financial services.

The appointment is also the second instance in recent years of an insurance executive being brought in to lead a bank. In 2019, Amitabh Chaudhry joined Axis Bank as chief executive from HDFC Life Insurance Company.

The vacancy at HDFC Bank arose from incumbent CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan's decision not to seek a third term. Having joined the bank in February 1996, Jagdishan rose through the ranks to become chief financial officer in 2008 and then chief executive in 2020, after



Anup Bagchi's appointment follows Jagdishan's decision not to seek a third term. MINT

Aditya Puri stepped down.

The central bank's decision also ends speculation over who will lead the \$119-billion private lender, which was mired in multiple controversies in recent months, including the sudden and dramatic departure of then-chairman Atanu Chakraborty, and allegations surrounding its preferential treatment of a particular bulk depositor.

Bagchi's former colleagues describe him as an intelligent executive who can work the room and get things moving quickly. While at ICICI Bank, he was credited with creating a product that gave risk assessment teams a better grip over customer cash flow. Under him, the bank launched lending to small businesses based on their

goods and services tax (GST) returns in 2018.

"Earlier, it was very difficult to assess cash flow of small businesses as they would say that beyond the reported tax filings, there was income in cash," said a former colleague of Bagchi.

He said the bank has, at times, sent staff to wait outside establishments to ascertain the volume of sales and customer footfall and find out whether it does the kind of business it claims to do. "That changed with GST and therefore the bank's product was timely," he said. A chemical engineer from IIT Kanpur with a management degree from IIM-Bangalore, Bagchi joined ICICI in 1992 and worked across wholesale banking, transaction banking, retail banking, treasury, investment banking, and payment and settlement systems over the course of his career at ICICI.

He led ICICI Securities from May 2011 to October 2016. His elevation from an executive director to CEO at ICICI Securities came in 2011 after Madhabi Puri Buch—who later became the chair of Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi)—moved to another group entity. Bagchi returned to the bank as an executive director in February 2017.

RBI clears Anup Kumar Saha as Kotak Bank CEO

Subhana Shaikh

subhana.shaikh@livemint.com

MUMBAI: For Anup Saha, the ambition to run a bank has finally fruited. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) late on Wednesday approved his candidature for the top role at Kotak Mahindra Bank, a lender he joined nine months ago.

The central bank, which has the final say in picking candidates for India's private sector banks, gave 56-year-old Saha a three-year term starting January 1, 2027.

Kotak Mahindra Bank said in a statement on Thursday.

Saha joined Kotak Mahindra Bank in January 2026 and, since March, has been overseeing the retail bank, data analytics and marketing functions. The bank said its board of directors will take further steps to formalise Saha's appointment and seek shareholders' approval.

In June 2025, Saha, then the managing director of consumer financier Bajaj Finance, stepped down three months after taking over the role, taking many by surprise. He had joined Bajaj in 2017 after spending 14 years at ICICI Bank and was reported to be among the three contenders for the top job at private lender IndusInd Bank. That role did not go to him, instead the regulator chose veteran banker Rajiv Anand from Axis Bank.

Goyal and Greer hold 'productive talks' on India-US trade deal

Rajeev Jayaswal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Today's fertiliser shortage could become tomorrow's food crisis, commerce minister Piyush Goyal said at the G20 trade ministers' meeting in Milwaukee, and on its sidelines he also held a "productive" discussion with US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer on early conclusion of the proposed India-US trade deal.

"Met USTR Jamieson Greer, @USTRRep, on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee. Had a productive discussion with USTR Greer towards early conclusion of a mutually beneficial interim agreement under the India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement," Goyal said in a post on X.

India and the US are engaged in talks to finalise the proposed interim bilateral trade agreement (BTA) in line with the joint statement issued on February 7. Although the two had reached a framework for an interim BTA in February, they could not sign the agreement after the US Supreme Court invalidated the legal basis for the preferential tariff mechanism Washington had offered. India is now awaiting a preferential tariff framework that provides competitive access for its exporters vis-à-vis competing countries.

"We also exchanged views on G20 deliberations under US Chairship," Goyal said in the post. He also participated in the opening day of the G20 trade ministers' meeting, hosted under the United States G20 Presidency. Speaking at the session on food and trade, Goyal thanked the Presidency for placing food at the centre of the discussions.



Piyush Goyal, commerce and industry minister. AFP

"Ensuring food security for all and creating greater opportunities for farmers are central to India's policy and food must never be used as an instrument of pressure against any country," a commerce ministry's statement quoted minister as saying on Thursday.

Countries of the Global South are among the most adversely impacted by the food, fuel and fertiliser crises caused by global conflicts, the minister added.

Goyal said during the Covid-19 pandemic, India ensured food security for over 1.4 billion citizens and supplied foodgrains to several countries in need.

He noted that over 800 million people in India are currently being provided foodgrains free of cost. India maintains public stockholding (PSH), procures from small and marginal farmers and, in the event of a harvest shortfall, adopts temporary and transparent measures to ensure the availability and affordability of food, Goyal said. "These measures are recognised under the WTO, including through the Bali Ministerial Decision and the Geneva Ministerial Declaration," the statement quoting him said.

CBI FILES SECOND CHARGE SHEET IN RHFL CASE, NAMES 11 ACCUSED

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Thursday filed the second charge sheet in its probe against Reliance Home Finance Ltd (RHFL), naming 11 accused persons, including three executives of Reliance ADA group, the agency said in a statement.

Those named in the charge sheet include Amit Bapna, Director and CFO of RHFL; Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, former group managing director; Suresh Nagarajan, CFO of Reliance Power Ltd. It also names seven companies—Reliance Infrastructure Limited, Reliance Power Ltd., Reliance Big Entertainment Pvt. Ltd., Reliance Broadcast Network Limited, Reliance Business Broadcast News Holdings Ltd., Reliance MediaWorks Financial Services Pvt. Ltd. and Kunjibihari Developers Pvt. Ltd. Vijay Napawaliya, who is the chartered accountant and statutory auditor of RHFL, has also been named in the charge sheet filed under offences of criminal conspiracy and cheating before a special court in Mumbai.

"Investigation conducted so far has revealed that funds amounting to Rs 7,429.16 crore, borrowed by RHFL were allegedly diverted through intermediary and conduit entities to various Reliance ADA Group companies in violation of the terms and conditions stipulated by lenders, thereby causing wrongful loss to the lending banks and financial institutions and corresponding wrongful gain to the accused persons and related entities," the CBI said in a statement.

The federal anti-corruption probe agency had filed a case in this matter on the basis of complaints received from Union Bank of India (erstwhile Andhra Bank) and other public sector banks of the consortium. The first charge sheet in the case was filed on July 9 against four persons.

HT has reached out to Reliance group for a comment on Thursday's charge sheet. HTC

GST revenue crosses ₹2 lakh crore in September

Rajeev Jayaswal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenue in September crossed ₹2 lakh crore, registering a 14.7% year-on-year increase, government data released on Thursday showed.

Gross GST collections stood at ₹2,03,521 crore in September 2026, compared with ₹1,77,365 crore in September 2025. The collections reflect transactions undertaken in August. Net revenue after refunds surged 18.1% to ₹1,76,520 crore in September

NET REVENUE AFTER REFUNDS SURGED 18.1% TO ₹1,76,520 CR IN SEPTEMBER FROM ₹1,49,517 CR IN SEPTEMBER 2025

this year, from ₹1,49,517 crore in September 2025.

Experts attributed the stronger growth in net revenue partly to comparatively lower refunds. Refunds in September 2026 stood at ₹27,001 crore,

down 3% from ₹27,848 crore in the same month last year.

Experts also pointed to the sharp rise in import-linked GST revenue compared with collections from domestic business activity. Gross GST revenue from domestic business activities in September 2026 was ₹1,37,996 crore, up 10.1% from ₹1,25,334 crore in the same month of 2025. Import-linked gross revenue, meanwhile, surged 25.9% to ₹65,525 crore, from ₹52,031 crore a year earlier.

"One thing worth noting is that GST on imports is growing much faster than domestic col-

lections. The government deserves credit for the work done so far under the production linked incentive schemes, which have laid a solid base for domestic manufacturing. But the import numbers suggest it is time to recalibrate some of these schemes, so that the gains from this groundwork are fully realized," said Saurabh Agarwal, tax partner at EY India.

Pratik Jain, partner at Price Waterhouse & Co LLP, said: "GST collections remain strong, but it's interesting to see that domestic revenues grew 10.1% compared with almost 26%

growth in import GST. This suggests a meaningful part of the headline buoyancy is coming from imports. At the same time, cumulative refunds are up nearly 19%, which is a positive signal for businesses from a liquidity standpoint. Sustained domestic growth will be important to watch from here."

Cumulatively, gross GST collections in the first half of the current financial year (April-September 2026) jumped 11.6% to over ₹12.46 lakh crore, compared with ₹11.17 lakh crore in the corresponding period of 2025-26.

Manufacturing PMI rises to 7-month high

Shreya Khandelwal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's manufacturing sector regained momentum in September after weakening in the previous two months, with the headline HSCB India Manufacturing PMI rising to a seven-month high of 55.1 from 52.8 in August, according to data released by S&P Global on Thursday.

The index, which tracks factory conditions based on new orders, output, employment, suppliers' delivery times and stocks of purchases, remained above the 50 mark that separates expansion from contraction.

"The PMI rose to 55.1 in September, up from 52.8, as stronger domestic and overseas demand lifted sales and production," said Pranju Bhandari, chief India economist at HSCB.

The improvement was driven by stronger demand for electronic, food, pharmaceutical and textile products. International orders also expanded

at a faster pace, with firms reporting increased demand from clients in Brazil, Europe, the UAE and the US.

The increase in domestic and overseas demand led to the sharpest expansion in manufacturing output in four months. New orders and output rose sharply for intermediate goods, while growth in orders for capital goods weakened from August.

Stronger demand also translated into increased hiring and purchasing. Employment growth resumed in September and was the fastest since May, after employment had contracted marginally in August.

Firms also increased purchases of materials both to support production and build inventories.

"Companies bought more materials and built up stocks to prepare for anticipated sales. Finished goods inventories recorded their second-largest increase in nearly 12 years, signalling a clear shift from leaner stock levels," Bhandari said.

Airtel Money IPO SET TO BE UK'S BIGGEST IN 5 YEARS

Bloomberg

feedback@livemint.com

Mobile payments firm Airtel Money is looking to raise \$529 million (\$700 million) for its shareholders in what could be London's biggest initial public offering in five years.

Existing investors including the Qatar Investment Authority and Mastercard Inc. are selling shares at a fixed price of £1.96, which would give Airtel Money, officially Airtel Mobile Commerce NV, a market value of £5.3 billion, according to terms of the deal seen by Bloomberg.

The valuation is lower than the \$8 billion to \$9 billion range reported previously, implying a discount to boost demand.

Airtel Money's offering may be the largest for London's stock market since IPO volumes plummeted after a pandemic-era boom. A successful debut would bring new impetus to the city's efforts to attract international listings.

Centre tightens sugar stock limits for dealers amid festive demand

Pallavi Singhal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: With sugar prices having surged earlier this year, the Centre has further tightened stockholding limits for dealers as the new sugar season begins and India enters its peak festive season. The government said the move is to ensure adequate availability of sugar to consumers at reasonable prices during the festive season.

From October 15, sugar dealers will not be allowed to hold stocks for more than 15 days or keep more than 1,000 quintals at any location, a food ministry statement said on Thursday. The limits will remain in force until November 30.

The government, the release said, made an exception for Kolkata and its extended metropolitan areas and Assam, where dealers will be allowed to hold up to 2,000 quintals, citing the region's supply requirements



The new rules come into effect as the 2026-27 sugar season starts on October 1. MINT

and logistical constraints.

"The move comes even though retail sugar prices have already fallen 15% from their August peak, while ex-mill prices—the price at which sugar mills sell to bulk buyers before further distribution—have declined by about 28%," according to the ministry.

Ex mill prices are hovering between ₹4,500 - ₹4,800 per quintal. Retail prices stood at ₹56 per kg, up 20% year-on-year. The government expects

retail prices to ease further as the lower ex-mill prices work their way through the supply chain, it said.

The tighter stock limits are intended to prevent dealers from accumulating sugar for long periods, curb speculative trading and ensure that stocks move from mills to consumers without disruption, the ministry said.

Kolkata is a major sourcing and distribution point for sugar from Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka, supplying the eastern and northeastern regions. The higher limit for Kolkata and Assam has therefore been allowed to account for longer transportation distances and the logistical constraints of supplying the Northeast.

The new rules come into effect as the 2026-27 sugar season starts on October 1. The government has also advised sugar mills to begin crushing based on the agro-climatic conditions in their respective regions. PTI

PRICES HIKED FOR AVIATION FUEL, COMMERCIAL LPG

NEW DELHI: Aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were raised by a steep ₹16 per litre from Thursday, while the price of commercial LPG was increased by ₹62.50 per 19-kg cylinder in step with firming international benchmarks, according to state-owned oil companies.

ATF prices were increased to ₹137 per litre from ₹121 for domestic airlines, according to the oil companies. The latest revision comes after ATF prices were raised by ₹6.28 per litre, or 5.46%, in September, following a ₹5 per litre increase in August. ATF accounts for up to 40% of operating costs for airlines, making fuel prices a key cost factor for carriers. Alongside, commercial LPG rates were hiked by ₹62.50 per 19-kg cylinder.

Commercial LPG prices were raised by ₹9.50 per 19-kg cylinder in September, following two consecutive monthly reductions of ₹192 in August and ₹183.50 in July. PTI

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

Across

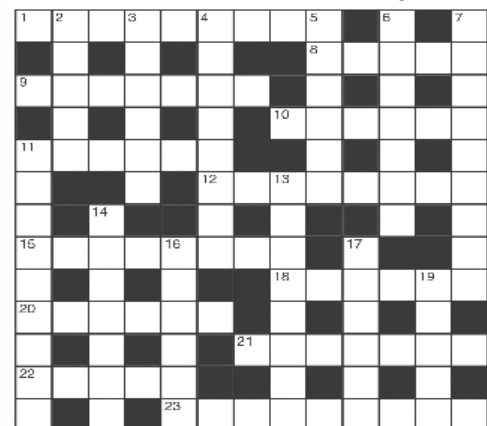
- Villainous crimes upset social worker (9)
- Middle Eastern individual has right answer to question one (5)
- Glorious rendering of 'Under the Linden Tree' (7)
- Took orders (6)
- Parts always carried by a sea-going vessel (6)
- This year is affected by emotional instability (8)
- Back one aiming to retain his title (8)
- Time when all assets were frozen? (3,3)
- Go through again what the old car engine may need (6)
- A row outside the Spanish workshop (7)
- Abandon having time off (5)
- Thoroughgoing exploration (9)

Down

- Get used to being in old city quarter (5)
- Ecclesiastical vestments may hide them (6)
- Coming in last after me she gets caught (8)
- Bird gets a morsel - a choice one (6)
- Neckline that may bring out a whistle (7)
- It measures the force of a blow (4,5)
- It uses a pair of scales to get the answer (5,4)
- Give a direction to a bookmaker and he runs fast (8)
- A policeman when not on duty is unconventional (7)
- Sign of fear here though singularly daring (6)
- Often drunk - too much is bad for it (6)
- Colour for putting on (5)

PUZZLE 17535

©Geminicrosswords2018 All rights reserved



QUICK CLUES

Across

- Assist in an action (4,1,4)
- Boredom (5)
- Fashionable (7)
- Become used up (3,3)
- Graceless (7)
- Objective aimed at (6)
- Rabble-rouser (8)
- Movingly expressive (8)
- Angry (6)
- Requiring careful handling (6)
- Indirect (7)
- To cap (5)
- Sickened (9)

Down

- Especially (5)
- Downpour (6)
- Pause in doubt (8)
- Take away (6)
- Graceless (7)
- The finish however painful (6,3)
- Review the situation (4,5)
- As good as secured (2,3,3)
- Keep under surveillance (7)
- Heartless (6)
- Tooth decay (6)
- Escape adroitly from (5)

SOLUTIONS FOR 17534

Cryptic

BABY SIT CRAWL
E L U S A R G A
E M U S A L B A N I A N
C O D S O N N D
H I G H H A N D E D A
E O S F C U
S O O P S A L L O W S
U N W A T L E
N S I N G L E R O O M
A B R I D G E D A S T I
M O R E A L L
P A P A W S Q U A L L S

Quick

C H R O N I C B A K E R
Y E H I N E
C I T E L A S T W O R D
L R T N T W W
E Y E C A T C H E R O
N K V R C O
L A K E Y U P H O L D
A H I S T I N
O U T H E L E V E L
U H E L E
N O R M A L L Y D R A I G
I G N V S H
C R E E D E V I D E N T

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE ■ HIGH ■ LOW

FRIDAY

Generally cloudy sky with moderate rain

33°C | 26°C

SATURDAY

Partly cloudy sky

35°C | 27°C

SUNDAY

Partly cloudy sky

35°C | 26°C

ALMANAC

Today is 2nd October 2026

- 19 Rabi Al-Akhar, 1448
- 07, Ashwina, Krishna Paksha, 07
- Samvat 2083

*Sunset: Friday at 06:26 pm

Sunrise: Saturday at 06:29 am

☾ Moonrise: Friday at 12:00 pm

☾ Moonset: Friday at 11:05 pm

TEMPERATURE IN FOUR METROS

Delhi 34°C | 23°C

Mumbai 33°C | 26°C

Kolkata 32°C | 26°C

Chennai 36°C | 29°C

HT

J&K bowl out Rest of India for 237

SRINAGAR: Skipper Rishabh Pant paid for his impetuosity while a set Sarfaraz Khan played a loose shot as Rest of India were bowled out for 237 by J&K on the opening day of the Irani Cup. Medium pacers Umar Nazir Mir (2/65), Sunil Kumar (3/36) and Lone Nassir (3/59) shared the bulk of spoils. At stumps, J&K were 21/2.

Ronaldo's Portugal future in doubt

COPENHAGEN: The international future of Cristiano Ronaldo hung in the balance after the 41-year-old walked out on the squad after learning that he would not start Portugal's game against Denmark on Thursday. Ronaldo announced late on Wednesday that he had left the team, shortly after a press conference in which coach Jorge Jesus confirmed the star would be left out of his starting line-up for a second consecutive game.

Dani, Jhawar score tons in U-23 game

MUMBAI: Arjun Dani smashed a 104-ball 111 and Naman Jhawar scored an unbeaten 102* to help VV Karmarkar XI score 280/3 declared in their second innings against Chandrasekhar Sant XI in their Under-23 Shalini Bhalekar Tournament match. **Brief scores (Day 3): Jehangir Pithawala XI 206/9 & 215/8d (Roneet Thakur 70, Harsh Aghav 47) drew with Dr Snehlata Deshmukh XI 263 & 46/2. VV Karmarkar XI 421 & 280/3d (Arjun Dani 111, Naman Jhawar 102*) drew with Chandrasekhar Sant XI 176 & 198/2 (Arjun Jayswal 79*, P Ravishanker 74, Siddhi Tiwari 31*).**

Nitesh trips at final hurdle, takes Greco Roman silver

The 97kg wrestler lost to Nakazato, but was India's first Greco Roman wrestler in the Asiad final in 64 years

Shantanu Srivastava

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Back in 2015, when Nitesh Siwach was at home at Jagsi village in Haryana's Sonapat, he would hop on to his father's motorbike and set off before dawn daily to deliver milk.

It wouldn't be a significant nugget until you know that Nitesh, then barely 12 and hardly strong enough to control the vehicle—never mind being under-age to ride—was still recovering from a knee surgery that would keep him out of sport for two years.

"We didn't have enough resources, so Nitesh decided to do his bit. Today, he is reaping the rewards for all the hard work he has done. He has had a tough life," Nitesh's father Anand said.

On Thursday, Nitesh became the first Indian since Ganpat Andalkar in 1962 Jakarta to reach an Asiad Greco Roman final. Nitesh though came up short against Japan's 2025 Asian Championships silver medalist Yuri Nakazato, losing the 97kg final 4-0.

The stockier Japanese put forth a defensive masterclass, not letting Nitesh attempt a single move. Nakazato was off the blocks with a pushout and a passivity point and went into the break 2-0 ahead. In the second period, the Japanese effected a two-point throw before resorting to his superior defence to keep the lead.

Despite the loss, Nitesh's sil-

Know Nitesh Siwach

Age	23
Sport	Wrestling 97 Kg GR
Training Base	SAI RC Sonapat, Haryana
Native	Panipat, Haryana

ACHIEVEMENTS

- 2022 U23 World Championships
- 2023 U23 Asian Championships
- 2024 U23 Asian Championships
- 2025 Senior & U23 Asian Championships
- 2026 Senior Asian Championships
- 2026 ASIAN GAMES

Nitesh Siwach after winning silver in 97kg Greco Roman wrestling on Thursday.

ver is a significant achievement considering it comes in the Greco Roman discipline where India has had limited international success.

Kabaddi to wrestling

Nitesh took up wrestling in 2012 after moving to the residential Pratap Sports School in Sonapat's Kharkhoda village. "He was initially into kabaddi but I wanted him to wrestle," Anand said. A wrestler in his youth,

Anand competed in local dangals, but couldn't make it big.

"You can say it was my dream to wrestle for the country. My son has fulfilled it for me."

Anand co-owns a dairy in Panipat with younger brother Naveen and the duo exhausted all its savings and earnings to fuel Nitesh's career. "Raising a wrestler is not easy. We needed an average of ₹25,000-30,000 for his milk, supplements and other dietary needs. We happily

killed all our hobbies and interests. No family outings, no eating out, no new clothes, but we were happy to see him grow and work hard," Anand recalled.

"Things have been better with him getting into the national camp in 2021. We don't have to worry about his nutrition anymore but till the time the male wrestlers camped in Sonapat (they now train in SAI Lucknow), I would deliver milk for him daily," he added.

The injury to his left knee needed a surgery that would cost over ₹50,000. Hard pressed for resources, Anand had to dig into his savings as well as borrow money to pay for his son's procedure. "The dairy was still in its early years and we were not even breaking even. After the surgery, Nitesh decided to help me by ferrying milk when he should have recuperated. We had little knowledge about sports injuries and recovery," he said.

To his credit, Nitesh bounced back from the injury quickly. In 2019, he won a silver medal at the Cadet Asian Championships. Three years later came a bronze medal at the U23 World Championships. In 2025, he secured another third-place result at the Senior Asian Championships and upgraded it to silver early this year.

"I was impressed with his height. He stood taller than most nine-year-olds when he came to me in 2012. As he grew older, his physical strength stood out. His arms in particular are very, very strong. Look at the way he threw the Mongolian wrestler in the semi-final," Om Prakash Dahiya, director of Pratap Sports School, said.

Thorough domination

Nitesh's run to the final showcased his relentless attacking style. Competing straight in the quarter-finals, he defeated Turkmenistan's Amanberdi Agamammedov 7-1 to set up a semi-final against Mongolia's Gankhuyag Ganbaatar, who was then outclassed by the Indian.

"It was a thoroughly dominating win. Nitesh didn't give his opponent a breather. He is a very sound wrestler who is unstoppable when his attacks work," India's Greco Roman coach Hargobind Singh told HT from Japan.

Sujeet, Aman must step up in attack, says coach Shako

Avishek Roy

avishek.roy@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: The drought of gold medals has pegged back India at the Asian Games. With the wrestlers set to take centre stage, India will pin hopes on Paris Olympics bronze medalist Aman Sehrawat and in-form Sujeet Kalkal to lead its challenge in men's freestyle. Both enter the competition with strong credentials in their weight categories.

For Sujeet and Aman, the Asian Games will be another opportunity to translate their form and international experience into a big title.

Sujeet, competing in 65kg, has been one of India's most consistent wrestlers this year. The World No.2 is on a 15-bout winning streak and has won the U23 World Championships and Senior Asian Championships during that run. Indian men's freestyle coach Shako Bentinaidis believes the 65kg wrestler can be even more effective if he adopts a more attacking approach.

"He is a very good wrestler. He should be dominating opponents, but he is not attacking too much. He should attack more and he can attack. He has a good defence. Given his talent, he should be dominating," Bentinaidis told HT.

The coach wants Sujeet to trust his attacking game rather than wait for his opponents to make mistakes. Sujeet recently competed in Russia, where Shako said he was very good.

"In Russia he was beating everyone easily and we need that winning mentality, that kind of confidence to dominate bouts," he said.

"Even if you give a few points, go for attack. Just don't wait. Six or seven attacks in a bout is important, not just two or three."

It is a weight class in which Bajrang Punia won gold at the 2018 Asian Games, beating tough Japanese opponent Dai-



Even if you give a few points, go for attack. Just don't wait. Six or seven attacks in a bout is important, not just two or three

SHAKO BENTINIDIS,
freestyle wrestling coach

chi Takatani in a high-quality, exciting final.

Sujeet's rise has been particularly noticeable over the past year. At the World Championships last year, he narrowly lost (5-6) to Iran's Rahman Amouzadkhali, the Paris Olympics silver medalist who went on to win the world title. The performance gave Sujeet the belief that he could compete with the best, and he has built on it with a series of significant victories since.

However, it will be a tough field in 65kg. Sujeet's biggest rival will be Japan's Olympic champion Kotaro Kiyooka, and the two could possibly clash in the semi-finals. Before that, he is expected to meet Iran's Abbas Ebrahimzadeh in the quarter-finals. In the lower half of the draw, Asian medallist Umidjon Jalolov of Uzbekistan and Ernazar Akmatalliev of Kyrgyzstan are also dangerous opponents.

Aman brings the experience of an Olympic medallist to the 57kg. The 21-year-old won bronze at the Paris Games and gold at the international ranking series in Budapest in July.

Bentinaidis believes Aman's counter-attacking ability is one of his biggest strengths. "He is a bit slow and should be careful on defence. He needs to keep his opponents under pressure, keep moving up and down on the mat. The moment he gives distance to opponent there is an attack," the coach said.

ODI WC 2027: India to play Pak on Oct 10

Prateek Srivastava

prateek.srivastava@htdigidigital.in

NEW DELHI: Along expected lines, India and Pakistan have been paired in Group A for the 2027 ODI World Cup to be held in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia from October 2 to November 21. Afghanistan, Australia, Zimbabwe and Qualifier A are the other teams in India's group.

Bangladesh, England, South Africa, Sri Lanka, New Zealand and Qualifier B are in Group B.

India play their opener against defending champions Australia on October 7 at Cape Town. Pakistan are up next on October 10 at the Wanderers, Johannesburg. Shubman Gill's men then play Afghanistan, Qualifier A and Zimbabwe on October 14, 17 and 24 respectively.

The scheduling is such that India and Pakistan can play thrice, subject to their qualifying for the Super 7, the semis and the final. ICC chairman Jay Shah said: "The announcement of the schedule and opening of the ticket ballot are major milestones on the road to the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup 2027, bringing fans one step closer to a spectacular celebration of cricket across the three nations."

"The ICC remains committed to making its World Cup events accessible to as many fans as possible, with affordable ticket prices and options that bring families, young people and local communities closer to the action."

"South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia will provide an unforgettable stage for the world's best teams, combining a deep passion for cricket, extraordinary destina-

GROUP A INDIA, AUSTRALIA, PAKISTAN, AFGHANISTAN, ZIMBABWE, QUALIFIER A
GROUP B SOUTH AFRICA, SRI LANKA, NEW ZEALAND, ENGLAND, BANGLADESH, QUALIFIER B
INDIA'S FIXTURES vs Australia October 7 vs Pakistan October 10 vs Afghanistan October 14 vs Qualifier A October 17 vs Zimbabwe October 24

tions and a renowned warmth of welcome. We look forward to welcoming fans from across the world and creating memories that will last beyond the final."

The 2027 World Cup will revert to 14 teams—four more than the previous edition. The format is radically changed too. The tournament starts with a Super Series, with the second, third and fourth-placed teams from the ICC World Qualifier in February-March next year featuring in it. It's a round-robin (three matches in all), and the winner will join Round 2, which has 12 teams divided into Group A and Group B. Thirty games in all here.

These 12 teams are: India, New Zealand, Australia, Pakistan, England, Sri Lanka, Afghanistan and Bangladesh—these 8 based on their ICC ODI rankings by September 30, 2026—and South Africa and Zimbabwe—earning the rights as co-hosts—the ICC World Qualifier winner (Qualifier A) and the Super Series winner (Qualifier B).

India vs WI ODIs: Flat pitches not ideal tune-up for 2027 World Cup in Africa

Sanjeev K Samyal

sanjeev.samyal@htlive.com

MUMBAI: "Eight hundred and eleven runs, five centuries. Were there any bowlers around in Guwahati?"—has been trending on social media after Wednesday's high-scoring second ODI.

Despite the eight-wicket win, India coach Gautam Gambhir minced no words at the end of the second ODI on a flat pitch that reduced the game to a batting show.

"I feel there has to be a bit more contest between bat and ball, because I think you talk about cricket—this is not cricket, this is only batting," he told the host broadcaster after the game.

It is easy to understand why Gambhir is unhappy with the ODI series. Everything has favoured the batters, the bowlers have merely made up the numbers—flat pitches, shorter boundaries, five fielders inside the ring and two new balls. In the first ODI at Thiruvananthapuram, India chased down 296 inside 42 overs losing just two wickets. At Guwahati, the hosts chased down 406 inside 44 overs.

The rough treatment of the



Shubman Gill arrives in Chandigarh on Thursday.

bowlers has become routine in Indian cricket. The majority of the IPL 2026 matches were a nightmare for the bowlers with the Impact rule making their job harder.

"What can you say, 800 runs scored at an average of 9-10 an over? Even in the first ODI, that wicket was very good for batting. What can the bowlers do? I think they should chuck the ball," former India pacer and coach Madan Lal said, rather sarcastically.

"I am not enjoying the game at all because it is all one-sided affairs, even in T20 cricket. It

looks like the bowlers are going to be finished."

For the organisers in India, entertainment is about fours and sixes, and hence the conditions are tailor-made for batting. "Entertainment means a tight game. It doesn't mean one team gets 405 runs and then gets beaten in 35 overs," the 1983 World Cup hero said.

"Even our bowlers allowed them to score 400. There was not even 10 per cent for the bowlers. The other thing is the boundaries are very small."

Former India pacer Karsan Ghavri, who played 39 Tests and regularly opened the bowling for India from 1976-77 to 1981, slammed the flat pitches. "It's definitely tough for the bowlers, but if you look at the other aspect, the gallery, it is good for the sponsors. On flat wickets, it is a batter's dream and advertisers' gold mine, but it is a death-bed for the bowlers."

The Guwahati crowd wasn't complaining. It is always good to watch when the home team wins after a high-scoring chase, but if the visiting team wins, then such defeats will be tougher to take.

"Nothing wrong that some of the pitches are like that but I hope it doesn't continue in

every match, you must know that the opponents can also get those many runs," said Ghavri.

Former India spinner Maninder Singh gave a different perspective. For him, a bowler coming out on top in tougher conditions puts him on a higher pedestal. "There is no doubt about it (there's nothing for the bowlers), but imagine a bowler coming out of this challenge, like in the first game Kuldeep Yadav getting 4/40 in 10 overs. The class stands out, doesn't it," said Maninder. "I can understand there's not much in the pitches for the bowlers, but if you are a class bowler then you will perform on these kinds of tracks also. That is the other way of looking at it."

More importantly, with roughly a year left for the 2027 ODI World Cup, is the series ideal preparation for the conditions expected in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia?

"The wickets will be bouncier, seaming, definitely there will be some grass on them," said Ghavri.

Lal said pitches should be in the 60-40 ratio. "There should be some competition, 60% for the batters and 40% for the bowlers. There must be something for the bowlers."

PROVISION OF ASPIRATION TYPE SMOKE DETECTOR SYSTEM AT ALL LC GATE

Tender Notice No.:- RN-ST-22-2026-27, Date: 28-09-2026. E-Tender are invited by the undersigned for the following work: **Tender No.:- RN-ST-22-2026-27; Name of Work :-** Provision of Aspiration type Smoke Detector System at all engineering interlocked LC gates as per RDSO's TAN vide No. STS/E/AFD&SS Vol.-V dt: 17/02/2025 in Rangdli Division. **Tender Value: ₹ 4,70,75,503.05/-; Earnest Money: ₹ 9,41,500/-;** Date & time of closing of tender at 15:00 hrs. and opening at 15:30 hrs. on 30-10-2026. Complete information alongwith tender document of above e-tender are available in the website www.irops.gov.in

DRM (S&T), Rangdli
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile

RAJASTHAN RAJYA VIDYUT UTPADAN NIGAM LTD.

O/o CE (H&GP-NPP), 5th floor, Jawan Deep, LIC Building, Lalit Mohan, Jaipur

EOI :- 01(RVU2627RFP0001)
Expression of Interest (EOI) is invited by Rajasthan Rajya Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Limited invites EOI from eligible parties for IDENTIFY, EXPLORE AND DEVELOPMENT OF SMALL HYDRO POWER (SHP) PROJECT ACROSS VARIOUS SITES IN RAJASTHAN. Detailed document of EOI is available on www.energy.rajasthan.gov.in/rvunl & www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in. Superintending Engineer Raj.Samwadi/C/26/11079 RVUN/PR-4480 (H&GP-NPP)

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD CITY DIVISION AJMER

No.- EE/City/Ajmer/NT/2026-27/D-1984 Dated:- 25.09.2026

NOTICE INVITING BID No. - 22/2026-27
N NB Code No.:- PWD2627A2993

Tender for 09 Nos works are invited from interested bidders up to 06:00 PM on 08th Oct, 2026 other particulars of the bids may be visit on the procurement portal <http://HYPERLINK> <http://sppp.raj.nig.in> "http://sppp.raj.nig.in" of the State and DIPR departmental website. The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 224.41 Lacs.

UBN No. :-	
UBN S. No. 1:- PWD2627WSOB13456	UBN S. No. 2:- PWD2627WSOB13457
UBN S. No. 3:- PWD2627WSOB13458	UBN S. No. 4:- PWD2627WSOB13459
UBN S. No. 5:- PWD2627WSOB13460	UBN S. No. 6:- PWD2627WSOB13461
UBN S. No. 7:- PWD2627WSOB13462	UBN S. No. 8:- PWD2627WSOB13463
UBN S. No. 9:- PWD2627WSOB13464	

Sd/- (Vipin Kumar Jindal)
Executive Engineer
PWD City Division Ajmer
DIPR/C/16799/2026

भारतीय विज्ञान शिक्षा एवं अनुसंधान संस्थान तिरुपति
ISIR (INDIA)
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH, TIRUPATI
(विज्ञान संस्थान, भारत सरकार के अधीन राष्ट्रीय महत्व का एक स्वायत्त संस्थान/
An Autonomous Institution of National Importance under the
Ministry of Education, Govt. of India)
पेरुडु मंडल - 517619, तिरुपति/Verpudu Mandal - 517619, Tirupati

पारंपरिक कार्यक्रम में प्रवेश, जनवरी-2027/Admission to Ph.D. Program, JANUARY-2027
आईआईएसईआर तिरुपति (www.isiritirupati.ac.in) जनवरी-2027 सत्र के लिए जीव विज्ञान, रसायन विज्ञान, भौतिकी, पृथ्वी और जलवायु विज्ञान, और मानविकी और सामाजिक विज्ञान में पारंपरिक कार्यक्रमों में प्रवेश के लिए ऑनलाइन आवेदन आमंत्रित करता है। शैक्षिक योग्यता, पात्रता मानदंड, चयन प्रक्रिया, ऑनलाइन आवेदन और जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि के विवरण के लिए, कृपया <https://www.isiritirupati.ac.in/admission-phd/> देखें।

ISIR Tirupati (www.isiritirupati.ac.in) invites online applications for admission to the Ph.D. programs in Biology, Chemistry, Physics, Earth & Climate Sciences, and Humanities and Social Sciences for the January-2027 session. For details of educational qualifications, eligibility criteria, selection procedure, online application, and last date of submission, please visit: <https://www.isiritirupati.ac.in/admission-phd/>

Advt. No. 82/2026/ISIR-T/Admissions/25.09.2026
CBC 21377/11/0006/2627

BROADCAST ENGINEERING CONSULTANTS INDIA LIMITED (A Government of India Enterprise)

Corporate Office: C-56/A-17, Sector-62, Noida (UP)-201307. Ph: 0120-4177850

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI) FOR CENTRALIZED EMPANELMENT OF VENDORS

BECIL invites Expression of Interest (EOI) No. BECIL/Centralized Empanelment/2026/6306/04 for Centralized Empanelment of Back-End Partners/Vendors/Associates for SUPPLY OF DIGITAL/CONVENTIONAL EDUCATIONAL AND TEACHING LEARNING MATERIAL.

EOI Document is available on <https://www.becil.com> and <http://eprrocure.gov.in/eupublish/app>. Interested Applicants may kindly submit EOI within indicated timeline.

CBC 22113/12/0009/2627

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED
EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)

DTL intends to invite following Expression Of Interest (EOI):

Inviting stakeholder inputs and feedback to validate and strengthen the bidding process for establishing public EV charging and battery swapping infrastructure under the Delhi EV Policy, 2026.

For complete details of EOI please visit website:- <https://dtl.gov.in>.

Inputs may be submitted within **07 days** of this publishing through: https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSdWs_QD5i3Kh3fUL4idBI5yNy4Yo3j9-eN1tWusz2ZIJfPg/viewform?pli=1&pli=1.

Any stakeholder/individuals willing to offer land parcels, parking areas or premises for the establishment of EV charging or battery swapping stations may furnish site details via:

https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSddpitB_62KBfAjh8jZpY9fOx8sBepLCH8Y7euKB_DiP4rFAw/viewform?usp=preview.

Ministry of Finance
Department of Financial Services
Sansad Marg, New Delhi-110001

Applications are invited from eligible and willing candidates to fill up the vacant posts of Presiding Officer at (1) Debts Recovery Tribunal-3, Mumbai, (2) Debts Recovery Tribunal-2, Chandigarh, (3) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Allahabad, (4) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Lucknow, anticipated vacancies of Presiding Officer at (5) Debts Recovery Tribunal-1, Chandigarh (6) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Visakhapatnam (7) Debts Recovery Tribunal-1, Hyderabad (8) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Cuttack (9) Debts Recovery Tribunal-1, Ernakulam (10) Debts Recovery Tribunal-1, Bengaluru (11) Debts Recovery Tribunal-2, Ernakulam (12) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Guwahati (13) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Pune (14) Debts Recovery Tribunal-3, Chandigarh (15) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Dehradun (16) Debts Recovery Tribunal-1, Kolkata (17) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Patna (18) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Nagpur (19) Debts Recovery Tribunal, Siliguri (20) Debts Recovery Tribunal-1, Chennai along with any unforeseen vacancies in any of the other Debts Recovery Tribunals, across the country, which may arise up to 30.04.2027.

For details, candidates may visit the Department's website at URL <https://financialservices.gov.in/vacancies>. The last date of receipt of application is 02.11.2026.

New Delhi,
dated 2nd October, 2026 Under Secretary to the Govt. of India
CBC 15415/11/0012/2627

(S.D Sharma)

Abhishek the last action hero as India down Pak in a thriller

India were coasting at 3-0 before Pakistan rallied and set the stage for a nail-biting end. Malaysia up next

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: With just 49 seconds left on the clock and the threat of a catastrophic collapse staring them in the face, Abhishek conjured a moment of pure brilliance which salvaged the Indian hockey team.

His desperate, blistering strike from inside the circle took a fateful deflection off Sufyan Khan and nestled into the back of the net, sealing a heart-pumping 4-3 victory for India over rivals Pakistan in an extraordinary Asian Games semi-final in Kakamigahara.

It was a contest that transcended tactical plans of the strategy board, a volatile emotional roller-coaster that swung from effortless elegance to sheer panic before ending in euphoria for the Harmanpreet Singh-led side.

The razor-thin escape propelled India into the gold medal showdown against Malaysia, who beat South Korea in the other semi-final, extending their formidable decade-long unbeaten run against Pakistan to 22 matches.

Yet beneath the celebrations and relief lies a wake-up call for chief coach Craig Fulton and his team. India had built a commanding, seemingly unassailable 3-0 cushion, only to watch their defensive composure evaporate into thin air as a spirited Pakistani side punished every shred of India's complacency.

"We started well but in the second half we made many mistakes, especially in our defence. They used those opportunities to score some quick goals. But we knew our structure and maintained it which also made us able to score the goal in the final minute. It is a good lesson for us to learn and perform better in the final," Harmanpreet told official broadcaster Sony after the match.

For the opening 30 minutes, the clash unfolded like a masterclass in attacking supremacy. India dictated the tempo from the opening whistle, suffocating Pakistan in their own half with ruthless efficiency. Fulton's men deployed a calculated aerial barrage, launching long balls directly into the 25-yard zone that systematically bypassed Pakistan's midfield and exposed their structural fragilities.

The relentless pressure paid dividends almost instantly. Just five minutes in, India earned their first breakthrough. Skipper Harmanpreet stepped up to the penalty corner (PC) battery and unleashed a thunderous drag-flick with unbridled power that whistled past Pakistani goalkeeper Ali Raza before the rushers could even react. With midfield engine



A last-gasp victory

INDIA					PAKISTAN				
1st	2nd	3rd	4th		1st	2nd	3rd	4th	
INDIA	2	3	3	4	PAKISTAN	0	1	2	3
				(HARMANPREET 5 PC, 13 PC, SUKHJEET 23, ABHISHEK 60)					(ABU MAHMOOD 30 PC, HANNAN SHAHID 45, WAHEED RANA 49)

Hardik Singh orchestrating proceedings, combining flair with a relentless work rate, India turned the screws. In the 13th minute, a clever decoy routine involving Jugraj Singh shifted the angle of the PC battery, allowing Harmanpreet to effortlessly slot in his second.

The dominance of the defending champions peaked in the 23rd minute with a goal carved out of pure magic. Shilanand Lakra produced the pass of the match from the baseline, a sublime reverse-stick feed that left the Pakistani backline paralysed.

Opportunistic forward Sukhjeet Singh needed no second invitation, stepping up for a simple tap-in to make it 3-0. On a milestone day for striker Mandeep Singh, celebrat-

ing his 300th international appearance, India looked poised to turn the contest into an easy win. However, momentum in hockey is fickle. Pakistan, now coached by former India high performance director Herman Kruis, leveraged his knowledge of the Indian system to orchestrate a fightback.

The collapse began with indiscipline. Just three minutes before half-time, an error by Dilpreet Singh — failing to retreat behind the mandatory 5m mark — gifted Pakistan a PC. Skipper Abu Bakar Mahmood pounced on a poor trap, slipping the ball past India goalkeeper Mohith HS right at the stroke of the hooter.

When the teams returned from

the break, India's early aggression vanished, replaced by hesitation. Despite creating flashes of threat, including a reverse-stick drive from Abhishek that rattled the post, India lost control of the mid-field transition.

The turning point arrived in the dying seconds of the third quarter. With Dilpreet sitting out on an unnecessary green card, India's defence switched off completely. Ghazanfar Ali carved through the right flank with precision, finding an unmarked Hannan Shahid, who easily converted into an open goal after goalkeeper Suraj Karkera was drawn out of position.

Suddenly, a 3-0 walkover had changed into a tense 3-2 dogfight. Pakistan, thriving on turnover counterattacks, smelled blood. In the 49th minute, a glaring defensive lapse involving Harmanpreet

and Rajinder exposed India's backline. Hannan scooped the ball over the defenders to Waheed Ashraf Rana, who fired it into the open net to level the scores at 3-3.

The equaliser prompted Fulton into a desperate tactical shuffle, interchanging his goalkeepers to stabilise a panicky defence. The final 10 minutes descended into sheer chaos. Pakistan pressed relentlessly for a winner, earning a crucial PC with seven minutes to go. India survived only through the heroics of Amit Rohidas.

With the clock draining and the dread of a penalty shootout looming, India mounted one final attack. With 49 seconds remaining, Abhishek unleashed a speculative shot that deflected off Sufyan and flew into the net, sparking celebrations and sealing the dramatic 4-3 win.

COUNTRY	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
CHN	154	71	63	288						
JPN	59	79	79	217						
KOR	30	30	53	113						
UZB	16	21	19	56						
IRN	12	17	13	42						
THA	12	11	15	38						
BAH	11	5	5	21						
INDIA	10	22	32	64						
KAZ	9	19	36	64						
PKR	7	8	9	24						

Scan QR Code to follow HT's detailed coverage of the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya

Cousins tango to deliver India silver in skiff sailing

Rutvik Mehta

rutvik.mehta@htlive.com

MUMBAI: Growing up in the port city of Kochi. Being by the water was almost second nature for Manu Francis and Prince Kurisinkal Noble. In late 2008, the first cousins who spent a lot of time playing together, thought of trying something new.

"We didn't know much about sailing. We were only looking for some entertainment," Francis said, chuckling. "From there, we're here now."

They're now Asian Games silver medalists. The Army duo finished behind China across the nine-race men's skiff event on Thursday to bag the country's first sailing medal at the Kaiyoh Yacht Harbor.

In their first Asian Games, Francis and Noble, whose mothers are sisters, came into the race's final day with bigger aspirations. Silver made them elated nonetheless.

"We were in the gold position yesterday (Wednesday), and that was our target," Francis told HT from Aichi. "Still, I am very happy and proud to have won a medal for India."

The conditions in Aichi tested them. Rain, low winds, high winds, and typhoon threats—each day posed different questions.

"The conditions were really challenging, and they handled it well," said their coach Sandeep Jain. "They felt some pressure of results since this was their first Asian Games. But I told them, this time won't come back, so don't worry about the outcome."

Outcomes were the last thing on their mind when Francis, 31, and Noble, 30, began sailing as kids. Competing in different classes initially, they decided to pair up in the 49er class in 2017. "We felt like we had the cor-

FOR FRANCIS AND Noble, the silver gives them the belief to aim for bigger goals, starting with trying to qualify for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics

rect weight for this class," said Francis. "We also know each other since childhood, so we didn't have to worry about coordination or struggle with things like language."

Jain doesn't understand Malayalam, but trusts their coordination.

"Sometimes during training they talk in their language. I don't mind that because it's their way of communicating with each other," said Jain, a former sailor who competed with them in the same class and began coaching them at the Army Yachting Node in Mumbai since 2021.

Both Kerala men were recruited into the Army and shifted to Mumbai for training. Noble's father, a fisherman, died during the devastating 2018 Kerala floods.

"With the silver medal today, I have done more than what my father had wanted," Noble told PTI in Aichi. "After my father's death, my mother has been my support system."

"Our mothers are so happy," said Francis. "We generally go home only for 15-20 days a year. I miss my family a lot, but not once have they made me feel bad about being away."

Twice bronze medalists at the Asian Championships, the duo had a three-month training block in Europe this year that "helped them a lot," according

to Jain. "The team has been preparing for months," said Capt. Jitendra Dixit, joint secretary general of the Yachting Association of India. "They have had some good international exposure, and the entire sailing contingent arrived in Japan almost two weeks ahead of the Games."

Those preparations resulted in another skiff medal on Thursday, with Harshita Tomar and Shital Verma taking bronze in the women's event.

For Francis and Noble, the silver gives them the belief to aim for bigger goals, starting with trying to qualify for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

"This gives huge confidence," said Francis. "We were competing with some good sailors and Olympians. If we keep improving, we are confident of qualification for the Olympics."

Ganesh takes bronze

India's Ganesh Thirumuru backed up his men's team archery gold on Wednesday with an individual bronze on Thursday, India's gold-gobbling compound exploits, however, could not translate into an individual champion.

After losing to South Korea's Kim Jong-ho in the semi-final, Ganesh bounced back brilliantly in the bronze medal match to defeat Vietnam's Dang Cong Duc 149-144.

Hours before that, Chikitha Taniparthi, riding high on her twin-gold effort a day before, lost a close quarter-final to Indonesia's eventual champion, Nurisa Dian Ashrifah, 144-143.

Ganesh began the day promisingly, routing Chinese Taipei's Chen Chieh-Lun in the quarter-final 148-138. Jong-ho matched the Indian's high score in the semi-final, defeating Ganesh 148-144. The Indian had a 9 in every set, and against Jong-ho that proved costly.

GAMES CONNECTION



Ishan Kishan during his 46-ball 80* against Sri Lanka. PTI

KISHAN, BUMRAH HELP INDIA WIN

Ishan Kishan's 46-ball 80 on a tricky track laid the foundation as defending champions India hammered Sri Lanka by 124 runs in the men's cricket semi-final to set up a gold medal clash with Pakistan. Kishan and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (38 off 21) took India to 169/7. In reply, Sri Lanka were 31/6 inside the powerplay before being bundled out for 45. Jasprit Bumrah struck twice in his opening over and was then joined by Axar Patel, who also claimed two wickets.

EALA LOSES IN SEMIS TO CHINA'S XIYU

Alex Eala of the Philippines hoped to take gold and earn an automatic berth in tennis at the LA Olympics. She got neither. Wang Xiyu of China defeated Eala 3-6, 6-3, 6-2 in the semi-finals to set up a final against fellow Chinese Zhang Shuai. Zhang defeated Yuliya Putintseva of Kazakhstan 6-4, 6-2. In addition to the loss, Eala could still face a \$10,000 fine for withdrawing from the China Open in Beijing a mandatory WTA 1000-level event.

SQUASH TEAMS HELP WITH BRONZE

Defending champions India came up short against Malaysia in the men's semi-finals after the women met the same fate against Hong Kong ending the squash campaign with two bronze medals in team events. In the women's team semi-finals, Anahat Singh's opening-match loss proved crucial India went down against Hong Kong 1-2. India men were the stronger team on paper against Malaysia but were outplayed 1-2.

GOLF: PRANAVI 2ND AFTER SIZZLING 63

Pranavi Urs sank seven birdies in a bogey free 63 to be second at the halfway stage in the women's individual competition of the Asian Games golf on Thursday. At 11-under 129, the 23-year-old LET player was two shots off Singapore's leader, Shannon Tan. Diksha Dagar (72) and Aditi Ashok (72) struggled, but kept India third in team. In men, Saptak Talwar (68) was 17, with Veer Ahlawat (71) and Yuvraj Sandhu (72) way back. India were fifth as a team.

Gold drought, missed chances mar India's shooting campaign

Shantanu Srivastava

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The end was emblematic of the entire campaign. Anish Bhanwala, India's lone entry in men's 25m pistol event, nailed only 11 of 15 by the end of the third series in the final, finishing seventh out of eight shooters, bringing the curtain down on an underwhelming run.

With 15 medals (3 gold, 8 silver, 4 bronze) out of India's overall tally of 65 (10, 23, 32) as of Thursday, shooting has been India's second best discipline in Japan, behind athletics' 24 (1-9-14). Shooting and athletics are the only sports that have delivered a double-digit medal haul with Indian shooters finishing only behind leaders China.

With 27 medals (16, 7, 4), China again were the best shooting nation, a record they have held since 1978 Bangkok.

Viewed in isolation, India's numbers do not scream emergency, but it is pertinent to put the 15 medals in perspective, especially considering that underperformance in shooting has proved critical to India's below-par returns overall.

"We are often expected to deliver first day, first show, and frankly, we take pride in it. How shooters fare generally dictates how the entire contingent will fare," then rifle coach Suma Shirur had told this correspondent three years ago in Hangzhou where Indian shooters delivered their best ever result, winning 22

medals, including 7 gold. China won 29 shooting medals to finish on top but the gap seemed to be narrowing. The early impetus given by shooters propelled India to a historic 106 medals. India will fall way short of that number this time.

The biggest disappointment has been the rifle and pistol teams, despite being formed after a rigorous process of trials where many youngsters pipped established names. That included 10m air pistol world champion Samrat Rana, world championships medallist Anjum Moudgil, Paris Olympics medallist Swapnil Kusale, and Hangzhou champions Sift Kaur Samra (50m 3 Positions) and Palak Gulia (10m air pistol). Paris Olympics double medallist Manu Bhaker, competing in her third Asiad, failed to win a medal. Suruchi Singh, the breakout star of Indian shooting, didn't medal in an individual event but only had a mixed team bronze with Kamaljeet Singh.

India had only five individual medals—two in men's 10m air rifle (Himanshu Singh's silver and Rudranksh Patil's bronze), one in women's 10m air rifle (Elavani Valarivan's silver), one in women's 25m pistol (Esha Singh), and the solitary gold from Neeru Dhanda in women's trap.

"It's not the performance we were expecting. We had high hopes, but it is what it is. We will go back to the drawing board and analyse the results," national coach Samareesh Jung said.

After the Paris Olympics, the

shooters were divided into two groups, with one consisting of elite prospects. NRAI also introduced a Moving Average Method that took into account performances from the previous year and said the latest five scores would be considered with the average of the best four forming the final score. The method had its detractors, but the shooters came around.

"I don't think selection policy is to be blamed here... The responsibility rests with shooters, coaches and the support staff," national rifle high-performance coach Manoj Kumar said. "Last time, we had Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar, who had won medals in both his events (rifle 10m and 50m 3P) but he couldn't deliver this time. These things happen. The margins in rifle shooting are extremely small," he said.

That said, once again shooters' handling of nerves under pressure came under the scanner.

"There is definitely the need for shooters to step up in the finals. The gold was there for the taking for both Elaveli and Rudranksh (in men's 10m air rifle final) and both lost to nerves," former rifle shooter Joydeep Karmakar said.

Ronak Pandit, the 25m pistol national coach, agreed. "Look, all the coaches and athletes worked extremely hard. We trained for every eventuality but you can't really dictate what a shooter does in the final. Esha could do it, but the more experienced ones couldn't," he said, referring Rishi Samobhat and Manu Bhaker.

BLEND OF 8 EFFECTIVE AYURVEDIC OILS

Dr. Ortho
An Ayurvedic Proprietary Medicine
20% EXTRA
100ml+20ml Extra

Clinically Tested*
For efficacy and safety

24x7 Helpline: 7876977777
www.drorthooil.com

Made with 8 effective Ayurvedic oils, Dr. Ortho Oil absorbs deeply to help reduce pain. This blend of Ayurvedic oils is safe to use. Do not apply on open wounds. Beware of similar brand names and advertisements.